The Essence of the Stages of the Path

The Lamp Illuminating the Essential Instructions of the Stages of the Path of the Persons of Three Scopes Based on the Outlines of the Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment

Takbhu Yongzin Yeshi Gyatso

English Translation by
Domnyershar Dadon

Edited by
Sharnon Mentor King, Geshe Lhakdor and Ven. Lobsang Dhonyo

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Geshe Gyaltsen Tsering

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Author	: Takbhu Yongzin Yeshi Gyatso
Translator	: Domnyershar Dadon
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PUBLISHER'S NOTE

The Library of Tibetan Works and Archives is pleased to be able to publish the English translation of *The Essence of the Stages of the Path,* authored by Takbhu Yongzin Yeshi Gyatso, based on the outlines of *The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment* by Je Tsongkhapa. This simple yet highly practical rendering contains the whole outline of Tsongkhapa's explicitly detailed *The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment* (*Lamrim Chenmo)* while offering brief explanations to clarify each point. *Essence of the Stages...* provides an accessible yet comprehensive English-language reference, a valuable tool for both teachers and students. It serves at once as an overview of Tsongkhapa's entire profound text, and as a map of precise links to each section of his much longer complete work. Students of the path to enlightenment will find *The Essence of the Stages of the Path* an indispensable key to their own practice. One would not want to miss the systematic roadmap laid out by the revered eleventh-century scholar and teacher Atisha in his revolutionary text *Lamp for the Path to Enlightenment*. Atisha organized the vast store of Buddhist knowledge into a single document, a clear guide for Tibetan practitioners. Master Tsongkhapa elaborated on this brilliant summary in the fifteenth century to produce his extensive, all-encompassing *Lamrim Chenmo*. These texts are a must for any serious student of Buddhism but time constraints and the breadth of material can discourage today's practitioner. *The Essence of the Stages of the Path* is the solution for such modern

spiritual enthusiasts — a book that will act as entrée and anchor to more readings and greater ease of understanding. It is for this purpose that I urged Mrs. Domnyershar Dadon to undertake this important translation. She has done a commendable job of not just translating but presenting the whole text in a much more readable and inviting form. May this publication benefit readers and practitioners in their search for peace and may it open for them the path to complete enlightenment.

Geshe Lhakdor
Director
Library of Tibetan Works and Archives, Dharamsala
1st May 2024

WORDS FROM THE TRANSLATOR

Takbhu Yongzin Yeshi Gyatso has stated in this book, "All these '*Stages of the Path'* texts concisely abridge Buddha's eighty-four thousand teachings and their commentaries."

From the eleventh-century scholar-saint Atisha, whose *Lamp for the Path of Enlightenment* reintroduced pure Buddhism into Tibet to the revered master Tsongkhapa's *The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment (Lamrim Chenmo)* which explains in detail Atisha's work, there are texts designed to be guides through the overwhelming number of Buddhist teachings. Understandably, anyone, particularly lay practitioners who are deeply serious about studying the *dharma*, would want a grasp of the entire path presented in the least time-consuming way possible. As a student myself of Buddhist philosophy, I have developed a special kind of gratitude for Takbhu Yongzin's text. It not only sets out a blueprint of the whole path and teachings of the Buddha but also makes it immensely easy to approach them.

It was my good *karma* that our director entrusted me with the job of translating this "extremely precise yet thoroughly inclusive" outline of master Tsongkhapa's *The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment* shaped by Takbhu Yongzin. Having said that, it was no easy task to just translate. Without years of advanced Buddhist scholarship, there was a point when I questioned whether I could really deliver what I had promised. However, these doubts were nothing compared to the multifaceted beauty of the work. The book is not just a

'*handbook*' for modern dharma teachers. It is also a readable and approachable '*guide book*' for those who are newly introduced to Buddhism and a '*lifelong spiritual reference*' for those who need one. While it would have been easier if I had relied only on the terminology in already translated version of the *The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment*, I chose to trust my own understanding of the terms in English as a way to ensure authenticity and remain faithful to author Takbhu Yongzin's work itself. However, given the expanse of what this summary covers – in one part a whole volume of debate is condensed to a single short paragraph – I did resort to some conventionally accepted translated terms, crucial expressions and footnotes.

The Essence of the Stages of the Path arrived in my inbox when I was just beginning to translate Buddhist works. Therefore, I owe a great debt to many people who generously pitched in to help me produce the best possible translation. My sincerest gratitude to Miss Sharnon Mentor King, my editor, for whom working on the first draft must have been truly exhausting, and to LTWA Director Geshe Lhakdor la for how subtly his editing encouraged me to take more responsibility as a translator. The book would still be a work in progress if not for Venerable Jonathan Owen who assisted in the final editing with the heart of a true *bodhisattva*. I am grateful that Geshe Thabkhe la kindly introduced me to him. Finally, I would like to thank Geshe Gyaltsen Tsering and Geshe Lobsang Tsundue, for benevolently explaining the more difficult parts of the text, and being the most indispensable reference of all.

Since this translation is designed for the broadest possible audience, everyone from beginners and the merely curious to advanced practitioners, the footnotes and the endnotes reflect an

intentional simplicity. For this, I am indebted to references such as GTSPE, the Internet, and various websites and books.

Domnyershar Dadon

INTRODUCTION

The basis of the stages of the path text

Our benevolent teacher himself, in the precious discourses on the Perfection of Wisdom, has shown the 'profound stages of the path of explicit teachings regarding emptiness' and the 'extensive teachings of the implicit stages of the path on realisation'. Through Manjushri, his principal disciple, to Nagarjuna, the lineage of profound view, and through Maitreya to Asanga, the lineage of extensive conduct existed in India. In the 11th century, when the Great Atisha visited Upper-Ngari, the ruler Lha Lama Jangchup Woe requested him to give a teaching that would help every Tibetan, high and low, mainly to tame their mind iBn stages. For that, while he was in Upper Ngari, the great sage authored the *Lamp of the Path to Enlightenment*, an essence of the complete teaching, which treated both the lineages of the extensive conduct and profound view in one text.

Based on the *Lamp of the Path to Enlightenment*, the Kadampa Masters of Tibet wrote many treatises, such as *Stages of the Teachings*[1]. Of these, the great Tsongkhapa valued highly the two; *Stages of the Teachings* by Ngog Lotsawa Loden Sherab and Dolungpa Lodoe Jungne. His own *Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment* and so forth were also composed based on the *Lamp of the Path to Enlightenment* and Dolungpa's *Stages of the Teaching.*

Hence, the meaning of 'stages of the teachings' explains the

1 Tenrim/bstan rim (Wylie format Tibetan Abbreviated as (Tib.) from here on)

teachings of realisation or the stages of the path. Je Tsongkhapa only made slight changes to the meaning of the title, *Lamp of the Path to Enlightenment,*as *Stages of the Path to Enlightenment*. Otherwise, in terms of the nature of the subject matter of the 'path', the content of the treatise is exactly the same as what was taught by early Kadampas and others and not something newly founded by Tsongkhapa. However, after his composition such as —the small, the middling, and the great stages of the path—the name 'Stages of the Path' became popular.

As explained before, this lineage of teachings on stages of the path of the Kadampas, which appear as the practice of a single person without any contradiction to all the teachings of the Buddha[2] and its commentaries in terms of the stages of the path as the subject matter, existed before Je Tsongkhapa. The Kadampas, Kagyupas, Sakyapas, and so forth are the well-known earlier lineage holders of this tradition.

These related texts, *Lamp of the Path to Enlightenment* and Dolungpa's *Stages of the Teachings,* are well known as the immediate and direct basis of these treatises on Stages of the Path to Enlightenment. However, all these 'Stages of the Path'[3] texts concisely abridge Buddha's eighty-four thousand teachings and their commentaries by the pioneers Nagarjuna, Asanga, and so on. The texts are arranged in a way that is suitable to the level of mental capacity of the three types of disciples, according to the practices of the stages of the paths. Therefore, all the teachings of the Buddha and their commentaries form the basis of the explanation of the stages of the path.

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2 Buddha with Capital 'B' refers in this book to the Siddhartha Gautama himself, the founder of the Buddhism (563 - c. 483 BCE)

3 Lamrim/lam rim (Tib.)

The subject: the path of the three types of persons

In the *sutras*, those that teach ethical discipline of abandoning ten non-virtuous acts as the causes of not taking rebirth in the lower realms and to be born in the higher rebirth of gods and humans, and even in the case of birth in the higher status, practice of generosity and so on as the cause of obtaining conditions of wellbeing like wealth, explain the path of happy migration of the small-scoped being. In between, the *sutras* that teach the four noble truths primarily for obtaining the definite goodness of liberation, explain the path of the beings of medium scope. Finally, the *sutras* of great vehicle, which teach the way to obtain the state of omniscience based on cherishing others more than oneself, explain the path of the beings of great scope. Thus, all the scriptures are included in the teaching depicting the path of the persons of the three scopes.

The way of explaining the path of persons of medium and small scope is as given in *The Sutra on Going Forth*[4], "What the Buddha spoke in the beginning in his teaching is: the discourses on generosity, ethical discipline, and higher *rebirth*" to "At the time when the Buddha saw that the fortunate ones have the potential to learn if correct and excellent teachings were given, the *buddhas*[5] gave the correct and excellent teachings. The extensive teachings thus given are; the supreme four noble truths of suffering, of origin, of cessation and of path."

Moreover, if one first mainly trains the mind thoroughly with the path of the small-scoped being and then subsequently trains in the path of the middling-scoped being, then it is easier

4 Dhege kyagyur/ sde dge bka' 'gyur (translated commentary, Dhege Publishing), Sutrapitaka /Basket of Discourse of the Buddha, sa 66 sha 3; a scripture about the Buddha's great renunciation, his life.

5 buddha with small 'b' in this text refers to the ones who have obtained buddhahood and are italicized.

to cultivate a reliable path, as is said in the remaining citation of the above-mentioned *sutra*. "For example, if a clean, dirt-free cloth is dipped in the appropriate liquid paint, it will retain the colour properly."

The purpose of teaching the paths of the persons of three scopes

One of the primary purposes of teaching the three stages of the path of the three persons , the small, middling, and great, is to mainly help us, spiritual practitioners of the beginning stages, not to try to overreach higher teachings but to first make effort in practices of the small-scoped beings, such as reducing ten non-virtuous harmful activities like killing and then gradually abandoning them and endeavouring in their opposites, such as saving others' lives, increasing the ten virtuous actions, and mainly to practice the ten virtuous deeds. In the habits of individuals like me and others like me in the important aspects of our daily lives, there is little interest in abandoning the ten non-virtuous actions, and the practicing of the ten virtues. We tend to ignore them and have not much regard. Instead, from the beginning, we pretend to make effort in higher level of practices, such as the highest *yoga-tantra*[6]. In this case, if we analyze ourselves, we will find ourselves in the risk of having none of the paths of the persons of the three scopes. What do we do then?

Depending on our own mental state, we should first put effort mainly into the practices of the persons of small scope.

6 Translated as unsurpassable yoga tantra, mahayoga, unexcelled mantra, highest union, etc., anuttarayogatantra (Skt.) rnal 'byor bla na med pa'i rgyud (Tib) is the highest exoteric practice in Tibetan Buddhism. This is a practice where mental union is the most essential part of the practice. This practice is divided into two stages: the generation stage and the completion stage.

We should check how many of the ten non-virtuous deeds we commit each day, and gradually the ten non-virtuous actions will hardly occur and will automatically cultivate diligence to perform the ten virtuous deeds. Thus one should ensure and possess the confidence that one becomes successful in the practice of the persons of small scope and not be born in the lower rebirth and be born in the happy migration as a human being or a god. This is what is extremely important in the initial period for me and people like me.

Then we progress towards the practices of the persons of medium scope in order to gradually reduce afflictive emotions like attachment to oneself and those that are on our side, hatred towards others and on their sides, and so forth, which are the causes of *samsara*[7]. Likewise, if one gradually endeavours towards the practices of a persons of great scope, where one cherishes others over oneself, then one is making effort in accordance with the major scriptures on the stages of the path and hence making one's life meaningful. In short, the practice of the persons of the medium scope is mainly to enable us engage in the lack of non-existence of an independently existing I and mine, and through that to gradually reduce the extremely strong grasping for the I, pride, and so on.

The practice of the persons of great scope was taught to reduce the self-cherishing mind and broaden the mind that cherishes others instead. The ethical discipline of eliminating the ten non-virtuous actions, being the practice of persons of small scope, is meant to prevent the individual from taking rebirth in the lower realm in their next lives and is also the preliminary practice for the path of persons of medium and great scope for the paths of

7 The cyclic existence: it is the continuous cycle of rebirth as any of the six types of beings due to the actions afflicted by delusions.

liberation as well as enlightenment. We have to achieve these through many higher rebirths. It is as stated in the line from the *Entering the Middle Way*[8]; "The cause of higher rebirth is none other than ethical discipline."

Therefore, the Buddha gave the entire teachings to tame and eliminate the concept of 'I' and 'mine', the view of grasping for a self, and to cultivate cherishing of others. Those of us who have the self-grasping and self-cherishing mind rampantly intact as before without any decline are unable to do anything about it. Thus, the teachings for small scoped beings are meant for us to eliminate the non-virtuous actions of three doors that we commit to harm others for our benefit because of the self-cherishing mind.

The four great features of this teaching:

The greatness of realizing the entire teaching as non-contradictory

These texts of instructions for the stages of the path by the Kadampas[9] show that the entire canon of sutric and tantric teachings of the Buddha, which may literally have different meanings, but all of them show the path for a single person advancing gradually through the paths of the persons of three scopes. Thus, there is no contradiction about whether they are necessary for a single person's progress towards enlightenment

8 Fourth sentence of the seventh verse of the second ground of *Entering the Middle Way* by Master Chandrakirti

9 The tradition attibuted to Atisha in which all the Words (ka) of the Buddha are taken as practical instructions (dam). The Kadampa, (Tib.); tradition followed the lamrim /Stages of the Path Approach of the three levels of spiritual capacity set out by Atisha in his *Lamp for the Path of Enlightenment*.

or not. They all, in summary, guide everyone towards the path to enlightenment. Thus, these texts have the greatness of realising the entire teaching without contradiction.

Therefore, we who are making the effort to listen and contemplate the stages of the path should also know that in all the teachings of the three vehicles, including their commentaries, there is no scripture that does not eliminate one fault, such as afflictive emotions, or does not generate one quality in the persons of the three scopes. Thus, all the teachings of the Buddha are taught as being included in the branches of the path of the Great Vehicle. Hence, we should take all the scriptural teachings of the victorious one and their commentaries as a means to our own enlightenment. The *sutra*[10] also states; "Entire path is to be cultivated, and entire path is to be understood."

For example, the doctor forbidding a particular food to a sick person in the beginning and later asking him to take that food is non-contradictory to curing the sickness of that person. In the same way, some activities are forbidden in some teachings, while in others they are taught to be implemented. Also, what is affirmed in some texts is refuted in others. If we do not develop this understanding that all of these are non-contradictory in terms of being the means to enlightenment and are alike in teaching the stages of practices, then as soon as we get a superficial understanding of our chosen teachings, we run the risk of making the serious mistake of abandoning the *dharma*[11] by thinking, "Such and such scriptures are not the subject of our study."

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10 *The Eighteen Thousand-Verse Perfection of Wisdom Sutra* Tsongkhapa, *The Great Treatise of the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment* Eng. Vol.1 p. 47 (Abbreviated as GTSPE from here on)

11 The Buddha's teaching of the ultimate truth.

Hence, when Geshe Tonpa praised [12]Atisha, he said, "Knowing how to adopt the entire teaching squarely is the specialty of my teacher." So, it is imperative that we also listen to the instructions of the Kadampa teachers without any bias, saying, "This is my scripture and this is your scripture," and should ensure and understand that the Buddha's teachings and all their Indian and Tibetan commentaries will sooner or later be part of an individual's path to enlightenment, and they do not create even a slightest hindrance. It is also important that, with great respect, one should be free from partiality and stay away from the act of abandoning the *dharma*.

The greatness of seeing all the teachings as instructions

Shakyamuni, [the completely enlightened teacher, the destroyer of all delusions, the possessor of all qualities and free of all sufferings] is the non-deceiving valid individual to look for by those striving for definite goodness regarding the objects of what to abandon and what to adopt. He willingly taught the path he practised to others with great love. Thus, the teachings given by this teacher are undoubtedly the best of instructions. However, it would be difficult for the future followers to understand his thoughts by themselves, so the two great pioneers he prophesied—Nagarjuna and Asanga—composed commentaries on the *sutra*s, such as the *The Six Collection of Middle Way Reasoning* and *The Five Treatises on Spiritual Levels,* and the like. Therefore, all the teachings of the Buddha and their major commentaries are supreme instructions. As is mentioned, "the unbiased, intelligent, and good-listeners are the right vessels."[13] However, there are

12 GTSPE Eng. Vol.1p.72

13 From the first stanza of the twelfth Chapter of the *Four Hundred Verses* by Chandrakirti

followers who do not possess these features, lack enthusiasm, and are unintelligent. Afflicted by the ninth non-leisure, they do not have time to study the great treatises. Hence, they must resolve to find the intent of the teachings of the Buddha and their commentaries within texts like the *Stages of the Path*. As Gompa Rinchen Lama[14] said, "Atisha's instructions pulverised my body, speech, and mind into one seat, and now I understand all the scriptures as instructions." As it is said that if we who listen and contemplate the Kadampa treatises do not see all the teachings as 'instructions for practice,' and then by thinking that there are separate texts for 'the purpose of practice,' we will categorise the Buddha's teachings and the major commentarial treatises into two categories: 'one for teaching' and 'another for practice.' Saying that these major treatises are for broadening external knowledge, necessary only for debate, and thus seen as texts merely for hearing and learning debate, and that they are not necessary for inner practice. This happens because we have not seen the treatises as instructions. This is similar to what the great Tsongkhapa said:[15] "You being deprived of *dharma* even after much hearing is the fault of having not dawned on the textual systems as instructions."

For example, if there is an object that has to be assembled from jumbled parts by two people—one knowing how the object should look and the other clueless—should they both attempt to assemble it, one will be able to arrange it properly and the other will not. Therefore, those who do not reject even a single word of the teachings of the Buddha but take them as instructions for practice are known as the Kadampas. We should also have a

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14 GTSPE Eng. Vol.1p.51

15 Trijang Lobsang Yeshi Tenzin Gyatso: *Liberation in the Palm of Your Hand,* 'lam rim rnam grol lag bcangs' (Tib.) p. 66

clear understanding of the stages of the practices by relying on an extensive or concise, complete text of the stages of the path. When we hear and understand any topic from the teachings of the Buddha and its commentaries, we should see them as instruction from the very moment when we—or any other person—engage in the practices of the path to enlightenment. It is important that I, and everyone like me, scrupulously apply effort to see all the teachings as instructions for practice.

The greatness of easily being able to find the Buddha's intentions

The great treatises and commentaries of the teachings of the Buddha are the supreme instructions for practice. However, for those of us who have not learned the texts at all, or very little, or not properly, — if we go on to directly studying them, we will not find the meaning of the Buddhas' thought, or it will be difficult to find, requiring a long period of study.

If we rely on the quintessential instructions of the Kadampa teachers, such as the teachings on the stages of the path, one will easily realise the crucial points of how to cultivate them in one's mind and actualize the essence of the Buddha's teachings and their commentaries. Therefore, the texts on the stages of the path possess the great quality of easily ascertaining the Buddha's intentions. Thus, for those of us who are studying the stages of the path texts, being able to understand any of the essential instructions of the practice of the stages of the path means finding a meaning concordant with the great commentaries and teachings of the Buddha. When we find their meaning, we should stay close to them and stop thinking of these great treatises as unrelated to our practices.

The greatness of automatically ceasing grave wrong deeds

All the teachings of the Buddha should be understood as only methods of attaining enlightenment, directly or indirectly. Instead, if we differentiate them into greater and lesser vehicles and see some of them as means of attaining enlightenment and others as obstructions, then with that thought of superiority and inferiority, if we study some and ignore others, we are abandoning the teaching. This huge transgression of abandoning the teaching will automatically cease if we become confident in the three: understanding all the teachings in the stages of the path as non-contradictory, seeing all the teachings as instructions for practice, and easily finding the Buddha's intentions. This way, those of us who wish to better ourselves by studying the stages of the path, should also apply effort to revere and have faith in the teachings of the Buddha and their commentaries as the best instructions for practice as they similarly show the essence of the practices in the way they are taught in the stages of the path.

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The Essence of the Stages to the Path

The Lamp Illuminating the Essential Instructions of the Stages of the Path of the Persons of Three Scopes Based on the Outlines of the Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment

Namo Guru Manju Ghosha ya[16]

I bow down in respect to the All-wish-fulfilling liberator possessing glory of the ten powers,
The preeminent spiritual sons of this protector; the undefeatable Manjushri, Nagarjuna and Asanga who pioneered the supreme prophecies
To grant me auspiciousness at all times.

By paying my obeisance to Dipamkara, the treasury of instructions,
And to Tsongkhapa, the father and his spiritual son, and all their lineages,
Who spread the doctrine of the Conqueror in all the directions,
Especially to the master, through whose benevolence I received this teaching,

16 'I pay homage to the master Manjugosha', the Buddha of wisdom. He is the personification of the perfection of transcendent knowledge.

I write the Lamp Illuminating the Essence of the Profound Meaning:
Of the stages of the path of persons of three types,
For myself to become familiar with it in all lives to come,
And with the hope to benefit others with whom I share similar fortune.

There are four parts to the stages of the path to enlightenment

A.1: Showing the greatness of the author to show the authenticity of the teaching
A.2: Showing the greatness of the teaching to generate respect for the instruction
A.3: How to listen to and explain the teaching that possesses two attributes of greatness
A.4: How to guide the disciples with the actual teaching

A.1: Showing the greatness of the author[17] to show the authenticity of the teaching

This has three sections:

I. Being born in a perfect lineage
II. Acquiring the qualifications in that life
III. The contributions made for the teaching after having acquired the qualifications

I. Being born into a perfect lineage

There was a great town in the supreme land of Bengal in eastern India, in the centre of which was a marvellous palace with golden banners filled with all the riches. Kalyanachandra the king of that land had a queen named Shri Prabhavati. To them, he was born as Chandragrabha, the middle amongst the three sons they had.

17 Atisa Dipamkara Srijnana (skt.) (Abbreviated as (skt.) from here on)

II. Acquiring the qualifications in that life

This has two parts:

A. Acquiring abundant knowledge of scriptural qualities
B. Acquiring realisational qualities from proper practices

A. Acquiring abundant knowledge of scriptural qualities

Until the age of twenty-one, he studied four subjects common to Buddhist and non-Buddhist fields of study, such as grammar, logic, craft, and medicine, and became a top scholar. Especially at the age of fifteen, after listening to The *Drop of Reasoning*[18], only once he was famously known to have debated with a great non-Buddhist scholar and defeated him. After that, he received complete empowerment from Guru Rahula Gupta, and until the age of twenty-nine, he studied the Vajrayana[19] Vehicle from various accomplished teachers and became proficient in all the treatises and instructions. He was then ordained by the great holder of monastic discipline, Shilarakshita, as the abbot and studied the epistemology of the Greater and Lesser Vehicles until the age of thirty-one. Crossing the vast ocean of both Buddhist and non-Buddhist tenet systems, he unmistakably excelled in the core instructions of all the scriptural teachings.

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18 'rigs thig' (Tib.) One of the Seven Treatises on valid cognition by Dharmakirti.

19 Sanskrit term (skt.) Also, also known as Mantrayna or Tantrayna (skt.), Tantric Buddhism, and Esoteric Buddhism. These are terms that refers to the various Buddhist traditions of Tantra and "Secret Mantra", which developed in medieval India and spread to Tibet, Bhutan, and East Asia. In Tibet, Buddhist Tantra is termed Vajrayana/Diamond Vehicle.

B. Acquiring realizational qualities from proper practice

This has three sections:

i. Possessing training in special ethical discipline
ii. Possessing training in special mental stabilisation
iii. Possessing the training in special supreme wisdom

i. Possessing training in special ethical discipline

This has three sections:

a. Possessing the vow of individual liberation
b. Possessing the vow of a *bodhisattva*[20]
c. Possessing the vow of knowledge holder[21]

a. Possessing the vow of individual liberation

Having received the fully ordained vow, which is complete with all the bases of the training, he protected even one of the minor bases of the training like he would his own life. Thus he became a great elder observer of the monastic discipline, possessing the glory of celibacy.

b. Possessing the vow of a bodhisattva

He received many instructions to train in mind of enlightenment, which is rooted in compassion and loving kindness, and, in particular, by relying on Serlingpa, he trained for a long time in the supreme instruction transmitted from Maitreya to Asanga

20 A bodhisattva is the person who aspires to obtain enlightenment through cultivation of the 'mind of enlightenment' for the sake of the entire sentient beings.

21 Here Knowledge holder refers to the Vajrayana/Mantrayana or the Diamond Vehicle practitioner and thus this is the vow of the secret mantrayana.

and Manjushri to Shantideva, which generated in him the mind of enlightenment[22] that cherishes others more than oneself. Induced thoroughly by that aspirational mind, he cultivated the engaging mind, which promises to practise the extensive *bodhisattva* ways of life, from which ensues the noble conduct of training the precepts, and he ensured not to transgress the demarcation of the *bodhisattva* precepts.

c. Possessing the vow of the knowledge holder

Possessing the meditative stabilisation of the generation and completion stages, he became the chief of the yogis. He was not being heroic just for taking the vow of ethical discipline of the three precepts; but followed what had been promised and guarded it without transgressing the limits of the prohibitions. In the event of a little transgression, he would immediately purify it with their individual rituals of purification. Such is his way of living that would please the wise who understand the essence of the teachings, and we should follow suit.

ii. Possessing training in special mental stabilisation

This has two aspects:

a. Common and
b. Uncommon

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22 Mind of enlightenment 'byang chub sems' (Tib.) 'Bodhichitta' (Skt.) is the mind that aspires to obtain enlightenment for the sake of all sentient beings. There are various translations of this term in English: here are some of the most prevalent ones; the spirit of enlightenment, the awakening mind, thought of enlightenment or the altruistic aspiration to enlightenment.

a. Possessing common training in mental stabilisation

He has obtained serviceability of the mind through calm-abiding

b. Possessing the uncommon training of mental stabilisation

He has actualized a very stable generation stage.

iii. Possessing the training in special wisdom

This has two:

a. Common and
b. Uncommon

a. Possessing the training in common wisdom

This is possessing meditative stabilization of special-insight which is a union of calm-abiding and special-insight.

b. Possessing the training in the uncommon wisdom

This is actualizing the special meditative stabilisation of the completion stages.

III. The contributions made for the teaching after having acquired the qualifications

This has two parts:

A. Contributions made in India
B. Contributions made in Tibet

A. Contributions made in India

In the Palace of the Great Enlightenment at Bodh Gaya, he maintained the Buddhist teachings by defeating the wrong assertions of the *tirthikas*[23] three times. He advanced the teaching by eliminating the stains of lack of understanding, misconceptions, and doubts, even within the higher and lower Buddhist schools. All the schools also respected him as their crown jewel without bias.

B. Contributions made in Tibet

During the reign of Jangchup Woe, the ordained king and his nephew made great efforts to invite Atisha to visit upper Ngari and request that he refine the teachings of the Buddha. Thus he authored the *Lamp for the Path to Enlightenment,* which is the condensed form of all the core teachings of the sutric and tantric practices arranged in terms of stages of practice, as well as other texts, and made the teaching flourish. He spent three years in upper Ngari, nine years in Nyithang, and five more years in other parts of U-Tsang, elucidating the teachings of the *sutra* and *tantra* to the fortunate ones to revive the lost portion of Buddhist teaching. And to spread what little was left and thoroughly correct those that were contaminated by the stains of misconceptions, thus making the precious teaching free from stench. He put a stop to those professing to be yogis and pundits who did great harm to celibacy, which is the foundation of the teaching, due to their wrong understanding of the meaning of the *tantra*. Moreover, after having quelled the misperceptions

23 Tīrthika (Sanskrit: tīrthika, Pali: titthiya/ford-maker, meaning one who is attempting to cross the stream of saṃsāra) in Buddhism is a term referring to non-Buddhist.

by developing the practice of the correct teachings, his kindness pervaded every person in the Land of Snow.

A.2: Describing the greatness of the teaching to generate respect for the instruction

This has four parts:

I. The greatness of realising the whole teaching as being without contradiction,
II. The greatness of seeing all the teachings as instructions
III. The greatness of easily understanding the intention of Buddha
IV. The greatness of the automatic cessation of all the major misdeeds

I. The greatness of realising the whole teaching as without contradiction

It is to realise that everything that is taught in the teachings of Buddha is meant to enable an individual to attain *buddha*hood. Some of them are the main path, while others are various parts of the path. Therefore, all the scriptures are included within the parts of the path of the Great Vehicle that establishes *buddha*hood. There is no teaching of the Buddha that does not put an end to one fault or generate one kind of quality, for there are none in all these that are not practised by the Great Vehicle.

II. The greatness of seeing all the teachings as instructions

This instruction has shown the stages of the path in proper steps by condensing the essence of the entire scriptures and the commentaries from relying on a spiritual teacher to calm-

abiding and special-insight while explaining where to apply analytical meditation and where to use stabilising meditation. In this way, the entire teaching can be understood as instructions for practice.

III. The greatness of understanding the intention of the Buddha easily

Although the great treatises and their commentaries are the supreme sources of instructions, beginners who are not thoroughly trained will not find the intent without relying on the instruction, and even if they do, it will take a lot of time and be very difficult. Therefore, this *Lamp for the Path of Enlightenment*, easily bestows conviction on the essence of the words of the Buddha and the treatises.

VI. The greatness of automatic cessation of all the major misdeeds

Without knowing the fact that entire canon of the Buddha's teachings is to be practiced directly or indirectly, as the path to enlightenment, if some of them are taken as means to enlightenment and some taken as obstructions to enlightenment and thus seen as good or bad and proper and improper etc., then one is committing the great fault of abandoning the *dharma*. However, as and when one finds the conviction it will be stopped thus the great fault automatically ceases.

A.3 How to listen to and explain the teaching which possess two attributes of greatness

This has three parts:

I. How to listen to the teaching
II. How to impart the teachings
III. Common concluding practice

I. How to listen to the teaching

This has three parts:

A. Contemplating the benefit of listening to the teaching
B. Respecting the teaching and the teacher
C. The actual way of listening to the teaching

A. Contemplating the benefit of listening to the teaching

By listening to the teachings one knows the teachings, negates wrong deeds, abandons the meaningless and actualizes liberation and enlightenment.

B. Respecting the teaching and the teacher

With one-pointed faith, one should respect them. And without ridicule and disparagement, one should make offerings to them with whatever offerings one possesses.

C. The actual way of listening to the teaching

This has two parts:

i. Abandoning the three faults of the vessel
ii. Adhering to the six attitudes

i. Abandoning the three faults of the vessel

Even while sitting at the teachings, not listening well is like a vessel turned upside down. Though one is listening to the teaching, if it is misunderstood or if the motivation is faulty then it is similar to a contaminated vessel. Likewise even if one does not have these faults if one does not firmly retain the words or meanings and forgets whatever is heard, that is akin to a leaky vessel. Therefore, one must abandon these three faults.

ii. Adhering to the six attitudes

The six attitudes to adhere to are: considering oneself as the patient; considering the teacher as the doctor; considering the teaching as the medicine; considering the practice of the teaching as the path to recovery from illness; considering the transcendent one as the Supreme Being; and wishing for the longevity of the teachings.

a. *Considering oneself as the patient*: This is to recognise oneself as one who is always sick due to the illness of afflictive emotions like attachments, which generate intense suffering.
b. *Considering the teacher as the doctor*, when you are afflicted by a serious illness like wind or bile disorder and so forth, you would search for a skilled doctor and feel delighted when you meet one, listen to whatever he says, and serve and respect him with humility. In the same way, we should find a person who can teach, and having found one, instead of considering him a burden, we should honour him with services and obedience.
c. *Considering the teaching as the medicine*: just as a sick person would highly cherish the medicine prescribed by

the doctor, similarly one should see the importance of the instructions given by the teacher and, with many efforts, cherish them and not waste them through forgetfulness and so forth.

d. *Considering the practice of the teaching as the path to recovery from illness*: just as a sick person knows that without drinking the medicine prescribed by the physician, the illness will not go away, similarly, one will not overcome delusions like attachment without following the teachings of the spiritual teacher. Therefore, one should practise the instructions instead of counting the number of teachings received without properly putting them into practice.

e. *Considering the transcendent one as the Supreme Being*: one should see the Buddha in the teacher and generate respect.

f. *Wishing for the longevity of the teachings*: this is thinking that by listening to such teachings may the teaching of the Victor last for a long time.

II. How to impart the teachings

This has four sections:

A. Contemplating the benefit of imparting the teachings
B. Paying respect to the teacher and the teachings
C. With what kind of attitude and manner to teach
D. To whom to impart the teachings and to whom not

A. Contemplating the benefit of imparting the teachings

It is extremely beneficial to teach without looking for trivialities such as honour and material gain. This will endow one with wisdom and mindfulness. Delusions can be reduced, and evil spirits cannot easily harm such a teacher. There are innumerable benefits, including being able to follow the wishes of the Buddha.

B. Paying respect to the teacher and the teachings

While imparting the teachings of the *Perfection of Wisdom Sutra*, the Buddha himself laid the cushion for the teaching. This shows that the teachings are respected even by the enlightened beings. Therefore, we must cultivate great respect for the teachings and revere the Buddha for his qualities and benevolence.

C. With what kind of attitude and manner to teach

While giving teachings, the teacher has to look at oneself as the doctor, the teachings as medicine, and the listener as a patient. Also, one should see the transient beings as supreme personages and wish for the teachings to remain long. Having compassion for the follower, one should abandon jealousy, laziness, grief, self-fabrication, speaking ill of others, unwillingness to teach, and craving food and material gain. Seeing the merits of enlightenment for oneself and others as the means for attaining lasting happiness, one should bathe, wear clean clothes, and then sit in a clean and pleasant place. Then chant the *mantra*[24] of

24 Here, mantra refers to recital formulae or an incantation: a particular combination of sounds symbolizing and communicating the nature of a deity, which leads to purification and realization, for example, Om Mani Padme Hung. Mantra, can also mean mantrayana or vajrayana, as in the secret-mantra vehicle.

eliminating demons, and with a radiant expression, clearly speak the ascertained meanings in an organised, illustrated, logical, and well-accredited way.

D. To whom to impart the teachings and whom not to

Do not give teachings to those who have not supplicated. Even for those who have, one must check to see whether the disciples are appropriate vessels or not. If they are, one can teach even when they did not supplicate for the teaching. And as said in the *Teachings on the Ethical Discipline*, one should teach those who possess the qualities other than the twenty-six1 not to be taught to — like giving instructions to one seated while standing.

III. Common concluding practice

Virtues acquired through imparting teachings and listening to them should be dedicated earnestly to the temporary and ultimate object of aspirations. Hereby, we have finished the preliminaries of the instruction.

A.4: How to lead the disciples with the actual teaching

This has two parts:

B.1: How to Rely on the Teacher as the Root of the Stages of the Path
B.2: The stages of training the mind

B.1: How to rely on the teacher as the root of the stages of the path

This has two sections:

C.1 A little elaborated explanation to generate certainty
C.2 Brief summary of how to retain the practice

C.1: A little elaboration to generate certainty

This has six sections:

I. The qualities of a spiritual teacher
II. The qualities of the disciples
III. How the disciples rely on the teacher
IV. The benefit of relying on the spiritual teacher
V. The disadvantages of not relying on the teacher
VI. Summary of the above

I. The qualities of the spiritual teacher

The spiritual teacher that we rely on should be someone who can lead us gradually through the stages of the path — for persons of the three scopes — that eventually reach enlightenment through the path of the Great Vehicle. Such a teacher must possess six qualities related to them and four qualities related to others. The six are: excellent training in ethical discipline; training in meditative concentration where the mind is stabilised within through the practice of mindfulness and introspection; training in wisdom analysing the ultimate reality; having heard the teachings such as the *Three Baskets*; having obtained the wisdom or scriptural and logical understanding of the selflessness of phenomena; and possessing more knowledge than the disciple. The four qualities relating to others are: being skilled in teaching the stages of the path that leads the students; having a love that is fully motivated by kindness and compassion; having enthusiasm to work for the wellbeing of others; not having tried imparting

the teachings. If possible, find a teacher with the above ten qualities, and if it is difficult to come across someone so highly qualified, one should at least find a teacher who possesses half, a quarter, or one-eighth of the above qualities. This way, rely on a qualified teacher.

II. The qualities of the disciples

The disciple should possess five qualities: being unbiased, consisting of wisdom that differentiates what is right and what is wrong, being interested, being respectful of the teachings and the teacher, and relying on the teacher.

III. How the disciples rely on the teacher

The way to rely on a teacher has two parts:

A. How to mentally rely on the teacher
B. How to rely on the teacher in action

A. How to mentally rely on the teacher

This has three sections:

i. General ways of relying on the teacher
ii. Particularly generating the basic faith
iii. Being respectful out of gratitude

i. General ways of relying on the teacher

In general, a disciple should have the following nine qualities when relying on a teacher: an excellent son-like sense of sacrificing one's freedom to be completely under the control of the teacher; endearing, a diamond-like sense of consistency

in holding a bond that nobody can break; a ground-like sense of responsibility in bearing all the burdens of the teacher; a mountain-like sense of firmness to stand against all sorts of suffering; a servant of the world-like sense of appropriating all sorts of dirty work; a sense of rug-like humility in abandoning pride or great pride and holding oneself lower than the teacher; a vehicle-like sense to bear all the difficult and heavier burdens of the teacher by oneself; a dog-like sense of not getting angry when the teacher belittles or scolds one; and a boat-like sense that goes back and forth untiringly for any amount of services one provides for the teacher.

ii. Particularly generating the basic faith

It is said that one has to see the teacher as the Buddha. This way, as we would not have any thought of judging the Buddha negatively and would see his good qualities, we would lose all thought of specifically finding fault in the teacher and would train in seeing the qualities. Although the teacher may possess more good qualities, if we are more inclined towards seeing their small faults, it will work against our accomplishment. Thus, if we practise devotion by seeing even the greater faults from the perspective of positive qualities rather than negativity, it will work as a cause of accomplishment for us.

iii. Being respectful out of gratitude

We should view the teacher as the one who finds us who have been lost in cyclic existence for a long time, the one who wakes us from the deep sleep of being obstructed by ignorance, the one who saves us who are drowning in the ocean of cyclic existence, the one who directs us towards the right path away from the

wrong ones, the one who liberates us who are chained in the prison of worldly existence, the doctor when we are stricken by a chronic ailment, and the raincloud that extinguishes the all-consuming fire of desire and the like in us.

B. How to rely on the teacher in action

Offer the more plentiful and better objects to the teacher and keep the poorer and less plentiful ones for oneself. But if the teacher chooses otherwise, let it be so, for there is nothing wrong with it. However, if one offers him the poorer and less plentiful good, given that there are better goods and greater quantities to offer, then it will disrupt the bond of the relationship. Therefore, if one offers whatever is the best of one's possessions, it will become an offering to all the enlightened beings and will generate a huge amount of merit for accomplishment. One needs to apply effort to everything that pleases the teacher—such as bathing, massaging, cleaning, nursing him when he is sick, praising his qualities, not transgressing his instructions—and abandon all that displeases him.

IV. The benefit of relying on the spiritual teacher

By relying on a spiritual teacher, one approaches closer to the state of enlightenment, pleases the victorious ones, will not fall short of virtuous teachers, it will be difficult for ignorance and bad deeds to overpower us, and, by not violating the conduct of a *bodhisattva*, one will gain mindfulness, which enhances more and more of one's positive qualities and aids in the accomplishment of all future and immediate endeavours. Such services paid to the teacher will obtain manual and mental virtues, amass merits, and work for the benefit of both oneself and others.

V. The disadvantages of not relying on a teacher

Once, after having taken the person as the teacher, if one makes mistakes with reliance, one will be afflicted by illness and demons and will suffer the boundless misery of lower rebirths in similarly boundless future times. Moreover, one will not gain the positive qualities that one does not possess, and those qualities that one does possess will decline.

VI. Summary of the above

In this way, one should understand the well-known instructions of Unification With the Teacher[25] as explained above. Otherwise, one session of meditation will not get us anywhere. If one wholeheartedly wishes to pursue a spiritual practice, he or she should rely on a spiritual teacher for a long period of time. With regards to this, the great master Chekawa said, "There is fear of losing a teacher when the time comes to rely on him." Therefore, relying on the teacher without knowing the right way will only prove disadvantageous. These methods of relying on the teacher should be seen as the most essential practice, the root of the enduring goal.

C.2: A brief summary of how to retain the practice

This has two parts:

I. Actual reliance
II. Clearing wrong views

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25 Also, Guru Yoga (skt.) bla ma'i rnal 'byor (Tib.); a meditation in which, through visualization and recitation, the meditator receives the blessing of the lama/teacher and the lineage.

I. Actual reliance

This has two parts:

A. What to do during the session
B. What to do at the end of a session

A. What to do during the session

This has three sections:

i. Preliminary practices
ii. The actual practice of reliance
iii. What to do at the Finishing

i. Preliminary practices

There are six preliminary practices. First, clean the place and set out the sacred objects representing the body, speech, and mind of the Buddha. Find unpretentious offerings and display them beautifully. On a comfortable cushion, sit upright in a crossed-legged position and say a heartfelt prayer for taking refuge and cultivating the mind of enlightenment. In the space before oneself, visualise numerous fields of merit, such as the lineage teachers of extensive deeds and profound views, others like the enlightened ones, the *bodhisattvas*, supreme hearers, and solitary-realizers, and their attendants. Accumulate merit for the cultivation of the path and the elimination of obstructive hurdles by training the mental continuum with the brief 'seven-limb practice.' Without cooperative causes, the mere observation of the object of focus, although it is the direct cause, will be difficult.

Regarding the limb of prostration, the combined prostration of body, speech, and mind is described in the stanza beginning with "However many of every single one of us...", that it is not

just to a *buddha* of a certain time or place that one pays respect but to all *buddhas* of the ten directions, of the past, present, and future, and one does so through the three doors not merely by accident but with a resolute mind.

Of the respective prostration of the three doors, the prostration of the body, it is shown in the stanza saying "Of good conduct...", which explains that by visualising the victorious ones of all times and directions as if they are real and oneself manifesting as numerously as the particles of dust in all the realms, one prostrates with the power of faith to their good conduct. Mental prostration is shown in the stanza starting with "On every particle..." which says that on every single minute particle there reside a vast number of *buddhas* surrounded by their retinues of *bodhisattvas*. One should engender faith that remembers their good qualities. Prostration of speech is shown in the stanza that says "Praising them..." which describes how, in order to enumerate the endless positive qualities to praise, we should imagine having countless heads on each of our bodies we imagined manifesting and each head having countless mouths. Those mouths are imagined to have countless tongues, uttering melodies of praise. Here, the melody is the praise; its parts are the cause, which is the tongue. The ocean represents vastness.

Regarding the limb of the offering, there are two parts. The surpassable offerings are described in the stanza "Excellent flowers…" which illustrates how excellent flowers are those marvellous loose flowers found in the realms of gods and humans. The garland is made of chains of various flowers, which can be both real and artificial. The instruments are those that have strings or that are played by blowing, beating, or using the fingers. The ointment is the essence of fragrant incense. The supreme umbrella is the best among all umbrellas. The lamps

can be shiny, precious jewels, or bright and fragrant ones like butter lamps. The incense should be of mixed or singular kinds. Excellent robes are those that are supreme among clothes. The supreme perfume is the scented water offering, which includes water that can give out fragrance throughout the three thousand world systems of the universe. The fine perfumed powders are the packaged incense powder ready to burn for offering or the coloured powder used for building a variant level of a *mandala*[26] of as much height as Mount *Meru*[27]. The 'setting' should be applied to all of the above, and they should be the majority, elaborated, and varied.

Unsurpassable offerings are described in the stanza "Whatever offerings..." The surpassable offerings are the worldly offerings. Therefore, the unsurpassable offerings are the finest things created by the powerful, such as the *bodhisattvas*. The last two stanzas apply to all the above, where these two are not present. These show the object and intention of offerings and prostrations.

The part that shows the confession of the downfalls is the one verse that begins with "Desire..." Caused by the three poisons, the three doors—body, etc. being the basis—is the nature of the action that one takes. That too, either through one's own actions, causing others to commit, or rejoicing in the actions of others.

Summarising all these in general is shown by the verse "whatever is..." By reminding oneself of the defects of those non-virtuous deeds, if we regret them and resolve wholeheartedly to stop committing more of them in the future, the increasing

26 A mandala (skt.) is a symbolic picture of the universe. It can be a painting on a wall or scroll, created in coloured sands on a table, or a visualisation in the mind of a very skilled adept.

27 Also Sumeru (skt.) or Sineru Pali is the name of the central world-mountain in Buddhist cosmology.

effects of the past deeds and the commitment of future misdeeds will be discontinued.

The part on rejoicing is the stanza that reads, "The victorious ones of all the ten directions..." By remembering the virtues of the five types of people[28], one should rejoice like a poor man finding a treasure trove. The part regarding requesting to turn the wheel of teaching is the stanza that says "Those who are in the ten directions..." which is asking those who have obtained enlightenment in the ten directions in recent time and have gained unattached and uninterruptable knowledge to give teaching through manifestations of an equal number of bodies. The supplication part is the stanza that says, "In showing how to be free of sufferings..." With numerous bodies imagined, one beseeches the *buddhas* of the ten directions — who are showing the process of passing into *nirvana* — to live for as many aeons as there are tiny dust particles to show the path that helps the sentient beings in the future and grants them happiness in the present.

The part about dedication is in the stanza that says, "And by prostrating..." This talks about the virtues obtained from the six limbs mentioned above and describes how, by diligently dedicating these virtues on behalf of all sentient beings for the cause of enlightenment, they will never be exhausted. In this way, having understood the meaning of these words, if one gradually undertakes the steps without distraction, there will be immeasurable collections of merits. Here, prostration, offering, requesting, supplication, and rejoicing are the five conditions by which one accumulates merit. Confession of transgression is for

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28 The buddhas/Enlightened beings, the bodhisattvas/Beings aspiring Enlightenment, the solitary-realizers, the hearers, and the ordinary person who obtains merit through positive actions.

the purification of obstructions. Rejoicing, on the other hand, by feeling joy in one's positive deeds increases the positive actions. Dedication multiplies the positive actions that one may have accumulated, purified, and increased and sustains those results that have already matured. In short, the purpose of rejoicing is to accumulate, purify, increase, and sustain positive actions.

Then, with a clear mind, one should offer a *mandala* and repeat this prayer several times: "Bless me that I may be able to abandon all negativity — from being disrespectful to the teacher to holding the wrong view of the two selfhoods—and to easily cultivate the right view of respecting the teacher to the understanding of the reality of selflessness. May all external and internal obstructions be pacified."

ii. The actual practice of reliance

This has two parts:

a. The general practice of reliance
b. The particular practice of reliance in this case

The general practice of reliance

First, make sure one has memorised the enumerations of the subjects to be practised in their respective sequences. Then, being sure of what has been ascertained, pray several times that we will be able to follow those subjects that are to be followed and not get distracted. After that, retain the subjects ascertained to be followed with mindfulness and introspection, without missing any or overdoing them.

The particular practice of reliance in this case

First, contemplate the advantages of relying on the teacher—such as easily obtaining *buddha*hood, and the disadvantages of not relying on the teacher—such as suffering in this and future lives. Then, with repeated firm resolutions not to let the mind develop any kind of dislike for the teacher. Then, cherishing the virtues of gaining an understanding of ethical discipline, mental stabilisation, wisdom, and listening, one should continue meditating until reaching a level of faith that is completely pure. Then, until one develops wholehearted respect for the teacher, meditate on the gratitude that is bestowed now and hereafter, as mentioned in the collections of *sutra*s.

iii. What to do at the finishing

Any virtue that has been accumulated should be dedicated by means of prayer to temporary and lasting happiness by reciting prayers such as *Aspirational Prayer, Seventy Verses*, etc.

B. What to do at the end of a session

After finishing a session, one should perform activities like prostration, circumambulation, and recitation of prayers in general, and particularly look for matters related to the object in focus during the meditation. Then strive to practise the three: training the mind to retain the object of focus, observing the vows, and accumulating merits. At the same time, practise the four merits, which are the causes for easily cultivating the path of calm-abiding and special-insight: controlling the faculties, being mindful, limiting the intake of food, diligently pursuing the practise until sleep, and appropriate behaviour during sleep.

II. Clearing wrong views

Some say that when meditating on the paths, one should practise meditative stabilisation without repeated analysis of the object. Since repeated analysis with the wisdom of individual investigation is used during learning and contemplation, and since the conceptual thoughts are fixations, they obstruct the way to enlightenment. We should negate this slanderous perverse perception, practise both analytical meditation and stabilised meditation on the essential points of the practices of the scriptural teachings and their commentaries wherever they are necessary, and apply effort stepwise in the threefold practice of listening, contemplating, and familiarising.

B.2: The stages of training the mind

This has two parts:

C.1: Urging disciples to appreciate the preciousness of the life of leisure

C.2: How to take advantage of the precious life of leisure

C.1: Urging disciples to appreciate the preciousness of the life of leisure

This has three sections:

I. Recognising the life of leisure and endowment

II. Considering the preciousness of the life of leisure and endowment

III. Contemplating the difficulty of obtaining a human rebirth

I. Recognising the life of leisure and endowment

This has two parts:

A. The leisure
B. The endowments

A. The leisure

A life of leisure is free of the eight unfavourable conditions, which are: the three unfortunate realms; a long-living god; the non-existence of the Buddha's teachings; birth in remote places as barbarians; being dumb or a simpleton; and birth as someone holding wrong views of the *dharma*.

B. The endowments

This has two groups:

i. Personal endowments
ii. Impersonal endowments

i. Personal endowments

The personal endowments are: being human, being born in Central land, having all faculties intact, not having committed irreversible evil deeds, and having faith.

ii. The impersonal endowments

The impersonal endowments are: the Buddha having come, him having taught *dharma*, Buddhism having prevalence, the teaching having followers, and the teachers being compassionate for others.

II. Considering the preciousness of the life of leisure and endowments

This human rebirth of leisure and endowments can easily accomplish all the causes—such as generosity, discipline, patience, etc.—that can obtain temporary goals such as the three higher rebirths, wealth, and attendants, as well as the ultimate goal of enlightenment. This quality being present in none other than a human rebirth, one should appreciate its preciousness.

III. Contemplating the difficulty of obtaining a human rebirth

The possibility of gaining such a leisurely rebirth is such that one migrating from one miserable realm to another after death is similar in number to the dust particles of the great earth. And to be born in the higher realms from a higher realm is like a fingertip of dust particles. The chances of falling into a lower rebirth from the two higher realms are like the dust particles of the great earth, and since gaining rebirth again in the higher realms from the lower realm is like a fingertip of dust particles, it is difficult to gain such leisure from both realms.

Therefore, just as the Buddha stated that the chance one has of obtaining a human rebirth is as slight as the chance of a turtle surfacing through a yoke thrown into a vast ocean, especially to obtain a human rebirth of endowments and leisure, one has to have a foundation of excellent ethical discipline, added to by many positive deeds—such as generosity—and connecting to the next life with pure aspirational prayer. Therefore, to generate a complete wish to take full advantage of obtaining a leisurely rebirth, one must contemplate the following four facts: practising the teaching, as every sentient being only wishes to obtain

happiness and eliminate suffering, and as obtaining happiness and eliminating suffering depend only on the sacred teachings of the Buddha; The scope for practice, for there is the presence of impersonal condition of the teacher and the personal condition of a birth of leisure and endowment; The need to practise the teaching in this life, for obtaining birth as a human in many future lives is difficult; and to begin the practise now, for the time of death is uncertain.

C.2: How to take advantage of the precious life of leisure

This has two parts:

D.1 Generating confidence in the presentation of the path in general

D.2 Actual practices for taking advantage of the precious life of leisure

D.1: Generating confidence in the presentation of the path in general

This has two sections:

I. How this path of three types of persons encompasses the whole teaching

II. The reason for teaching the paths in the stages of persons of three scopes

I. How this path of three types of persons encompasses the whole teaching

The Buddha first generated the mind of enlightenment, then accumulated merit, and finally attained perfect enlightenment

only for the sake of all sentient beings. Therefore, whatever he taught was meant for the benefit of sentient beings. His aim was for sentient beings to temporarily achieve higher rebirth and, ultimately, definite goodness. All he taught regarding obtaining higher rebirth is included in the path of the actual persons of small scope or those who share the path with the persons of small scope. Regarding the two statuses of definite goodness—liberation and omniscience—all that was taught for obtaining liberation is included in the path of the persons of medium scope or those who share the path with the persons of medium scope, while all that was taught regarding the two methods of obtaining omniscience—the secret *mantrayana* great vehicle and the perfection of wisdom great vehicle—is included in the teaching of the person of great scope, for there is no teaching of Buddha that is not included in these three paths.

II. The reason for teaching the paths in the stages of persons of three scopes

This has two parts:

A. What does it mean to teach through the paths of persons of three scopes
B. Why is the path taught in such stages

A. What does it mean to teach through the path of the persons of three scopes

The respective paths are shown not just to lead persons of small scope towards worldly happiness or persons of medium scope to self-liberation but as the preliminary branches of the practices of the common path that leads to the path of persons of great scope.

B. Why is the path taught in such stages

This has two parts:

i. The actual reason
ii. The Necessity

i. The actual reason

Cultivation of the mind of enlightenment is the only gateway to the Great Vehicle. To develop the mind of enlightenment, one needs to generate the root of that mind: kindness and great compassion. For this reason, at the stage of the person of small scope, one understands the problem of being born in the lower realms. Then, at the stage of the person of medium scope, one understands that even in higher rebirths there is suffering and no peace. By relating these experiences to the rest of the sentient beings who have been our friends, one can generate kindness and compassion, from which the mind of enlightenment arises. Therefore, training in the practices common to persons of small and medium scope is the means of cultivating the true mind of enlightenment.

Similarly, during these two stages, the practices to engage in—such as going for refuge and contemplating cause and effect—are part of the seven preliminary practices that are required for the cultivation of the mind of enlightenment, like taking refuge. They can, therefore, be considered the method of generating the mind of enlightenment. After cultivating the mind of enlightenment, one trains in the six perfections and the four means of attracting disciples. One should especially train excellently in concentration, the essence of calm-abiding, and, in order to cut the rope that binds us in our clinging to the two concepts of selfhood, one should achieve special-insight, the

essence of wisdom, by ascertaining the selflessness, the meaning of emptiness, in accordance with the doctrine and by properly meditating on it. In this way, after training the mind with these common paths, one must necessarily enter the practice of *mantrayana, f*or it will complete the two accumulations. It is stated in all vehicles—and especially to enter the secret-*mantra* vehicle—that one should first meticulously perform the rituals of relying on the teacher and protect the vows taken during the receiving of initiations as per the original *tantra* with one's life. Then, one needs to practise either *yoga* with sign and *yoga* without sign as per the lower *tantra* or the generation and completion stage as per the higher *tantra*.

ii. The Necessity

It destroys the manifest pride of those who have not cultivated the mind of the person of small and medium scope but think of themselves as the person of great scope and has immense benefit to the intelligence of small, medium, and great levels.

D.2 Actual practices for taking advantage of the precious life of leisure

This has three parts:

E.1: Training the mind in the stages of the path shared with the persons of small scope

E.2: Training the mind in the stages of the path shared with the persons of medium scope

E.3: Training the mind in the stages of the path of the persons of great scope

E.1: Training the mind in the stages of the path shared with the persons of small scope

This has three parts:

F.1: The actual training of the mind of a person of small scope
F.2: The measure of the practice of the mind of a person of small scope
F.3: Eliminating misconceptions about the path

F.1: The actual training in the mind of a person of small scope

This has two parts:

G.1: Generating the mind that aspires for better future lives
G.2: The method of obtaining happiness in future lives

G.1: Generating a mind that aspires for a better future life

This has two sections:

H.1: Contemplating the inevitability of the end of the present life shortly
H.2: Contemplating the changing nature of happiness and suffering in the two realms in the future lives

H.1: Contemplating the inevitability of the end of the present life shortly

This has four parts:

I. The defect of not contemplating the inevitability of death
II. The benefit of contemplating the inevitability of death
III. The kind of mind necessary to generate contemplation of the inevitability of death
IV. How to contemplate the inevitability of death

I. The defect of not contemplating the inevitability of death

Although everyone has this feeling that ultimately we are going to die, each day we still have a defensive inner mind that says, "Not dying today, not also today", even when we are on our deathbeds. Instead of countering these feelings, we let these thoughts obscure our minds, which gives rise to the desire to live for this life. It does not allow us to analyse future lives, liberation, enlightenment, or any other bigger matter, and it, therefore, prevents the development of the thought of spiritual practice. This way, even if hundreds of acts of listening, studying, and meditation are performed, the merits accumulated from these will only serve this life. Distracted by gossip, ignorance, food, and drink, etc., one cannot carry out the proper practice and every virtuous deed will not last long. Our hope for a long life brings an immense desire for wealth and fame, and suspicion of obstruction to our acquisition of them will make one hostile. Not knowing the defects of these desires will generate ignorance, and this breeds a stream of afflictive emotions such as pride and jealousy and other extremely afflictive subsidiary delusions. Moreover, one will accumulate many negative actions, such as the ten non-virtuous deeds, the five heinous crimes, the misdeeds of abandoning the *dharma* and the like. These will drag one to intense sufferings such as rebirth in the lower realms.

II. The benefit of contemplating the inevitability of death

If one can develop a genuine contemplation of the inevitable nature of death, even if one is going to die today or tomorrow, someone with a modest knowledge of the *dharma* will see no use in clinging to loved ones or material wealth, and most of them will have a spontaneous will to make the most of this life through giving and such. There is nothing of greater value than seeing worldly concerns, such as fame and riches, as meaningless, as chaff tossed in the air, or as a source of deception, and instead engaging in positive activities like taking refuge and observing ethical discipline at all times with diligence rather than negative deeds. This way, what can be more meaningful than ridding oneself of the useless body, turning it into a genuinely significant one, and lifting oneself and other sentient beings to an excellent state? Therefore, contemplation on the inevitable nature of death is the great gateway towards eliminating all delusions and demerits of wrong deeds and achieving all positivity simultaneously.

III. The kind of mind necessary to generate contemplation of the inevitability of death

For fear of being unable to stop the causes of rebirth in the lower realms and obtain the causes of rebirth in the higher realms and definite goodness, one should fear death. Having contemplated these, since there is a way to achieve these two aims, one will know not to be afraid on the brink of death. However, if these aims are not accomplished, one cannot be liberated from cyclic existence, and, worse, one dies with a fear of being born in the lower realms. Therefore, a frequent recollection of the fact that

one is quickly parted from wealth and life or the impermanence of things helps one to counter the fear of losing life and wealth, and soon one will be free of the suffering of dying.

IV. How to contemplate the inevitability of death

This has three parts:

A. Contemplating the certainty of death
B. Contemplating the uncertainty of the time of death
C. Contemplating the fact that at the time of death, nothing but the practice of *dharma* can help

A. Contemplating the certainty of death

This has three sections:

i. Contemplating the fact that when death comes, nothing can prevent it
ii. Contemplating the fact that life cannot be extended but rather constantly diminishes
iii. Contemplating the fact that even though one is alive, one might die without being able to practise the *dharma*

i. Contemplating the fact that when death comes, nothing can prevent it

Death is inevitable for all forms of life. Wherever one lives, death comes. There is no difference in the fact that death always subdues sentient beings. There is no running away from death. It cannot be challenged by *mantra*s or prayers. As the *Kamaba*[29] has said, "although we should live with the fear of death and die

29 A great scholar and translator by the name of Kamaba (1057–1131), lay name Sherab Woeser, founder of the Kamaba monastery.

without it, contrastingly, we do not fear it now, while at the time of death, we clutch our fists to our chests in terror."

ii. Contemplating the fact that life cannot be extended but rather constantly diminishes

Life passes very quickly—years dwindle into months, months into weeks, weeks into days, and days into hours. Seen in this way, it becomes obvious that life is brief, that half of it is already spent, and that though that which remains cannot be extended, the causes for ending it are present every moment of the day and night.

iii. Contemplating the fact that even though one is alive, one might die without being able to practise the dharma

As a large part of our lives has already passed without much meaning, and of what remains, half will be spent in sleep, a good part of it will be spent eating and dressing, and part will be consumed by illness and distraction, we can suppose there are only about five years left to us that we can dedicate to spiritual practices. All the wealth that one accumulates in this life will turn into just a memory at the time of death, as if one were waking up from a pleasurable dream. But the enemy, death, comes, and we are unable to stop it. So, concluding that there is no reason to be deceived by the delusions of this life, decide to practise the *dharma* and repeatedly promise to do so.

B. Contemplating the uncertainty of the time of death

This has three sections:

a. Contemplating that life in *Jambudvipa*,2 the worldly realm is never certain
b. Contemplating the fact that the causes of life are very few while the causes of death are numerous
c. Contemplating that life is very fragile and that the time of death is never certain.

a. Contemplating that life in Jambudvipa, the worldly realm is never certain

As the longevity of beings on *Uttarakuru*,3 the northern continent of Mount *Meru,* is fixed, the duration of life on the other continents is not so, though mostly predetermined. However, lifespan in the *Jambudvipa* is never certain. In the beginning, the beings of this realm lived for countless years, and later, ten years of age would seem long enough. Even now, young or old, beings here are never certain when they will die. Therefore, one should constantly contemplate the fact that, like everyone else, one will certainly die one day within the next hundred years, starting today. Until then, there is no certainty whether or not we are going to die or if it is today or not! Nevertheless, we should incline our minds more towards the possibility of dying today. Otherwise, if we choose to believe that we are not going to die today or most probably so, we prepare ourselves to live this life, but in the middle of it, we might die with the regret that we have not prepared for the life to come. If we live each day by preparing for our departure from this life, we can accomplish many necessary deeds for our future lives, and even if we don't die right away, we will accumulate plentiful merit—and that is for the best, for if we are to die, we will need them more than anything else.

b. Contemplating the fact that the causes of life are very few while the causes of death are numerous

The life we have obtained is frequently threatened by various human and non-human evils, as well as demons. We should think of how many types of animals there are who would harm us and how often we are disturbed by the imbalances of inner and outer elements. There is no means whatsoever to extend life; every second it is diminished by various enemies, and even the causes of our survival may turn into factors of our death. We find food, shelter, and companions, but there is no telling if these things are going to become the cause of our deaths. We may perish by eating too much or too little, by houses falling, or by loved ones who betray us. Therefore, there is no life support that may not be the cause of our deaths.

c. Contemplating that life is very fragile and that the time of death is never certain

Life is so vulnerable—like a water bubble, it does not need severe harm since a simple thing such as a thorn can damage it, as can every other cause of death, to destroy life so easily. By contemplating these things, one should not feel that one has time until one's life is taken by the *Yama* (lord of death). But from this moment on, make many holy vows to engage in the *dharma* practice. Of the three contemplations, the most important is the contemplation of the uncertainty of the time of death. It is this thinking that will transform the mind, and thus we should strive to cultivate it.

C. Contemplating the fact that at the time of death, nothing but the practice of dharma can help

Seeing that we must leave this life for another, we realise that at the time of death, we cannot take with us even the dearest of friends and relatives that surround us. Whatever wonderful possessions we may have collected, we cannot take even a minute dust particle with us, for even the very bones and flesh that we were born with must be left behind. Thus, we should feel that there will certainly come a time when all the riches we have acquired must be forsaken, for we must one day leave this world for a different life—and that day could well be today! We should contemplate how, at such a time, the *dharma* is our sole refuge, protector, and defender. It is very difficult to obtain a leisurely, meaningful, and endowed life, and even when obtained, it is very easy to lose. If we cannot be mindful of death and are not able to do something virtuous for the sake of the future life but think only of obtaining happiness and eliminating suffering in this life, then animals are better than us. We should have a behaviour different from that of the animals. Otherwise, there is no point in taking a higher rebirth. Although it is hard to generate such thoughts, since this is the foundation of the path, we must put effort into this practice. If we can generate this, we will be free of all the delusions of this lifetime. Knowing that we must indubitably go to the future life alone and unaccompanied, and understanding that we should not do any un-*dharmic* deeds, we must develop a sense of detachment from this world. Until this mind is generated, the path of all *dharma* is closed to us. At the same time, if we accumulate the collections of merit, rid ourselves of ignorance, make supplications to the deities and lamas, and contemplate with perseverance, as compounded

phenomena are impermanent, we will soon obtain a realisation that we thought we might not obtain even in a hundred years.

H.2: Contemplating the changing nature of happiness and suffering in the two realms in the future lives

Since it is certain that we will soon die, there is no living leisurely in this life, as even after death, one has to take rebirth, for one will not just disappear. As there are only two options for rebirth, we will be born in either the higher or lower realms. Where we take rebirth is out of our control, for it is dependent on *karmic* accumulation, which follows in accordance with our positive and negative deeds. Therefore, it is imperative that we contemplate the sufferings we would experience if we were to be born in one of the lower realms. Contemplating being born into an ocean of suffering generates repentance and helps us reduce our pride and sense of self-importance. Suffering being the result of wrong deeds, one will refrain from committing huge transgressions. As we do not want to suffer and wish to be happy, seeing that positive deeds are the cause of happiness, we will rejoice in engaging in positive activities. In light of our own experience of suffering, we will feel pity for others, and becoming disillusioned with cyclic existence, we will generate the aspiration to be liberated. Fearing to suffer, we should ardently seek refuge. Contemplation in this way brings together the essence of many such practices.

Accordingly, there are three sufferings of the lower realm to contemplate: the suffering of hell-beings, the suffering of animals, and the suffering of hungry ghosts.

I. Contemplating the sufferings of the hell-beings

There are four sufferings of the hell beings to be contemplated:

A. The great hells of sentient beings
B. Neighbouring hell
C. The cold hell
D. The occasional hell

A. The great hells of sentient beings

The Reviving Hell is located at a depth of thirty-two thousand leagues below the surface of the earth, and the other seven hells are located below that at intervals of four thousand leagues.

In the first of the eight, the Reviving Hell, beings gather and attack each other with weapons that appear by the force of their *karma*[30]. In the Black Line Hell, guardians of hell draw the outlines of various shapes—such as squares, octagons, and pieces—on the bodies of those beings born there and carve out the flesh from within the lines. In the Crushing Hell, the beings are gathered and then crushed by the guardians of hell between two iron mountains, shaped like the heads of rams. Ceaselessly, these two mountains squeeze the prisoners, while blood flows like rivers from every opening. In the Howling Hell, the beings, searching for an abode, are put in an iron room and, upon entering, are consumed by flames. In the Great Howling Hell, the same thing occurs, but the iron room has two floors. In the Hot Hell, guardians insert white-hot iron stakes so far into the anuses of the beings that the tip exits through the top of their heads, and tongues of fire issue from their mouths and nostrils.

30 Karma is a (skt.) term that literally means "action" or "doing". In the Buddhist tradition, Karma refers to action driven by intention that leads to future consequences that is; cause and its effect or action and its result.

In the Extremely Hot Hell, a white-hot three-pronged trident is forced up through the anus, with the left and right points exiting from the shoulders and the central point exiting from the crown of the head. The tongues of the flame issue from the mouth and all the orifices. In the Hell of Excruciating Pain, there is a land that stretches for many hundreds of leagues in the four directions and burns with ever-increasing heat that gradually incinerates the skin, muscle, and bone of beings to the very marrow. Like the wick of a lamp, the whole body is engulfed in fire. It is evident from their unending suffering that they are pitiful and moaning sentient beings.

B. Neighbouring hell

The eight neighbouring hells each have four levels and four doors. They are surrounded by iron fences, each with four gates. Within each of these gates are four further hells: the Hell of fiery trenches, the Hell of the swamp of filth or mire of excrement reeking of corpses, the Hell of the road of razors, and the Hell of the unfordable great river.

C. The cold hell

Each of the eight great hells has ten thousand leagues in a breath, and beyond that lie the eight cold hells. Thirty-two thousand leagues below the earth is the Blistering hell, and two thousand leagues below are the other seven. Blistering hell is where an extremely gusty storm makes one shrink in coldness as if filled with blisters all over the body. The second is the Oozing blistering hell; the difference with the first is that in the second, the bodies shrink like they are filled with oozing blisters. The teeth chatting, the *Achu* (burr!), and the *Kyehud* (Alas!) hells

should be understood from the way they are sounded. The cracking like a blue lotus is the turning of the body into blue with five or six crakes as the gusty storm blows. The difference with Hell of Cracking like a Lotus is that the skin turns reddish, and there would be ten or more cracks. The difference with the Hell of great cracking like the lotus is that the skin turns very red, and there could be hundreds or more crakes.

D. The occasional hell

The occasional hell exists near the hot and cold hells and is also located within the world. The beings in the hot and cold hells have to face immeasurable suffering, and the possibility of us taking birth in these hell realms is intervened by just the time we have before our breathing ceases. And we should know that the cause of such suffering is our physical, mental, and verbal misconduct. So, we should be as tactful as we can to avoid being defiled by even the slightest wrongdoing.

II. Contemplating the Sufferings of the Animals

Animals suffer from the killing of the weaker by the stronger, and having become possessions of god and humans, they are either killed, beaten, or harmed without any freedom of their own. They eat each other and suffer from ignorance and stupidity. They suffer hunger, heat, and wind while hunters corner them from everywhere. Seeing the way they suffer continuously in such a fearful condition, one should feel pity and develop a mind of renunciation. Most of these live in the ocean, and the rest are found in relative places. Those with a long life could live for aeons, while the others have varied longevity.

III. Contemplating the sufferings of the hungry ghost

The third suffering is that of the hungry ghosts. The miserly are reborn in the realm of the hungry ghosts, where they are consumed by hunger and thirst, their flesh, skin, and blood having been dried up like the burnt stump of a tree, with hair covering their faces. Their mouths are extremely shrivelled, and they must lick anything they eat with their tongues.

There are three types of hungry ghosts. The ones with external impediments to obtaining food and drink are prevented from drinking by animals, knives, spears, and arrows whenever they see a lake, pond, or stream. The very water they see appears like blood or pus, which makes it undesirable for them to drink.

The second type of hungry ghosts are those faced with personal difficulties in eating and drinking. Their mouths are as narrow as the eye of the needle and are attached to a great gullet and a huge belly, and imbibing anything causes their mouths to burn. Even without external obstructions, when they find food and drink, they are unable to consume it.

The third type of hungry ghosts are those that have difficulty with the victuals themselves. Whatever is eaten or drunk by those called Garland of Flame, turns to fire and burns them. Those who are called Filth Eaters are dirty, have a repulsive smell, and eat pieces cut from their own bodies. They cannot eat or drink anything wholesome.

The base of their abode is located five hundred leagues below the city of *Rajgriha*[31] in this world. The rest of it is spread out from there. They live anywhere from five hundred to ten thousand years, given that one month of their time is equal to one human day.

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31 Rajagriha, was the capital of the Magadha kingdom at the time of the Buddha. Present day Rajgir, a city in Bihar's Nalanda district India.

We should examine whether we have committed misdeeds in the past or not, are currently committing misdeeds or not, or have the mind to do so in the future or not. If we have committed these deeds in the past, are committing them in the present, and have the thought of doing so, then they being the causes, we will be born in these realms—the thought of which should make us ponder as to how we are going to cope if we were born there. With our heads bursting and bodies restless, we should be panicked at the prospect of such suffering. Therefore, abandon laziness and develop joy in practising the path. Inspire ourselves to engage in the journey to liberation. To this end, we should contemplate these sufferings. There is no other way to do this, even if we were to meet the Buddha himself.

G.2. The method of obtaining happiness in the next life

This has two parts:

H.1: Training in taking refuge, the excellent door to the doctrine

H.2: Generating faith, the source of all goodness

H.1 Training in taking refuge, the excellent door to the doctrine

This has four parts:

I.1: The dependent cause upon which one takes refuge

I.2: The object of refuge

I.3: The measures by which one takes refuge

I.4: The stages of training after taking refuge

I.1: The dependent cause upon which one takes refuge

Although there are many reasons for taking refuge, wanting to free ourselves from the fear of lower rebirths and believing the Three Jewels to have the power to help us are the two reasons we are talking about here. A mere nominal understanding of the two is akin to taking refuge at a similar level, but if these two are done with strength and commitment, the refuge-taking will also be mind-taming. Therefore, we need to make an effort to realise the two causes.

I.2: The object of refuge

This has two parts:

A. Recognising the object of refuge
B. The reasons why the objects of refuge are worthy

A. Recognising the object of refuge

We should take the enlightened, victorious, and thus-gone *buddha* as our infallible refuge. This represents the other jewels—the *dharma* and the *sangha*[32]. Those aspiring for enlightenment should take these three as their refuge.

B. The reasons why the objects of refuge are worthy

There are four reasons:

i. They are free from all fears
ii. They are skilled at freeing others from fear

32 The sangha (skt.) is a part—together with the buddha and the dharma —of the Threefold Refuge. Four fully ordained monks are equivalent to one sangha. Also loosely refers to the community of monks and nuns in a monastery.

iii. They are compassionate to all without bias
iv. The object of refuge should be someone who works for everyone, irrespective of their own benefit

These qualities are present only in the enlightened and not in those such as Shiva. Therefore, the teachings he has given and the monk followers of those teachings should be worthy of refuge. We should earnestly generate certainty in the impossibility of them not protecting us if we engender single-pointed faith. Concerning the two causes of protection from suffering, although the complete external factors are shown by the Buddha, suffering does not cease due to our lack of conviction in taking refuge from our side. Therefore, see the incomparable object of refuge as the genuine protector and, trusting in him, go for refuge.

I.3: The measures by which one takes refuge

This has four aspects:

A. Taking refuge by knowing the qualities
B. Taking refuge by knowing the distinctions
C. Taking refuge through acceptance
D. Taking refuge by not acknowledging other refuges

A. Taking refuge by knowing the qualities

This has three parts:

i. Knowing the qualities of the *buddha*
ii. Knowing the qualities of the *dharma*
iii. Knowing the qualities of the *sangha*

i. The four qualities of the *buddha*

a. Bodily qualities
b. The verbal qualities
c. The mental qualities
d. The qualities of activities

a. The bodily qualities

Contemplate that the enlightened one possesses thirty-one auspicious signs and eighty-one minor features.

b. Verbal qualities

We should contemplate the immensely fascinating way the *buddha*, when asked different questions by the entire sentient beings at once, can answer all of them with one statement, and that too, in their respective languages, through the wisdom of one moment of mind.

c. Mental qualities

There are two kinds of mental qualities: the qualities of knowledge, and the qualities of compassion.

1. The qualities of knowledge—the *buddha* possesses the understanding of all phenomena in their ultimate number and state as if they were a gooseberry in the palm of his hand. To the rest of us, the object of knowledge is so vast and what we know is so little that others do not possess this much understanding.

2. The qualities of compassion—as immeasurable compassion sees the sufferings of all sentient beings, the compassionate heart arises unceasingly.

d. The Qualities of the activities

The activities of body, speech, and mind are accomplished spontaneously and consistently to help sentient beings. If the disciples are suitable to be led, there isn't a time when the enlightened ones have deprived the follower of completeness or not given or pulled them from troubles.

He sure would do everything necessary for the followers. Therefore, a brief way of recalling his kindness is that if one recalls his kindness in every way, a similar kind of faith will be generated. If one recalls his benevolence repeatedly, it will become stronger and longer. It›s the same for the other two jewels. This should be done after becoming familiar with mind training on a daily basis. It will be difficult in the beginning; however, one will get used to it and want to become someone like the enlightened being that one has recalled, and generated the mind of enlightenment. Day and night, one will see him. At the time of death, however severely one is suffering, the mind recalling the *buddha* will not decline. Therefore, one should assiduously develop a sense of commitment from the depths of one's heart to repeatedly contemplate the qualities of the enlightened one. Being able to practise this will bring the same level of certainty to the *sangha* that engages in the *dharma* from where the *buddha* has come, leading to a proper practice of taking refuge.

ii. The qualities of the dharma

With respect to the enlightened ones, we should contemplate that the beings of impeccable qualities have become such by acquiring and practising the scriptural and experiential realisations of the *dharma* of the path and cessation, through which they have abandoned the defilements and acquired positive qualities.

iii. The qualities of the sangha

The *sangha* is chiefly made up of supreme beings, and bearing in mind the qualities of the *dharma*, we should accordingly contemplate their qualities.

B. Taking refuge based on knowing the six distinctions

i. The distinction of the defining characteristics
ii. The distinction of enlightened activity
iii. The distinction of devotion
iv. The distinction of accomplishment
v. The distinction of recalling
vi. The distinction of increasing merits

i. The distinction of defining characteristics

The *buddha* is the definition of complete perfection, and the *dharma* is the result, while the *sangha* is the definition of excellent accomplishment through others' instructions.

ii. The distinction of enlightened activity

The *buddha* is the embodiment of excellent transmission; the objective of the *dharma* is the elimination of all delusions

and suffering; and the *sangha* is the enthusiastic achiever of enlightened activity.

iii. The distinction of devotion

We should be devoted to the enlightened ones as the objects of veneration, to the *dharma* as the object of realisation, and to the *sangha* as the ones who are in harmony with the *dharma*, that accompanies us.

iv. The distinction of accomplishment

*buddha*hood is achieved through service and making offerings, the *dharma* through habituation with the higher practices, and the state of the *sangha* through sharing teaching and material things.

v. The distinction of recalling

Saying, "Such is the *buddha*..." etc., one should recall the qualities of the three Jewels.

vi. The distinction of increasing merits

Merit is best increased through beings or teachings. The enlightened ones and the *sangha* belong to the first category. The merits increased would be associated with one or more persons since a *sangha* requires four monks.

C. Taking refuge through acceptance

While taking refuge, the enlightened ones should be seen as the teachers of protection, the *dharma—being nirvana*[33]*—should* be

33 In Buddhism, nirvana (skt.) means the state of having extinguished the fire of affliction, the end of suffering of cyclic existence.

seen as the actual protection, and the *sangha* as the friends on the way.

D. Taking refuge by not following other refuges

By understanding the supremacy or inferiority of both Buddhist, and Non-Buddhist doctrines teachers, and followers, one should not seek refuge in anything different from the three jewels.

I.4: The stages of training after taking refuge

This can be done in two ways:

A. The stages of training as per the *Compendium of Ascertainments*
B. The stages of training as per the quintessential instructions

A. The stages of training as per the Compendium of Ascertainments[34]

There are two sets of four for this:

i. The first set:

The first of the four, *relying on supreme beings,* is to take refuge in the *buddha*, which means considering the teacher of the path as the refuge. To practise by following him is to actually rely on the teacher of the path. *Listening to the supreme dharma and mentally applying attention* means listening to the discourses on the *sutra* and other suitable texts and engaging in them, which will generate the mind and eliminate affliction. *This means*

34 Viniscaya-samgrahani of the *Levels of Yogic Deeds* by master Asanga, 'bsdu ba' by thogs med (Tib.)

taking refuge in the dharma, which will hold the realisation of the scriptural and experiential teachings as necessary. *Taking refuge in the sangha,* we befriend those who are on the path towards *nirvana*. *To concordantly follow the path* is to train like those who are pursuing liberation.

ii. The second set:

In the second set, *the pacification of the excited sensory organs* involves seeing the loss of attention to objects and becoming distracted as a disadvantage and refocusing one's attention. *Observing the excellent basis of training* means persevering in observing the bases of training that are laid down by the enlightened one. *Having compassion for sentient beings* is an essential particularity of the doctrine of the victorious one. Therefore, we should be compassionate to all sentient beings and not harm them once we have taken refuge. *Making offerings to the three jewels then and now*. This should be done daily.

B. The stages of training as per the quintessential instructions

This has two parts:

i. Special precepts
ii. Common precepts

i. The special precepts

There are two sections to this:

a. Precepts on what to negate
b. Precepts on what to adopt

a. Precepts on what to negate

There are three precepts to negate:

1. Avoid going for refuge to other gods.
2. Abandon harming sentient beings
3. Avoid the company of *tirthikas*

b. Precepts on what to adopt

There are three precepts on what to adopt:

1. By not making fun of the objects representing the buddha found in any form, disoriented or excellent, such as in paintings. And by not putting them in unpleasant places or putting them on mortgage, one should venerate them equally as the buddha by avoiding disrespect and negligence.

2. Abandon all sort of disrespect to even four words of the *dharma*. The scriptures should not be sold or pawned. Avoid placing them in inappropriate places, allowing them to come into contact with shoes, or walking over them. Respect them like actual jewels of the *dharma*.

3. One should not scold or insult monks or ordained practitioners who possess even the slightest mark of being one. They should be respected as the Jewel of the *sangha* without distinguishing them as enemies or different from us.

ii. Common precepts

There are six common precepts:

a. As one recalls the qualities and distinctions of the Three Jewels, take refuge again and again.
b. By recalling the kindness of the Three Jewels, continually make offerings, such as the first servings of food and drink.
c. By recalling the compassion of the Three Jewels, lead all other sentient beings on the same path.
d. Make offerings and supplications to the Three Jewels for any kind of endeavour or purpose, and abandon all other worldly methods.
e. Having understood the benefits, take refuge three times during the day and three times during the night.
f. Even for fun or at the cost of our lives, do not ever forsake the Three Jewels.

How to take refuge in the Three Jewels three times during the day and three times during the night by recollecting the benefits has two parts:

1. Benefit stated in the *Compendium of Ascertainment*
2. Benefit stated in the quintessential instruction.

1. Benefit stated in the Compendium of Ascertainment has two sets of four

Accumulating extensive merit in the first set of four is as follows: It is said that should the merit of going for refuge through contemplating the unique qualities of the Three Jewels take form, even the three world systems would be too small to accommodate it—such is the enormity of the merit that will gain. If we go for refuge, recalling the Three Jewels, we will gain joy and supreme joy. Considering what we have found and seeing that what we found is excellent, our joy will increase greatly.

Gaining concentration through meditation and a state of purity calms and liberates the mind.

The second set of four consists of great protection, which eradicates all defilements amassed through perverse beliefs. Achieving complete exhaustion and elimination reduces and erases the transgressions accumulated through befriending false spiritual friends and following false doctrines. We will be counted among the superior beings and will be blessed by the enlightened ones and the gods who appreciate chaste living. This is pleasing to the superior beings and the masters. The gods are pleased by the constant taking of refuge and unceasing devotion; they see us as their friends and utter praise in triumph.

2. Benefits stated in the quintessential instruction are eight:

The eight are: we will be counted among the followers of the *buddha*; all the vows we have taken will become our support; the afflictions gathered from previous actions will be reduced and extinguished; we will accumulate great merit; we will not be born in the lower realms; we will not be harmed by human or non-human beings; we will accomplish all our aspirations; we will be soon purified.

By remembering these benefits, we should take refuge three times every day and three times every night. This way, taking refuge is the gateway to the practice of the doctrine. If the taking of refuge is more than verbal repetition, it becomes mighty and actively combats all sorts of external and internal obstacles, helping us to easily obtain positive qualities and to sustain and advance them. Therefore, as mentioned above, fearing what will happen if we do not, we should take refuge, contemplating the qualities of the objects of refuge, and, following their precepts, we should not go against them.

H.2: Generating faith, the source of all happiness

This has three parts:

I.1: Contemplating the general presentation of *karma*
I.2: Contemplating in particular
I.3: Engaging and abandoning after contemplation

I.1: contemplating the general presentation of karma

This has two parts:

I. Actual contemplation of *karma* in general
II. Contemplating individual *karma*

I. Actual contemplation of *karma* in general

This has four parts:

A. The certainty of *karma*
B. The increasing nature of *karma*
C. *karma that is* not created has no result
D. *karma* created will not go to waste

A. The certainty of karma

Even a minute of happiness is caused by positive deeds and can never be caused by negative deeds. In the same way, even a minute of suffering is caused by negative deeds and never by positive deeds. Therefore, happiness and suffering do not arise without causes and are not made by substantially different causes, such as worldly gods like Shiva and Vishnu. All the virtuous and non-virtuous deeds we commit lead to all the happiness and suffering we experience. Each act of virtue or non-virtue causes a corresponding outcome. There is no fluctuating or deceiving

the causes and their effects. To find certainty in this is to find the excellent view for every Buddhist, which is praised as the foundation of all wholesome phenomena.

B. The increasing nature of karma

From small positive deeds arises great happiness, while small negative deeds can bring intense suffering. The development of internal *karma* is different from the nature of external *karma*. Therefore, with faith in the fact that every positive or negative action can bring great happiness or sadness like a shadow, we should engage in positive deeds, however small they may be, and abandon negative deeds.

C. karma that is not created has no result

If one does not do anything that will cause suffering or happiness, then there never will have experience of suffering or happiness caused by that action.

D. karma created will not go to waste

All positive or negative actions will bring forth pleasant or unpleasant results.

II. Contemplating individual karma

This has two parts:

A. Explaining primarily the ten paths of action
B. Establishing actions and their results

A. Explaining primarily the ten paths of action

In general, there are three doors to committing good and bad actions. Although the entire range of positive and negative actions of these three doors is not encompassed in the ten paths of action, the Buddha condensed the general negative deeds—or sources of evil actions—into the ten most serious harmful acts. Seeing that the abhorrence of the ten generates great merit, he has taught the ten positive deeds. Therefore, understanding the ten negative actions and their results, we should engage physically, mentally, or verbally in the ten positive deeds, without being tainted by negativity, even in our motivation. This was taught by the victorious one over and over again as the essential basis of the path of all three vehicles and the temporary and ultimate benefit of sentient beings.

B. Establishing actions and their results

This has three sections:

i. Negative actions and results
ii. Positive actions and results
iii. Other divisions of action

i. Negative actions and their results

This has three parts:

a. The actual path of negative action
b. Different weights of the actions
c. The results of the negative actions

a. The actual path of negative actions

For each of the ten negative actions to become truly negative, there must be a basis—the intention—an actual action, and finally, a consummation stage for each. Killing, harsh words, and harmful intent are initiated by the three afflictive emotions and are completed by hatred. Stealing, sexual misconduct, and covetousness are initiated by the three afflictive emotions and are completed by attachment. Lies, slander, and gossip are initiated by all three and are also completed by all three afflictions. The wrong view is initiated by the three afflictive emotions and is completed only by ignorance. In this case, intentions are action, not the path of the action. The seven negativities of body and speech are actions as well as the path of the action, for they arise through the mind. The remaining three negativities, including covetousness, are more paths of action and not action.

b. Different weights of the actions

This has two parts:

1. The different weights of the ten paths of action
2. The powerful actions in brief

1. The different weights of the ten paths of action

There are five different ways of weighing negative actions: If an act is heavy in terms of thought, this means that the agent was possessed by intense, afflictive emotion. If it is heavy in terms of

action, the agent takes satisfaction and joy in committing the act themselves or in inciting others to do it. Heavy in terms of having no remedy means that the agent has no regret regarding the act and takes no joy in virtuous deeds. Heavy in terms of preferring wrong views means that the agent does not consider the ten non-virtuous deeds to be wrong. Heavy in terms of the being that is the basis of the act means that the act was committed against the agent's parents, those they are close to, or the learned ones and teachers, and heavy in terms of the substance that was the basis of the act means that the act involved good and numerous substances, inferior and poor substances, or those things that have been offered to the Three Jewels.

2. The powerful actions in brief

This has four types:

2.a Actions that are powerful in terms of the object
2.b Actions that are powerful in terms of basis
2.c Actions that are powerful in terms of substance
2.d Actions that are powerful in terms of intention

2.a Actions that are powerful in terms of the object

This refers to crimes against the Three Jewels, our teachers, those that are like our teachers, our parents, and so forth. Any act committed to such as these, even without strong intention, be it small or great, negative or positive, will bring great merit or demerit accordingly.

2.b Actions that are powerful in terms of basis

Actions that are powerful in terms of basis: Just as a small bit

of iron will sink in water while a vessel made of iron, however big it may be, will float over the surface, the deeds performed by the unlearned and learned ones will bring variant in the strength of the results. The ignorant ones are like a bee stuck on a snotty nose that cannot pull free. They cannot be rid of even a small transgression. Without any regret, they will not be able to take any positive action. They do not try to correct their mistakes, and the virtues they have formerly accumulated are overcome by the dirt of non-virtuous deeds to the extent that they become fruitless. These beings will be born in the deepest hell. For the learned ones who regret their wrongdoings, resolve to change, and confess their transgressions, if they try to remedy their mistakes, then the consequences are lighter for them. The merit accumulated by an ordained *bodhisattva* monk through offering a butter lamp in front of a stupa is said to be far greater than what would be accumulated if all sentient beings of the three realms embarked on the path of the Great Vehicle and if the kings of the great empires each offered butter lamps in vessels as big as oceans with wicks the size of Mount *Meru* to the stupa of the Buddha himself. The demerit accumulated by an ordained monk enjoying offerings received through misusing the fame of the great sage for one night is far greater than that of a man who commits the ten non-virtuous deeds continuously for a hundred years. These are stronger in terms of the support of the agent.

2.c. Actions that are powerful in terms of substance

Giving charity to beings in the form of the doctrine and offerings of practising his teaching is even more excellent than the giving and offering of material things to the *buddha*. From this example, the rest may be understood.

2.d. Actions that are powerful in terms of intention

Based on intention, the merit accumulated by one with the mind of enlightenment who offers a flower to a stupa of *buddha* is greater than that which would be accumulated by all the sentient beings of the three great realms building a stupa the size of Mount *Meru* and venerating it for ten million aeons. The more durable and afflictive negative deeds are, the greater the source of negative results. Among these, anger is particularly strong, and therefore it is stated in the Bodhisattva's Way of Life, "Whatever great merits have been accumulated over thousands of aeons through generosity, offering, and virtue, all may be vanquished by a single moment of anger."

c. The results of the negative actions

This has three types:

1. The fruitional result
2. The causally concordant result
3. The environmental or dominant result

1. The fruitional result

The ten paths of action based on the three afflictive emotions, each have a great, a medium, and a small result. This means that the ten negative actions—such as killing—can lead to beings taking rebirth as hell beings, hungry ghosts, or animals in accordance with the levels of each of the root afflictions.

2. The causally concordant result

Even when born as a human after lower rebirths, in the sequence of the ten non-virtuous deeds, we will have a short lifespan filled

with sickness; we will have no riches and live a common life; we will have impudent attendants and servants, will not be trusted, and will have to compete for a wife; we will often be spoken badly of and deceived, while our retinues will be uncontrollable and bad; We will hear evil things, and the words we speak will become the source of conflict; we will not keep our word; our speech will be inaccurate and rude. We will be greedy and discontent, seeking harmful things and not seeking that which is beneficial; we will harm others and be harmed by others; and we will be ill-willed and deceitful.

3. The environmental or dominant result

Killing results in having little sustenance, medicines, and fruits. With difficulty in digestion, increasing sickness leads to an early death. Stealing results in possessing very little of poor quality or not having anything at all. Sexual misconduct leads to being filthy, disordered, lowly, and ugly. Lying leads to unsuccessful farming and sailing, and we will probably live in fear of deceit. Slander will lead to being born in mountainous, craggy places. Speaking harsh words will make one take birth in the places of thorns, broken logs, and stones. Idle gossip will lead to trees not bearing fruit and roots being unstable and not lasting. Covetousness will cause the decline of all prosperity and reduce it so that it will never increase. The harmful intention will bring numerous; epidemics; harms; illness; robbery; violence and ferocious animals. Wrong views will lead to the decline of valuable resources around the world.

ii. Positive actions and their results

This has two parts:

a. Positive actions
b. Positive results

a. Positive actions

This is the virtuous mind that sees such acts as killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct as wrong and has the heart to engage in positive deeds. These are the physical deeds of practising total restraint from these acts and completion of the restraint. The same should be applied to the four positive verbal actions and the three positive mental actions; the difference between them is that some are actions of speech and the others are actions of the mind. In the act of killing, other living beings are the basis of the action, and the thought is to see the wrong in the deed and want to abandon the act. The positive action is abandoning the act with proper realisation, and the consummation stage is physically desisting from carrying out the act. The same should be understood as applying to the other positive deeds.

b. Positive results

There are three positive results:

1. Fruitiotinal results
2. Causally concordant results
3. Dominant results

1. Fruitional results

Each small, medium, and great positive act will result in rebirth in the human realm, the desire realm, and the two higher god realms, respectively.

2. **The causally concordant results and (3.) the dominant results** are the opposite of the same results of the negative deeds.

iii. Other divisions of actions

a. Projecting and completing actions

Positive deeds project us to be born in higher rebirths, while negative deeds project us in the lower realms. But completion is not certain. Even in the higher realms, there are those who lack complete faculties due to their negative deeds, while in the lower realms, some animals and hungry ghosts possess riches due to their virtues.

b. The types of actions that give definite and indefinite experiences

The actions that bring indefinite experiences refer to those deeds that are committed unintentionally or are not accumulated. Deeds that give definite experiences are those that are committed intentionally. Their experiential results are time-based, and there are three categories to this: Results that are experienced in the same life; results that are experienced in the next life; and results that are experienced in later lives. In terms of how all these accumulated positive and negative actions give rise to results in order from the strongest deeds to the lesser ones, if particular actions are similar in weight, it should be known that the ones that are committed just before death give rise to results first. If they are of similar weight, the ones with which we are more habituated will give rise to the results first, and if they are

equally familiar to us, then the ones committed first will give us the results first.

I.2: Contemplating in particular

We will gain a higher rebirth just by abandoning the ten negative actions. However, with a basis that has all the characteristics that are the foundation of omniscience, we can practise the path at a different level; therefore, we must obtain that.

There are three aspects to this:

I. Fruitional qualities
II. Fruitional results
III. Fruitional causes

I. The fruitional qualities

There are eight fruitional qualities:

A. Excellent birth
B. Excellent complexion
C. Excellent lineage
D. Excellent dominion
E. Credible speech
F. Powerful popularity
G. Being male
H. Having Strength

II. The fruitional results

There are eight fruitional results:

A. One will continue to perform positive deeds for oneself and others for a long time

B. One will gather disciples by being agreeable to them on sight, and they will readily listen to and take to heart one's words
C. One will not stray from the instructions.
D. One will have a giving spirit, which will attract sentient beings and mature them.
E. One will speak eloquently, express themselves clearly, and, being consistent in what they say, they will attract sentient beings and mature them.
F. Due to being helpful in every action, one will be repaid, and one's instructions will be promptly heeded.
G. One will become a vessel of all good qualities and will be unafraid of gatherings; one will be able to walk and talk and take pleasure with all sentient beings; and one will also have no obstacles to staying in solitude.
H. One will soon gain the individual realisation that directly understands higher knowledge, for one will rejoice in that which benefits themselves and others without being discouraged.

III. The eight fruitional causes

A. Avoiding harming sentient beings and adhering to that non-harming attitude.
B. Giving light, such as a lamp, and offering new clothes.
C. Suppressing pride, doing prostrations and such acts of servitude to the teachers, and cultivating a sense of servant-like humility towards others.
D. Giving clothes and food to the needy and helping them even when unasked; giving necessities to those who are suffering or the learned who do not possess their needs

E. Being habituated to restraining from committing the four negative verbal acts.
F. Praying for various good qualities in the next life, making offerings to the three jewels, and making offerings to our parents, the hearers[35] and solitary realizers[36], the masters, and the teachers.
G. Rejoicing in the qualities of men, not longing for the pleasures of women, and seeing such longing as a disadvantage
H. Doing what others cannot do, helping others with what can be achieved with our assistance, and providing food and drink.

The eight fruitional causes, accompanied by three driving forces, namely pure motivation, pure practice, and pure field, give excellent fruitional results.

Of the three causes, pure motivation is dedicating the merits of adopting the three causes to the obtaining of unsurpassable perfection. Upon seeing the practitioners who are better, equal or less than yourself, abandon jealousy, competitiveness, and contempt. Instead, appreciate them, and if one is not able to do so, consider them every day to constantly accomplish.

Pure practice is applying effort for a long time, without interruption and with great strength. Then to make others who have not taken pure actions to do so, praising those who have taken to find delight in doing so, making them continue for long

35 A follower of the basic vehicle first hears the instructions from the Buddha on teachings such as the four noble truths or the twelve links of interdependent origination, and then, through reflecting and meditating on these instructions, they attain their fruition of liberation.

36 A pratyekabuddha or paccekabuddha (skt.) and Pali respectively, literally means 'a buddha on their own', or solitary realizer. They are said to achieve liberation on their own, without the use of teachers or guides.

periods and not to abandon them.

The pure field is called so as the great and manifold merits are generated by pure motivation and pure practice, which is like a field.

I.3: Engaging and abandoning after contemplation

This has two parts:

I. General presentation
II. Emphasis on the practice of the four remedial powers

I. General presentation

We need to know what the positive and negative actions are. After understanding them, however, we should not just leave it at that. Instead, we must put effort into meditating on them again and again. It is very difficult to get a clear understanding of the accrual meaning of these very obscure actions. Therefore, we must have faith in the words of the One Gone Beyond and persevere in the practice. Without certainty in understanding this, we will not be able to decipher any teaching well enough to please the Victorious One. If we are thoroughly convinced of the phenomenon of *karma* and examine it day and night by way of three doors, we will be exempt from being born in the lower realms. In the beginning, with little or no knowledge of the divisions of *karma*, we let the three doors of body, speech, and mind go astray, which only leads to the gateway to the miserable realms. Not at all in accord with the practice of the law of causality, we make mistakes and cannot free ourselves. This way, watch if we are going in accordance with the law of causality. As we examine whether we are going in concordance

with the teachings and genuinely see that we are not, then we are wise.

II. Emphasis on the practice of the four remedial powers

To correct the wrongs we have done, we should apply the four remedial powers, which are:

A. power of complete repentance
B. Power of complete antidote
C. Power of reversing negative *karma*
D. Power of reliance

A. Power of complete repentance

The first is to feel deep regret about the negative actions we have committed since the beginningless time. To do this, we should meditate on how the effects of negative actions, such as the three fruitional results are generated. We can do so with the *Confession of the Excellent Golden Light* and the *Confession of the Thirty-five Buddhas.*

B. Power of complete antidote

The second is the power of relying on the antidotes, which has six parts:

i. Reliance on the profound *sutras*[37] means reading, reciting, or memorising scriptures like the *Perfection of Wisdom Sutra*.

37 In Buddhism, sutras (skt.) also known as suttas, Pali, are canonical scriptures, many of which are regarded as records of the oral teachings of Gautama Buddha.

ii. Interest in the theory of emptiness means meditating and generating reverence for the clear-light nature and its primordial pure state.
iii. Reliance on repetition means repeatedly reciting the essential *mantra*s, like the *Hundred Syllable Mantra* and so forth, as per their respective rituals.
iv. Reliance on the image means creating images of the *buddha* with profound faith in him.
v. Reliance on the offering means offering various substances to the *buddha* and those objects that represent him.
vi. Reliance on the name means hearing and learning the names of the *buddhas* and *bodhisattva*s.

C. Power of reversing negative karma

The third power is firmly abstaining from the ten non-virtuous actions. This will put an end to actions such as taking life, etc., by destroying all negative *karma* and afflictions and obscurations of the three doors. This eliminates the effect of previously committed negative acts—the ones we have compelled others to do or in which we have rejoiced.

D. Power of reliance

The fourth power is cultivating the mind of enlightenment and taking refuge. Although the Victorious One has taught various ways for beginners to purify negative actions, complete purification comes through applying the four remedial powers.

F.2: The measure of the practice of the path of a person of small scope

For someone who has a genuine desire to live this worldly existence and who has an intellectual understanding of the life after, an advancement should happen where the life after becomes the main objective and the existence of this life becomes secondary. However, as this has to be lasting, we have to consistently practise it.

F.3: Eliminating misconceptions about the path

It is said in the scriptures that we should shun the pleasures of the world, but if due to this we think that it is a bad idea to strive for a higher rebirth endowed with an excellent body and riches, as it is a worldly existence, we should understand that with regards to immediate and lasting objectives, a higher rebirth endowed with excellence is something that those who are seeking liberation should gain as the immediate objective, as we will achieve enlightenment gradually through ascending levels of rebirth. The higher rebirths that are complemented with excellent bodies, wealth, and attendants are not worldly compilations. They are the fruition of the form-body, its practice, and its environment.

I have covered the stages of the path shared with persons of the small scope with the text, *The Essence of the Stages of the Path*: Lamp Illuminating the Essential Instructions of the Stages of the Path of the Persons of the Small Scope Based on the Outlines of The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment.

Since beginningless time, we have grasped the pleasures of the world as the source of happiness and habituated ourselves to the exaggeration of beauty. If we contemplate suffering and

unpleasantness, we can reverse this. If we do not, through the increasing ignorance and attachment, it is said that we will continue to cycle in on the wheel of existence. Therefore, it is very important to realise the defects of worldly existence. Concerning this, the second stage of the path for training the mind is that shared with persons of medium scope.

E.2 Training the mind in the stages of the path shared with a persons of medium scope

This has four parts:

F.1: Actual mind training in the practice of a person of medium scope
F.2: The measure of the practice of the path of the person of medium scope
F.3: Eliminating misconceptions about the path
F.4: Establishing the nature of the path leading to liberation

F.1: Actual mind training in the practice of a person of medium scope

This has two parts:

G.1: Recognising the mind that aspires to be liberated
G.2: Methods to generate that mind

G.1: Recognising the mind that aspires to be liberated

Liberation is being free of the bondage that binds us to cyclic existence through *karma* and ignorance. It is these two causes that link the six kinds of life forms throughout the three realms to the four sources of rebirth4. This is how we are bound, and freedom from this bondage is liberation. And the desire to obtain that is the mind that aspires to be liberated.

G.2 Methods to generate that mind

There are two ways to generate the aspiring mind:

H.1: Cultivation of the mind by contemplating the truth of suffering and its origin

H.2: Cultivation of the mind by contemplation of the twelve links of dependent arising

H.1: Cultivation of the mind by contemplating the truth of suffering and its origin

This has two parts:

I.1: Becoming convinced that the truth of suffering is the defect of cyclic existence

I.2: Contemplating the process of entry into cyclic existence through the truth of the origin

I.1: Becoming convinced that the truth of suffering is the defect of cyclic existence

This has two parts:

J.1: The reason for explaining the truth of suffering as the first of the four truths

J.2: The actual meditation on the truth of suffering

J.1: The reason for explaining the truth of suffering as the first of the four truths

If we are not able to develop a genuine desire to be free from cyclic existence, we are cut from the root. How can we then be led towards liberation? As it has been said that worldly pleasures are suffering, various kinds of suffering are taught to cultivate

renunciation; therefore, the truth of suffering is taught first. Having learned this and seeing that we have fallen into the ocean of suffering and desire to be free of it, we will see the need to overcome suffering. Having understood that without eliminating the causes, there can be no reversal of suffering, the truth of the origin is taught next regarding the nature of these causes. With this truth, we will realise that the suffering of cyclic existence arises from contaminated actions, that those actions are caused by ignorance, and that self-grasping is the root of this ignorance. Seeing that self-grasping can be countered, we vow to actualize the cessation of suffering. Therefore, the truth of cessation was taught next. With the resolve to actualize liberation, which is the cessation of suffering, we look for the path and follow it. Thus, the truth of the path is taught last. This way, the four truths are explained repeatedly in all the greater and smaller vehicles. These important points regarding the reversal of entry into cyclic existence have all been encompassed by the one gone to bliss, and as they are crucial in the attainment of liberation and are essential landmarks in the practice of *dharma*. Students should thus be taught in accordance with these stages.

J.2: Actual meditation on the truth of suffering

This has two parts:

I. Contemplating the general suffering of cyclic existence
II. Contemplating the sufferings of individual types of beings

I. Contemplating the general suffering of cyclic existence

This has three parts:

A. Contemplating the eight sufferings
B. Contemplating the six sufferings
C. Contemplating the three sufferings

A. Contemplating the eight sufferings

i. Contemplating the suffering at the time of birth

When you are born, you are born with suffering possessing bad rebirth that itself leads to sickness, ageing, mental afflictions, and death. We must consider how these too produce suffering. In particular, while in the womb, the embryo grows and evolves with its hands, feet, and jaws wrapped up in the vessel of the handkerchief-like placenta, amongst all sorts of impurities teaming with thousands of types of bacteria, below the stomach and above the intestine, which has two foul-smelling exits; surrounded by darkness and unbearable smells; stung by bitter, sour, salty, hot, and astringent tastes like sparks from a fire; sustained by impure juices like a tapeworm; passing through a putrid swamp of impurities; and fully scorched by all the heat within the body, immensely tormented by the unbearable unpleasantness of rough sensations. When it comes to delivery, there is also suffering at the time of birth. Due to the impact of previous *karma*, the limbs, forehead, nose, and chin are all facing up, and the head is facing down. In order to pull the hands, one has to bear the immense pain of passing through the hip bones. With unbearably unpleasant roughness, the limbs of the body, like an open wound, turn blue. All the faculties of the body hurt, and the body itself is covered with the impurities of the womb. The lips, throat, and heart are parched with thirst. In this state of unbearable anxiety and fear that arises due to causes

and conditions of fully ripened past *karma*, the air of birth is expelled fitfully and with difficulty. The impact of the outside air pierces like a sharp blade, and contact with hands or fabric brings terrible pain, like being cut by a knife. It is an unbearably unpleasant experience.

ii. Contemplating the suffering of ageing

The suffering of ageing makes our bodies bend like a bow, our hair grows as white as the flowers of the hummingbird tree, and our foreheads become wrinkled like the grooves on a chopping board. When we sit down, it is like a sack being dropped, and when we stand up, it is like uprooting a tree. When we speak, it is unintelligible, and we stumble when we walk. Our eyes can no longer make out forms. We suffer from forgetfulness and loss of memory. We have trouble digesting our food and cease to enjoy the luxuries of life. Having already lived the majority of our lives, it is a downhill slide towards death. We should contemplate these things again and again.

iii. Contemplating the suffering of sickness

Due to the suffering of sickness, our flesh wastes away and our skin becomes dehydrated. The decrease in the fluid element of the body leads to mental imbalances. This extends to tormenting the body, and day and night, the mind is disturbed. Because pleasant things are said to worsen the illness, we cannot enjoy them even if we want to. We must abstain from doing all such desirable things, and instead, we must meticulously consume food, drink, and medicines that are unpleasant to our liking without choice. To recover, we must undergo the pain of harsh and burning medical instruments. Even so, seeing that the

illness cannot be cured, our suffering will increase. We need to thoroughly contemplate these points.

iv. Contemplating the suffering of death

At the time of death, one must part from the pleasantries of wealth, friends, and family, the material world, and the body. At the time of death, the pain of parting with these pleasantries is tremendous. Therefore, contemplate these facts again and again until we feel disenchanted by them.

v. Contemplating the suffering of meeting with unpleasantness

Just by seeing one's enemy, we become unhappy and stressed. The fear of being attacked by them makes us panic. Hearing bad news frightens us. The thought of dying pitifully and taking a lower rebirth makes us anxious. Think over these points repeatedly.

vi. Contemplating the suffering of being separated from the pleasantness

If we are parted from very dear friends and so forth, much sorrow arises in us. We mournfully lament, harming our bodies. Recalling their virtues, we desire their presence. Feeling their absence, we suffer in misery. These are thoughts we should contemplate.

vii. Contemplating the suffering of not finding what we desire

This is the suffering of discouragement that comes from not reaping a harvest even though we have tilled and planted the

field, not making a profit on what we sell, or not finding whatever we hope and strive for.

viii. Contemplating the five appropriated aggregates as suffering

Contemplating the five appropriated aggregates as suffering requires understanding that being born with the five appropriated aggregates is the cause of all the sufferings of future lives. Since the body has been formed, it will undergo the sufferings of ageing, sickness, and so forth. The two sufferings also arise due to the dysfunctional tendencies linked to them. By merely acquiring the appropriated aggregates, the suffering of conditionality naturally arises. That is because appropriating the aggregate itself by nature is suffering since all compositional factors under the control of past *karma* and mental afflictions are suffering from conditionality.

B. Contemplating the six sufferings

i. The defect of uncertainty

Our parents and those we love in this life will become our enemies in other lives, and the enemies of this life in future lives will be our beloved friends. Even in this very life, friends become enemies, and enemies become friends. The concept of attachment and hatred based on friendship and animosity is unfounded. Seeing that there is thus no worldly phenomenon we can rely on, we should deplore.

ii. The defect of discontentment

Concerning worldly happiness, no matter how many possessions we may own, discontentment continues to increase. Due to this, we circle in cyclic existence for a long time, and not even a portion of the suffering we must bear every time can be compensated by the meager enjoyments.

iii. The defect of having to repeatedly abandon bodies

If we kept all the discarded bones of the bodies we assumed in each incarnation, the pile would be bigger than Mount *Meru*.

iv. The defect of constantly migrating between lives

If we were to hold up little balls of the earth the size of juniper berries and say, "This represents my mother; this represents my mother's mother," the count would never end, but the vast mass of the earth would be exhausted.

v. The defect of constantly falling into lower states

With regard to how we migrate from higher to lower realms, we should feel detached from the cyclic existence for every worldly pleasure ends in deterioration.

vi. The defect of loneliness

If this very flesh and bone that came together with this body must fall and disintegrate, then what need is to say about separation from our friends as well.

The six can be combined into three

i. The cyclic existence is unreliable
ii. One will never be satisfied by the pleasures of cyclic existence
iii. We have been cycling in *samsara*[38] since beginningless time

i. The cyclic existence is unreliable

i. We cannot rely on the acquisition of a body, for we must repeatedly leave our bodies
ii. We cannot rely on being helped or harmed, for there is no certainty
iii. We cannot rely on the acquisition of good things, for we fall from high states to low states
iv. We cannot rely on friends, for we will end up alone

ii. One will never be satisfied by the pleasures of cyclic existence.

iii. We have been cycling in samsara since beginningless time

We are perpetually engaged in transmigration, for the end of the continuation of birth is inconceivable.

38 In Buddhism, samsara, (skt.) is the "suffering-laden cycle of life, death, and rebirth, without beginning or end". Also referred to as the wheel of existence. Jeff Wilson

C. Contemplating the three sufferings

Imagine the bliss of a boil or an inflamed pustule being splashed with cool water—that is the kind of happiness we experience in our worldly existence. The feeling will soon fade, and that is the *suffering of change*. When that painful boil comes into contact with salt water or the like, the pain will be excruciating, and we will realise our suffering. These inflammations torment our body and mind from the moment they arise. Understand this as the *suffering of suffering*, like the pain of a kidney stone. Before coming into contact with either of these two sufferings, we have the feeling of having an undeveloped boil, which is a contaminated neutral feeling. This conditions us to be born in lower realms and is *conditional-pervasive suffering*. This sort of suffering is preconditioned by previous *karma* and mental afflictions and serves as the seed for future suffering and affliction. It is capable of impelling rebirth persistently in the lower realms.

The feeling of happiness breeds attachment and suffering increases anger, the perception of the impermanent body which is neither happiness nor suffering but dysfunctional tendency as permanent, increase ignorance. Attachment causes the sufferings that impel us to take future rebirths as the five types of sentient beings; hatred causes us to suffer in this life and impels us to experience the suffering of lower rebirths in future lives; ignorance prevents us from letting go of the causes that give rise to these two sufferings. Therefore, by viewing the feeling of happiness as suffering, we should eliminate attachment. By considering that feelings of suffering arise as torment due to the body which is a collection of causes of suffering, we should eliminate anger. By viewing neutral feelings as impermanent and, by nature, exhaustible and to be negated, we should

eliminate ignorance. In doing this, we will prevent the three types of feelings from becoming the causes of the three poisons.

II. Contemplating the sufferings of individual types of beings

This has six parts, of which the *sufferings of the three lower realms* have already been discussed.

The sufferings of human beings are such that we have to experience the discomforts of hunger and thirst, cold and heat, and other unpleasant things such as struggling to make a living, exhaustion, and the seven aforementioned trials of birth, ageing, death, and such.

The sufferings of the demi-gods are that they are tormented by jealousy of the wealth possessed by the gods. This leads them to wage war on the gods, in which they are hacked to pieces. Although they are intelligent, they are afflicted by the mature result of previous karmic deeds, so it is not right to believe in such a rebirth.

The gods of the desire realm experience three types of suffering: the suffering of death and downfall, the suffering of jealousy, and the suffering of being cut, torn, or killed. While the life of the desire realm god is very enjoyable, at the time of their death, they are greatly frightened by seeing the five signs of their demise. Their bodies discolour and become ugly; their thrones become unattractive; their flower garlands become old; their garments lose their fragrance; and their bodies begin to perspire like never before. When they are about to die without any positive *karma* remaining, they begin to visualise being born as animals, hungry ghosts, or hell-beings, which terrifies them. This is the suffering of downfall.

The suffering of jealousy arises when a god of the desire realm sees another who has accumulated greater virtue and

merit than themselves. This makes them jealous and greatly unhappy. Then, when the gods battle the demi-gods, they suffer from being cut and wounded. Moreover, when the gods fight among themselves, the powerful drive the weaker ones from their abodes.

The gods and goddesses of the form and formless realms do not have to face these sufferings, but they possess mental afflictions and have defilements. Because where they will transmigrate to and abide is not under their own control, they too experience the suffering of negative rebirths.

In this way, by contemplating the sufferings of the six kinds or five categories of sentient beings as well as our own, if we can cultivate a sense of disenchantment with cyclic existence, then we will be able to contemplate its causes and examine them.

I.2: Contemplating the process of entry into cyclic existence through the truth of the origin

There are three aspects to this:

J.1 How mental afflictions arise
J.2 How this leads to the accumulation of *karma*
J.3 Process of death and conception

J.1: How the afflictions arise

This has four parts:

I. Recognising the afflictions
II. The stages by which the afflictions arise
III. The causes of the afflictions
IV. The faults of the afflictions

I. Recognising the afflictions

The general definition of affliction is anything that greatly disturbs the mental continuum when it arises. The definitions of the ten individual afflictions are as follows:

A. Attachment is the desire that develops upon seeing an external or internal object as attractive. When we are deeply attached to an object, separating from it is as hard as trying to extract oil that has been absorbed by a cloth.
B. Anger is the wild state of mind that directs our dismay at the perceived cause of suffering—such as other beings, suffering, weapons, thorns, and so forth—and wishes to harm them.
C. Arrogance is the haughtiness that we develop in dependence on the view of transitory collections, having perceived external or internal concepts of high and low, good and bad. It is to have a sense of superiority.
D. Ignorance is having an afflicted and confused mind that does not know the four noble truths, *karma*, and the Three Jewels.
E. Doubt is confusion as to whether the four noble truths are true or not, and whether *karma* and the Three Jewels exist or not.
F. The view of transitory collections is the afflicted intelligence that causes us to think of ourselves and our possessions as me and mine due to perceiving the aggregates with the mind of endearment.
G. The view of grasping at extremes is the afflicted intelligence that—due to perceiving the I grasped by the view of transitory collections—causes us to develop the

eternalist[39] view of permanence or the annihilationist view that there is no such thing as future lives.

H. Holding the extreme view as supreme is the afflictive intelligence that, having perceived the constitution of the arisen view, grasps at its superiority due to dependence on any of the three: the view of transitory collections, the eternalistic view, or the wrong view.

I. Holding ethics and conduct as supreme is having an afflictive intelligence that affirms ethics that determines abandoning corrupted morality, manner, way of life, and physical and mental activities with their countering conducts, and cleansing of the aggregate from where these arise as way of purifying wrong deeds, liberation from afflictive emotions and deliverance from *samsara*.

J. The wrong view is having an afflicted intelligence that denies the existence of past and future lives, *karma*, and so forth, and holds Shiva, Vishnu, and the like as the origin of living beings.

II. The stages of arisal of affliction

Just as a coil of rope might be taken for a snake in the dark by one who does not know it to be a rope, the darkness of ignorance that obstructs us from clearly seeing the mode of existence of the aggregates gives rise to the false idea of a self, which causes the rest of the afflictions to arise.

39 Eternalism: rtag lta (Tib.) the belief that there is a permanent and causeless creator of everything; in particular, that one's identity or consciousness has a concrete essence that is independent, everlasting, and singular.

III. Causes of the arisal of the afflictions

There are six causes:

A. Basis—having dormant mental afflictions
B. Object—perceiving objects concordant with the arising of afflictions
C. Gathering—following unholy, bad friends
D. Explanation—listening to false teachings
E. Habituation—the increasing power of formally familiarised afflictions
F. Attention—fabricating the characteristics of wholesomeness and unwholesomeness, misapprehension of that which is impermanent as permanent, and so forth.

VI. The faults of the afflictions

The afflictions bring harm to both ourselves and others. They generate wrong deeds in both the present and future lives. They cause the experience of suffering and displeasure, spread defamation in all directions, and bring about reproach from teachers, guardians, and other holy beings. They cause us to die a regretful death, leading to a lower rebirth, and prevent us from attaining our purpose.

J.2 How this leads to the accumulation of karma

This has two parts:

I. Recognising the *karma* we accumulate
II. How *karma* is accumulated

I. Recognising the karma we accumulate

This has two types:

A. Intentional *karma*
B. Determined *karma*

A. Intentional karma

This is the mental action that moves and incites the associated mental factor towards the objects.

B. Determined karma

This is the action motivated by intentional *karma* and performed through the body and speech. Generally, actions are virtuous, non-virtuous, or ethically neutral. Non-virtuous actions are those that are unmeritorious, while contaminated virtuous actions are either meritorious or unwavering actions. Meritorious virtuous actions are those performed within the desire realm, and unwavering actions are contaminated virtuous actions performed in the form and formless realms.

II. How karma is accumulated

As long as we hold onto a conception of the self, we will accumulate impelling *karma*. The accumulation will cease once we become truly aware of the reality of selflessness. Those who accumulate *karma*, which impels them into cyclic existence, are ordinary beings. Due to this, afflictive ignorance and a nihilistic view empower the three doors of body, speech, and mind to commit non-virtuous actions such as killing, which leads to the accumulation of *unmeritorious karma*. The virtuous

actions of the desire realm—such as generosity, renunciation, and observing ethical discipline—will bring *meritorious karma*, and meditative concentration and the calm-abiding within the formless realm will bring about the accumulation of *unwavering karma*.

Seeing all the pleasures of cyclic existence as flawed and thoroughly motivated by the wish to be liberated from it all, the meritorious *karma* of performing many virtuous deeds as well as properly applying the discriminative awareness that understands the true meaning of selflessness is the remedial antidote to craving.

But if one does not find the antidote to craving and does not investigate the meaning of selflessness, deprived of familiarity with the mind of enlightenment, all ordinary beings will have to cycle on the wheel of *samsara,* and only the realised beings who are supported by the power of the sacred grounds will be exempt.

There are two types of accumulated *karma*:

A. That which is accumulated for the sake of happiness
B. That which is accumulated for the sake of neutral feelings

A. karma accumulated for the sake of happiness

This has two categories:

i. That which is accumulated for the sake of the happiness that comes from the enjoyment of the sense pleasures.
ii. That which is accumulated for the sake of the feeling of happiness that arises from meditative stabilisation.

i. karma accumulated for the sake of the happiness that comes from the enjoyment of the sense pleasures

There are two categories for this:

a. a. The *karma* accumulated for happiness in this life, which is non-virtuous,
b. b. The *karma* accumulated for the sake of happiness in future lives, which is virtuous.

ii. That which is accumulated for the sake of the feeling of happiness that arises from meditative stabilisation

In this, we will accumulate the unwavering *karma* that leads to rebirth at the first to third stages of meditative stabilisation.

B. That which is accumulated for the sake of neutral feelings

If we commit actions for the sake of neutral feelings with no attachment even to the object of desire, as well as being wary of happiness, we accumulate the unwavering *karma* of the fourth concentration up to the peak of cyclic existence. Having become disgusted with all of cyclic existence, committing actions through the three doors for the sake of liberation distances us from *samsara* and brings us closer to liberation.

J.3: Process of death and conception

This has five sections:

I. The causes of death
II. Consciousness at the time of death
III. How the body loses heat
IV. How the intermediate stage is assumed after the death
V. How conception takes place

I. The causes of death are:

The causes of death are: death from the exhaustion of lifespan; death from deprivation of necessities; or death caused by food, medication, and the like.

II. Consciousness at the time of death

There are three types of consciousness at the time of death:

A. Virtuous dying consciousness
B. Non-virtuous dying consciousness
C. Neutral dying consciousness

A. Virtuous dying consciousness

It is like rising from darkness into light with a happy mind preconditioned by the recollection of virtues like faith and so forth, whether self-initiated or encouraged by others. At the time of death, the body experiences no feeling of extreme suffering.

B. Non-virtuous dying consciousness

Non-virtuous dying consciousness occurs when we recall non-virtues, such as attachment, initiated by ourselves or inspired by others. Due to this, our bodies experience immense pain at the time of death, and we die with the sensation of travelling from light into darkness.

C. Neutral dying consciousness

This means that, when neither our own effort nor that of others makes us recall any virtue or non-virtue, one would not have any feeling of joy or suffering at the time of death. At the time of

death, the presence of either of these consciousnesses and their strength depend on our familiarity with each of them in this life. They continue as long as the gross sense faculties exist, but all dying consciousnesses become neutral once the senses become subtle.

III. How the body loses heat

In those who are engaged in negativity, consciousness abandons the upper part of the body, and the torso is the first part to become cold as the warmth retracts towards the heart. Those engaged in virtue lose heat first from the lower body. In both cases, consciousness departs the body from the heart.

IV. How the intermediate stage is assumed after the death

As explained before, consciousness assumes the intermediate stage without interruption, like the shifting of weight from one side of a set of scales to the other. This is caused by attachment to the body, our habituation with the enjoyment of pleasure, and our conditioning by either virtuous or non-virtuous actions. In the intermediate stage, we still have all the sense faculties—such as sight—fully functioning, and until we enter the next body in which we will take birth, our eyesight is incredible, like that of the gods, and our body is miraculously unobstructable. There are four states of existence: The time between death and the next conception is called the *intermediate state*. The first moment of birth is called the *state of birth*. The period from the second moment until the final moment before death is called the *prior state*, and the last moment of death is called the *state of death*.

V. How conception takes place

When we experience conception in a womb and see beings of our own kind, out of a desire to be able to see and love them, a desire to go to that place of birth arises. Then, distracted by the parents' sperm and ovum, we see them having intercourse. If we were to be born female, we would be attracted to the male partner and wish to lie with him. If we were to be born male, we would be attracted to the female partner and wish to lie with her. At a certain point, seeing no part of the person but only the sex organs, we become enraged and leave the intermediate state to be born. When we are born from heat and moisture, it is due to a desire for smells, and when we are miraculously born, it is due to a desire for places. Birth from eggs follows the same sequence as birth from a womb.

H.2: Cultivation of the mind by contemplation of the twelve links of dependent arising

There are four parts to the contemplation of the twelve links of dependent arising:

I. Divisions of the links
II. Grouping of the links
III. Lifetimes needed to complete one circle of the links
IV. Summary of the points

I. Divisions of the twelve links

The twelve links of the dependent origination are:

A. *Ignorance*: This has two: Ignorant of the law of causality and ignorance of the meaning of suchness.
B. *Compositional activity*: This is *karma* or action,

unmeritorious *karma* that impels us into negative states, and the *karma*s that impel us into positive states. There are two types of *karma*s that impel us into positive states: Meritorious *karma*s that impel us into the positive state of the desirable realm and unwavering *karma*s that impel us into the positive state of the upper realms.

C. *Consciousness*: Consciousnesses are of two types: causal consciousness, which is the consciousness of the present life, conditioned by the imprints of compositional actions; and resultant consciousness, the consciousness of the fruition period.

D. *Name and form*: Name refers to the four formless aggregates, namely feeling, discrimination, compositional factors, and consciousness; and form is the physical embryo of all sorts.

E. *The six sense spheres*: The six sources of consciousness of the eyes, and so on.

F. *Contact*: The collection of object senses and consciousnesses that discriminate whether an object is pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral.

G. *Feeling*: As contact discriminates the objects, the feelings of pleasure, displeasure, and neutrality are generated, respectively.

H. *Craving*: The sensation of wanting to be rid of suffering and not to part with happiness.

I. *Grasping*: Holding onto sense pleasures; holding onto views; holding onto wrong modes of conduct; and holding onto the assertion of a self

J. *Existence*: Rebirth caused by previous compositional factors that leave imprints on consciousness, empowered by grasping and craving

K. *Birth*: Conception of consciousness in any of the four modes of birth
L. *Ageing and death*: Ageing is the maturing and transformation of the body, while death is leaving that same body.

II. Grouping of the links

There are two categories into which the links are grouped:
A. The impelling and impelled factors
B. The establishing and established factors

A. The impelling factors are ignorance, compositional activity, and consciousness, and the impelled factors are name and form, the sense-spheres, contact, and feeling.

B. The establishing factors are craving, grasping, and existence, and the established factors are birth, ageing, and death.

Another way of grouping the twelve links is to summarise them into affliction, *karma*, and the path of suffering, as follows:

A. *Affliction:* The first link, gnorance; the eighth, craving; and the ninth, grasping.
B. *karma*: The second link, compositional factors; and the tenth, existence.
C. *Suffering*: The remaining seven links

III. Lifetimes needed to complete one cycle of the links

Although there may be many aeons between the arising of the impelling and impelled factors, the cycle may be completed in the following life without any other life in between. Since the establishing and established factors are experienced without interruption, this cycle will be completed in two lifetimes, which is the fastest. For example, if in the current life we accumulate new experiential *karma* by taking birth as a god, at that time the two-and-a-half links of ignorance, compositional factors, and causal consciousness will be completed, and before the time of death, the three links of craving, grasping, and existence will be completed. Then, in the next life, the four and a half impelling factors and the two established factors will be completed. At most, it will take no more than three lifetimes to complete this circle. The establishing factors and the two established factors, as well as the three impelling factors, will each take one lifetime to complete, while the impelled factors are completed along with the established factors. Although there may be a gap of many lifetimes between the impelling and establishing factors, this occurs due to a link of dependent arising other than the current. As mentioned earlier, mere phenomenal causal links produce mere phenomenal resultant links, and due to the ignorance of not understanding the workings of the cyclic existence, we grasp at a self; and wanting happiness for that self, we collect virtuous and non-virtuous *karma* through the actions of our three doors—body, speech, and mind—which leads us again into the cycle of existence. From the three root afflictions come the two types of action, and from these, the seven types of suffering arise. From the seven sufferings, mental afflictions arise, and due to this, we continue to cycle.

Deeply contemplating how we wander in cyclic existence is the best way to develop a disregard for worldly things. For innumerable aeons, we have accumulated impelling factors through various virtuous and non-virtuous actions that, being neither yet mature nor eliminated by antidotes but rather empowered by our current craving and grasping, will impel us either into the fortunate or unfortunate realms. Even though *arhats*[40]may have accumulated countless impelling factors in their previous incarnations, because they are free of mental afflictions, through obtaining a firm conviction in the method of liberation from cyclic existence, they conceive the afflictions as the enemy and apply effort in the pursuit of the path of cessation. Moreover, contemplating the twelve factors of entering and leaving the unfortunate realms pertains to persons of small scope. Contemplating the twelve links of entering and leaving the two fortunate realms pertains to persons of medium scope. Accordingly, by abandoning preoccupation with our own wellbeing and developing compassion for all other mother sentient beings—who are wandering in cyclic existence through the twelve links of the dependent origination—training in the wish to cultivate enlightenment and studying the path is the province of the person of great scope.

V. Summary of the points

As explained earlier, through the origins—*karma* and mental affliction—the circle of the aggregate of suffering is established. Knowing how the cycle of existence is perpetuated through the twelve links of dependent arising and becoming familiar with

40 'Arhat' (skt.): Foe-destroyer, one who has vanquished his enemies, the obscuring emotions. The highest level attained by person of small capacity or medium capacity.

it is the best way to develop the inspiration to follow the path. Seeing the nature of cyclic existence through the treasure of the teachings of the victorious one eliminates the root of the darkness of ignorance. For those who have become familiar with the path, this will awaken the imprints necessary for gaining supreme status.

F.2: The measure of the practice of the path of the person of medium scope

When we have a thorough understanding of the nature of cyclic existence, the wish to renounce it and obtain liberation is the mind of renunciation. However, the desire must be stronger, like the desire to run away from a burning house or to break out of prison, and the intensity of this desire should continue to increase.

F.3: Eliminating misconceptions about the path

We might think that by renouncing cyclic existence and contemplating the unhappy nature of it, like the hearers, we might develop an aversion to existing in *samsara* and fall into the extreme of peace. Therefore, feeling depressed about cyclic existence is suitable only for the lesser vehicle and is not a subject of meditation for the *bodhisattvas*. It is not that *bodhisattvas* are not saddened by the sufferings of wandering in cyclic existence—birth, ageing, and death—but rather, having prepared themselves to abide by the trainings of developing the mind of enlightenment until the end of cyclic existence and experiencing all the sufferings of sentient beings, without being saddened or exhausted by such an onus, they exert incredible effort in joyfully carrying the conduct of a *bodhisattva*. If they

are wandering in the cyclic existence oppressed by suffering due to afflictions and negative *karma*, they will not achieve their own objectives, let alone the objectives of others. This state is the threshold for all sorts of degeneration. Therefore, they are saddened, far more so than the lower vehicles. Therefore, this needs to be stopped. This is different from taking worldly birth, brought about delightfully by the power of prayer, compassion, and so forth.

F.4: Establishing the nature of the path leading to liberation

The thought of wandering in cyclic existence since beginningless time is depressing and detaching. The fear of remaining in it for endless lifetimes to come should inspire us to renounce it not merely in words but to find a remedy to completely prevent our being born in it. This can be achieved by getting rid of the causes, which is done by eliminating *karma* and mental afflictions. Without mental afflictions, no matter how much *karma* has been accumulated, it will not mature, but if there are mental afflictions, this will immediately lead to the creation of new *karma*, even though we may not have accumulated any earlier. Therefore, we must eradicate mental afflictions.

However, to do this, we must depend on the cultivation of a complete and correct path. This has two aspects: The kind of rebirth that will put an end to cyclic existence, and the kind of path to train to put an end to cyclic existence.

I. The kind of rebirth that will put an end to cyclic existence:

The best option is to have obtained the rebirth with leisure and endowments. This will become even better if we are ordained. The superior beings praise the ordained ones. They should be

clad in religious robes, own a simple bowl for alms, and always be content. By reducing afflictions and living in an isolated place, observing the life of a sage is truly how we will come to understand the teachings of the Buddha. Therefore, a life of ordination is the best rebirth through which we can obtain liberation from cyclic existence and also achieve enlightenment through perfection as well as the diamond vehicle (Vajrayana). Of the three types of vows, the vow of ordination is the vow of self-emancipation. Therefore, revere the vow of ordination, the root of the *dharma*.

II. The kind of path to train to put an end to cyclic existence:

For this, we must practise the three precious paths of training.

This has three parts:

A. Ways to ascertain that there are three trainings
B. Ascertaining their stages
C. The nature of the three trainings

A. Ways to ascertain that there are three trainings:

i. Ascertainment through the stages of disciplining the mind
ii. Ascertainment through the results of the trainings
iii. Ascertainment through the level of afflictions they eliminate

i. Ascertainment through the stages of disciplining the mind

To focus the distracted mind, there is training in ethics. To stabilise the unstabilized mind, there is training in concentration.

And to liberate the unliberated mind, there is training in wisdom. These three trainings complete the path of a practitioner.

ii. Ascertainment through the results of the trainings

The result of upholding ethics is a rebirth in the two desirable realms. The result of stabilising the mind is a rebirth in the two higher realms. And the result of gaining wisdom is liberation.

iii. Ascertainment through the level of afflictions they eliminate

The three trainings can be numbered based on the stages of how they remedy the afflictions, subdue the active afflictions, and uproot the latent afflictions.

B. Ascertaining their stages

Training in ethics is the basis on which the next two trainings follow. With regards to ethics, meditative equipoise and great joy are the second stages. Through meditative equipoise, we are endowed with the view of superior beings who perceive ultimate reality as it is and are separated from wrong views, which is the third stage.

C. The nature of the three trainings

Ethical discipline is a training endowed with six branches. Being disciplined and receiving the vow of self-emancipation is a sign of the pure ethical discipline that assures liberation. Performing rituals and being endowed with a sphere of activity is a sign of a pure ethical discipline that is impeccable. Fearing to commit the smallest of wrong deeds shows a pure ethical discipline that

is non-degenerative. Learning from the right sources shows pure ethical discipline that is unmistakable. The four bases of mental training are the four absorptions, practising of which enables one to live peacefully in this life. This is what is known as training the mind.

The training of wisdom is gaining realisation of the sixteen aspects: the four aspects of the suffering—impermanence, suffering, emptiness, and selflessness; the four aspects of the origin of the suffering—cause, origin, intense generation, and conditions; the four aspects of the cessation—cessation, peace, satisfaction, and renunciation; and the four aspects of the path—path, awareness, achievement, and deliverance.

First, one must repeatedly contemplate the benefits of observing pure conduct and take immense joy in the training, as it is the stairway to all kinds of practice. Pure conduct is not possible for someone who does not observe the law of causality. Being aware of this is the main instruction. It is essential to curb mental afflictions; otherwise, pure conduct is impossible. Without pure conduct, we cannot achieve concentration and the wisdom that subdues and eradicates the afflictions, and thus we remain forever wandering in cyclic existence. Therefore, whenever an affliction arises, we must immediately fight it off like an enemy. Instead of doing that, if we let it come in the first place and then nourish it with dispersive thoughts, it will be empowered in such a way that it controls everything. So, as soon as any kind of affliction arises, without delay or laziness, we should immediately remedy it with antidotes. If we cannot overtake it, we should lay out the offerings of the *mandala*, offer and pray to the deities and spiritual masters for help, and repeat the *mantra* of the wrathful ones. This will make the affliction disappear. Alternatively, it is said that we can try to fight it off

by changing locations or engaging in a movement of some kind, which can cause the afflictive thought to disappear.

Ignorance is the most difficult affliction to get rid of and is the parent of all other afflictions. To remedy it, we need to repeatedly meditate on the phenomenon of dependent origination and develop an excellent understanding of how we fall into and are freed from cyclic existence. By becoming familiar with this, we will also free ourselves from the five wrong views.

Hatred is the mental affliction that gives rise to suffering and destroys the root of all positive deeds in the present as well as in future lives. We must always be diligent in ridding ourselves of hatred.

Attachment strengthens all the positive and negative deeds we have committed and allows them to actively become causes of cyclic existence. This can be remedied by those in the desire realm by constantly meditating upon the unpleasant internal and external nature of the attributes of this realm. Do not be overcome by faults, but arise victorious over all that is discordant with the path.

Here I have covered the stages of the path shared with persons of the medium scope with the text, *The Essence of the Stages of the Path*: Lamp Illuminating the Essential Instructions of the Stages of the Path of the Persons of the Medium Scope Based on the Outlines of The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment.

Those who see that sentient beings are tormented by suffering and engage laboriously in helping them are superior beings. They are the erudites, the source of all goodness, and the remedy for all that is detrimental. The great path followed by all superior beings is to nurture sentient beings just by seeing, hearing, touching, or recalling them. They are the ones who

skillfully accomplish their own purposes while engaging in the help of others. Finding a great vehicle such as this, followed by great beings, is excellent indeed, and with all the skill of a superior being, we should enter this path.

E.3: Training the mind in the stages of the path of the persons of great scope

Training the mind in the stages of the path of a person of great scope has three parts:

F.1: Establishing the mind of enlightenment as the only door to the Great Vehicle

F.2: How to cultivate the mind of enlightenment

F.3: How to engage in the practice after cultivating the mind of enlightenment

F.1: Establishing the mind of enlightenment as the only door to the Great Vehicle

The Buddha taught that there are two aspects to the Great Vehicle: the Great Vajrayana Vehicle and the Perfection Vehicle. Whichever of these we choose, the only door to either is the cultivation of the mind of enlightenment. Therefore, as long as we have cultivated that mind, even if we lack any other conditions, we will become followers of the Great Vehicle. The mind of enlightenment is the unique cause, like the seed for the sprout of *buddha*hood, and the wisdom of understanding emptiness is the common cause, like water and fertiliser for all three types of enlightenment. If we cultivate the mind of enlightenment genuinely, it can help reduce defilement and easily produce merit. The effect of that can also multiply the small positive deeds already accumulated while sustaining their effect.

F.2: How to cultivate the mind of enlightenment

This has four sections:

G.1: Causes and methods of cultivating the mind of enlightenment
G.2: The stages of Training in the mind of enlightenment
G.3: The measure of cultivation of the mind of enlightenment
G.4: How to retain the merits

G.1: Causes and methods of cultivating the mind of enlightenment

This has three sections:

I. Cultivation of the mind through the four conditions
II. Cultivation of the mind through the four causes
III. Cultivation of the mind through the four powers

I. Cultivation of the mind through the four conditions

A. Cultivation of the mind by witnessing or hearing of the power of the buddhas and *bodhisattva*s and thinking, "The state of perfection they abide in or seek is powerful."
B. Even without witnessing or hearing of their power, we can cultivate the mind just by hearing the teachings of the enlightened ones and by being inspired by their wisdom.
C. Although we may not have heard the teachings, just by seeing that the teachings can help numerous sentient beings, we can cultivate the mind to prevent the teachings from declining.
D. We may not see the danger of the declination of the teachings, but we can cultivate the mind of enlightenment

by knowing that in this time of darkness—in which the majority of beings are engaged in ignorance, shamelessness, unconscientiousness, jealousy, and miserliness—it is difficult to cultivate the minds of hearers and solitary-realizers, not to mention the mind of enlightenment.

II. Cultivation of the mind through the four causes

The four causes are: Excellent lineage; support from a virtuous teacher; compassion for sentient beings; and not fearing the hardship of cyclic existence.

III. Cultivation of the mind through the four powers

Cultivating the mind of enlightenment depends on four powers: *Personal will power* that wishes for the state of enlightenment; the *power of others* in wishing for the state of enlightenment; the *causal power* of cultivating the mind of enlightenment easily by hearing the *mantra* of altruistic awakening due to familiarisation with the practice of the Great Vehicle in previous lives; and the *power of familiarity* with the practice of virtuous deeds such as listening to the teachings of the masters and contemplating them.

Therefore, we should establish the basis for cultivating the mind through personal will power, for all the practices of the *bodhisattva*s depend on this.

G.2: The stages of Training in the mind of enlightenment

There are two ways of training in the mind of enlightenment:

H.1: The sevenfold cause and effect instruction transmitted from the great Atisha

H.2: Training by relying on the *bodhisattva* Shantideva's text of exchange of self and others

H.1: The sevenfold cause and effect instruction transmitted from the great Atisha

The seven stages of cause and effect are: Perfect enlightenment comes from the *mind of enlightenment*; that mind of enlightenment comes from *wholehearted resolve*, which comes from *compassion*, which comes from *loving-kindness*. Loving-kindness comes from a wish to *repay kindness*, which arises from remembering the *kindness of others*, while the remembrance of kindness comes from *seeing other beings as our mothers*.

First, in the transmission of Atisha, the teaching of the sevenfold stages of cause and effect has two parts:

I. Developing interest in the stages
II. The actual training in the stages

I. Developing interest in the stages

This has two sections:

A. Showing that 'compassion' is the root of the path of the Great Vehicle
B. How other causes and effects become its causes and effects

A. Showing that 'compassion' is the root of the path of the Great Vehicle

There are three ways to show how compassion is the root of the Great Vehicle:

i. Great Compassion is important at the beginning: Compassion motivates us to take the vow to liberate all sentient beings from the cycle of existence, and taking responsibility for freeing all sentient beings depends on the great compassion.

ii. Great compassion is important in the middle: Cultivating great compassion not just once but by repeated familiarisation with it will help in selflessly accomplishing the welfare of others without tiredness; this causes us to easily accumulate merit. This way, if we persistently apply effort to the difficult task, it will surely endow us with complete merit and lead to the attainment of enlightenment. Therefore, the root of all the teachings of the Buddha is great compassion.

iii. Great compassion is important at the end: It is with great compassion that the *buddha*s fulfil all their wishes but choose to remain until all sentient beings are free.

B. How other causes and effects become its causes and effects

How the recognition of all living beings as your mothers—through the development of love—acts as a cause of compassion is; generally, a wish to free sentient beings from suffering will arise just by reflecting repeatedly on their suffering. However, for that mind to arise easily and firmly, we first have to feel affection for these beings. Normally, we love our family and feel joy in seeing our enemies suffer, and if anything joyous or bad happens to those who are neutral, we dismiss it with a neutral feeling.

Accordingly, caring for sentient beings as our own relatives is to generate love. Since our mother is the closest of our relatives, we generate the view that all sentient beings are our mothers, recall their kindness, and cultivate the wish to repay this kindness. These three steps are the basis through which loving kindness is generated. Generating loving-kindness towards sentient beings as if they were our only child is the result of these steps. This generates great compassion.

The loving-kindness that wishes happiness for others and the compassion are not necessarily the karma. Therefore, these three steps, including recognising all beings as our mothers, are the basis for cultivating the compassion that wishes for beings to be free from suffering and the loving-kindness that wishes for beings to have happiness.

How wholehearted resolve and the generation of the mind of enlightenment become the results: It is not enough just to wish for all sentient beings to have happiness and be free from suffering; rather, we need to have the wholehearted resolve to take responsibility for the actualization of this wish. Therefore, with the support of compassion, we should cultivate a wholehearted resolve to free all sentient beings from suffering. With this resolve, seeing that we cannot do anything for even a single living being in the current state that we are in and that the number of sentient beings is countless, we will realise that it is only the enlightened ones who can help them, not just temporarily but for all the ultimate objectives. This leads to the generation of the wish to obtain enlightenment.

II. The actual training in the stages

This has three parts:

A. Training the mind to engage in the welfare of others
B. Training the mind in the pursuit of enlightenment
C. Recognising the mind of enlightenment as the result of the training

A. Training the mind to engage in the welfare of others

There are two parts to training the mind to engage in the welfare of others:

i. Laying the foundation for generating the mind
ii. The actual generation of the mind

i. Laying the foundation for generating the mind

This has two parts:

a. Generating equanimity towards sentient beings
b. Establishing all beings as objects of affection

a. Generating equanimity towards sentient beings

First, if we do not eliminate the biased mind that cares for some beings and has animosity for others, the generation of loving kindness and compassion will be biased. That will not happen if we aim to generate impartiality. Therefore, we must cultivate an unbiased mind.

The stages of cultivating an unbiased mind are to first generate the mind towards someone who has neither benefited nor harmed us, which makes it easier to get rid of anger and attachment. Having generated a neutral mindset towards those close to us, we can have a neutral mindset towards our enemies. If this is successful, then we can direct the same attitude towards all sentient beings.

How do we then eliminate attachment to them? We must contemplate the fact that sentient beings are all equal in their want of happiness and their aversion to suffering, and since the beginningless time, there has not been one being who has not been our relative. Thus, it ceases to make sense that we should be attached to some and hostile to others.

b. Establishing all beings as objects of affection

It is said that if we give the good field of mind the water of loving-kindness, which looks at all beings with affection, and sow the active seed of compassion, then, naturally, the great compassion will be cultivated easily. This is a very essential point.

There are three stages to this:

1. Recognising all sentient beings as having been our mothers
2. Recall the kindness of all sentient beings
3. Repaying kindness

1. Recognising all sentient beings as having been our mothers:

First of all, we should recognise all sentient beings as having been our mothers—as there is no beginning to cyclic existence, taking rebirth also has no beginning. We should contemplate how through continuously dying and being reborn over an inconceivable length of time, there is no living being that has not been our father, mother, brother, sister, abbot, or master, and develop the conviction that this is the case. Having understood this, it will be easier to recall the kindness of others—if we do not have this conviction, there will be no basis on which to recall their kindness.

2. Recall the kindness of all sentient beings:

To recall the kindness of all sentient beings, we should think of the kindness of our mother in this lifetime. Think of the number of times she has been our mother since beginningless time, and contemplate that while she has been so, she has protected us from all kinds of harm and given us all the necessities of life. Even in a lifetime, she carried us in her womb for a long time, and then at the time of birth, when our body was filled with messy yellowish-fine hairs, she warmed us with her flesh. She separated our ten fingers with her mouth, suckled us, fed us, and cleaned the mucus from our nose with her own mouth. With her own hands, she tirelessly cleaned the filth from us while making sure we were not uncomfortable. She gave us food, drink, clothing, and the wealth she cherishes, and wishing to die rather than see her child suffer from any illness, she was ever ready to suffer in place of her child. In short, think of how she put herself out there to provide the best for her child and to deflect any harm from us. If we can recall the kindness of our mother not just in words but from the depths of our hearts in this way, this may be extended to others who are close to us, such as our father, and then to those towards whom we feel neutral. If we can generate this feeling of closeness towards them, then we should cultivate the feeling of a mother towards our enemies and cultivate a memory of their kindness. And once we could develop this recognition of a mother towards them, then we should begin with the beings of the ten directions and then broaden the attitude to all sentient beings.

3. Repaying kindness:

For this, we must think that although our taking birth several times since has made them unrecognizable to us, our benevolent

mothers, without guidance, have been tormented by the demon of ignorance and are without freedom. Deprived of the wisdom that sees the path to the higher states and rebirths and lacking excellent teachers to lead them away from darkness, they constantly commit sins and accumulate downfalls, propelling them into cyclic existence. Especially in the lower rebirths, a mother needs the help of her child. With this in mind, we, the children, must help our mothers and free them from cyclic existence to repay her kindness.

ii. The actual generation of the mind

This has three parts:

a. Generating loving-kindness
b. Generating compassion
c. Generating wholehearted resolve

a. Generating loving-kindness

To generate loving-kindness, the object we should focus on is those beings that do not have happiness. The nature of the mind of loving-kindness is the wish for them to be happy. We should think, 'How wonderful it would be if they were happy, and that, we will make them happy.'

The benefits we gain from loving-kindness are so much more meritorious than those we gain from making everyday offerings to the ultimate objects of reverence.

The stages of cultivating loving-kindness begin with the development of the mind towards those we are close to, then towards those with whom we are neutral, followed by our enemies, and finally all sentient beings. By constantly contemplating how sentient beings are deprived of contaminated

and uncontaminated happiness and how they are destroyed by it, the thought becomes familiar, and naturally, the wish for their happiness arises. We should then see the various ways of obtaining happiness and offer them to sentient beings.

b. Generating great compassion

To generate compassion, the object of focus should be sentient beings that are oppressed by any of the three types of suffering. The nature of the mind of compassion is the wish for beings to be free of suffering. We should think about how wonderful it would be if they were free of suffering and how we would free them from it.

The stages of cultivating compassion are: first, we must generate the feeling towards those whom we are close to, then towards neutral beings, and then towards our enemies. Once we have developed the mind of compassion equally towards those we are close to and our enemies, then we should maintain that mind towards all sentient beings in the ten directions.

The way we cultivate the mind of compassion is to contemplate how mother sentient beings and we ourselves suffer in cyclic existence. Having the thought about ourselves will cultivate renunciation, and having it about others will generate compassion, but if we do not think of our own suffering first, we will not generate a proper mind. The power of generating the mind of both compassion and loving-kindness is much stronger and firmer if we contemplate for an extended time every way in which beings lack happiness and are overwrought by suffering. Otherwise, being satisfied with briefly hearing some instructions and not doing a thorough study of the voluminous treatises, the mind we cultivate will be very weak. As mentioned already, the door to the Great Vehicle is the cultivation of the mind

of enlightenment, and great compassion is the root of that. Therefore, we should have an experiential understanding of these, with a clear objective and realisation through discriminative wisdom. Without a clear understanding, impelled by momentary persistence, we will not get anywhere. The same goes for all practices.

The measure of having cultivated great compassion is to have generated a full-fledged compassion, the same compassion 'that a mother has for her only beloved child' towards all sentient beings. This should also explain the measure of cultivating great loving-kindness. By the power of familiarity with great compassion and vowing to lead all sentient beings to liberation, the mind of enlightenment, which aspires to obtain the perfect state, will be generated automatically. It is said that the generation of the aspiring mind of enlightenment needs to be cultivated through great compassion, and this defines the measure of cultivation of the mind of enlightenment.

c. Generating wholehearted resolve

To generate wholehearted resolve, after cultivating great compassion and loving-kindness, one should think, 'Alas! The sentient beings who care and love me are in suffering and do not have happiness. How can I best help them obtain happiness and eliminate their suffering? And to take responsibility, one should cultivate the mind, even through mere words. That too should not be temporary only at the time of meditation. The power of merit is greater if one could hold this in mind in all aspects of daily life, such as even after meditation sessions. This should be the same whenever one sustains focus on an object.

B. Training the mind in the pursuit of enlightenment

Encouraged by the stages that are explained above, we will see the importance of obtaining enlightenment to help others. We will have the desire to cultivate that mind. However, it is not enough just to have the thought. We must begin by reflecting on the qualities of achievement in the body, speech, and mind of the enlightened ones to increase our faith, for faith acts as the basis of aspiration. Then we would have the wholehearted wish to obtain those qualities, with the ascertainment that achieving enlightenment is indispensable for our own sake as well.

C. Recognising the mind of enlightenment as the result of the training

Whether or not we engage in deeds such as generosity and so forth, if we aspire to become enlightened for the sake of sentient beings or resolve to do so until we take the *bodhisattva* vow, we are adopting the *aspiring mind of enlightenment*. Once we take the *bodhisattva* vow, the *engaging mind of enlightenment* commences.

H.2: Training by relying on Shantideva's Treatise

There are three sections to this:

I. The benefits of exchanging self and others and the defects of not exchanging self and others:

We should contemplate the fact that cherishing ourselves is the door to all degeneration, and cherishing others is the source of all excellence.

II. Showing that the method of exchanging self and others is accomplishable through familiarisation:

If we can befriend someone who was at an earlier time our chief enemy and feel sad in the absence of that person, then we can surely cherish others as we cherish ourselves and see ourselves as others through familiarisation.

III. The steps to meditate on the method of exchanging self and others:

We have to exchange an attitude that cherishes the self with an attitude that disregards others. In this way, we can cherish others the way we formerly cherished ourselves and disregard ourselves in the same way we disregarded others before. In short, we engage in the act of benefiting others instead of our own happiness.

While cultivating this attitude, there are two obstructions: Thinking that the persons, who are the basis of suffering and happiness are individuals and differently established, like the colours blue and yellow. Accordingly, with regard to happiness and suffering, we tend to procure or eliminate those that are ours, while ignoring those that we think of as belonging to others. The remedy for this misconception is knowing that self and others are not different entities, for they are established in dependence upon each other like the front and back sides of a mountain, which generate the mind that sees others as oneself and oneself as the other.

After eliminating the obstructions, we can cultivate the actual mind that exchanges self and others. Cherishing the self, due to attachment, has caused all our unwanted suffering since the beginningless time until now. Therefore, even while striving

to accomplish something good for oneself, because we have always given priority to ourselves in the wrong way, we are unsuccessful in fulfilling either our own or other objectives, even after endless aeons. Apart from not fulfilling our objective, this has also caused us to suffer more. If we had exchanged others with ourselves, we would have long ago obtained the state of enlightenment and would have easily achieved all our own and others' objectives. However, since we have not, the efforts and the time have passed meaninglessly.

This self-cherishing attitude should be rejected with mindfulness and introspection. Stop it from arising, and with certainty, diligently refuse to let it continue if it has already arisen. Without favouring self-centeredness and not sustaining the interests of those who are close to us, we should repeatedly develop the practice of unconditionally offering our bodies, wealth, and merits for the benefit of sentient beings. If we let this practice slip and incline towards self-centeredness or begin to harm others through acts of body, speech, and mind, this is an error that has caused immense harm to us before, though it has been continuously seen as a source of benefit. If we fall into this error, there will be unbearable suffering. Knowing this, we should prevent such an error from occurring. We should contemplate the benefit of cherishing others constantly, rejoice in cultivating the attitude if it has not yet arisen, and increase it if it has arisen by viewing others in the most caring, affectionate, and loving way possible in the same way as we have formerly done for ourselves.

To cultivate the mind that cherishes sentient beings, we should remember their kindness or how they are helpful for us. In the same way we would cherish a field that gives us a good harvest when sown with excellent seeds, the field of sentient

beings sown with the excellent seeds of virtuous deeds such as generosity will give us both temporary and lasting goodness. Being certain of that will cultivate a mind that cherishes others. We must contemplate this.

Therefore, understand that engaging in others' welfare and the resultant unexcelled enlightenment are generated by the sprout of the awakening mind of enlightenment, the root of which is great compassion. Seeing this, the sons of the Buddha should strenuously meditate on it. Once it becomes familiar and consistent, we will be able to engage effortlessly in even the most arduous of practices.

G.3: The measure of cultivating the mind of enlightenment:

This should be understood from the above explanation

G.4: How to retain the mind of enlightenment with ritual

After mind training, when we gain certainty about cultivating the mind of enlightenment, we should perform rituals to maintain that certainty.

There are three rituals:

H.1: Obtaining the unattained
H.2: Sustaining what has been attained
H.3: Repairing violations

H.1: Obtaining the unattained

This has three parts:

I. The person in front of whom you adopt the mind
II. The individual who adopts the mind
III. How to proceed with the rituals

I. The person in front of whom you adopt the mind

This should be a master who has received the complete *bodhisattva* vow.

II. The individual who adopts the mind

The person should be someone who has practised the stages of the path that are explained above and has some experience of inclination towards the mind of enlightenment.

III. How to proceed with the rituals

This has three parts:

A. Preparation
B. The actual ritual
C. The conclusion

A. Preparation

Preparation has three sections:

i. The special practice of taking refuge
ii. The accumulation of merit
iii. Purifying the Mind

i. The special practice of taking refuge

This has three stages:

a. Adorning the space—setting up objects of refuge and arranging the offerings
b. Supplication and taking refuge
c. Reciting precepts after taking refuge

a. Adorning the space—setting up objects of refugee and arranging the offerings:

Away from the people who are sinful, in a plain and clean place, anoint the space with water scented with the five cow products[41], fragrances of sandalwood and so forth. Strew aromatic flower pedals, and amid this space, place the representations of the three jewels. Prepare the best offerings obtainable, set up a throne for the spiritual masters, and adorn it with flowers. Among the objects of offering, there should be a valuable image of the founder of the lineage, the Buddha. Moreover, the scripture should be bigger than the *Verse Summary of the Perfection of Wisdom*. Then call in the noble beings and say the *Cloud of Offerings Mantra* three times to praise them. After that, the disciple should bathe and don clean clothes, fold their palms together, and evoke pure reverence for the qualities of the great teachers from within their hearts. Visualising oneself bowing before each *buddha* and *bodhisattva*, perform the seven limbs of the preliminary practice.

b. Supplication and taking refuge:

Since it is said that one should perceive one's teacher as the *buddha* with the wish to obtain enlightenment, one should prostrate and make a *mandala* offering along with the other offerings. Kneeling upon the right knee with our palms pressed together, pray for the ultimate perfection. While praying, we should say thrice: "Just as the victorious, transcendent *buddha* and the heroic *bodhisattvas* who entered the great grounds have aspired to the unsurpassable enlightenment, may I (one's name) be able to cultivate the complete mind of enlightenment.

41 Urine, dung, butter, milk, and yogurt GTSPE Vol. II p 63

With this special intent, I take refuge in the three objects—the *buddha*, the *dharma*, which is the great vehicle of the truth of the path of the essential cessation, and the *sangha*, the non-returner *bodhisattva*s. To protect all sentient beings, until enlightenment, I take the *buddha* as master, the *dharma* as the actual teaching, and the *sangha* as spiritual friends."

With great motivation, still on bended knee, go for refuge, reciting three times: "Oh master, please heed me! I (one's name), from now until I obtain perfect enlightenment, go for refuge to the *buddha*, supreme among bipeds. Oh master, please heed me! I (one's name), from now until I obtain perfect enlightenment, go for refuge in the supreme doctrine, the *dharma* that is free from attachment. Oh master, please heed me! I (one's name), from now until I obtain perfect enlightenment, go for refuge to the supreme assembly, the *sangha* of the non-returning excellent *bodhisattva*s."

c. Reciting precepts after taking refuge:

The teacher recites the same precepts as given to persons of small scope.

ii. The accumulation of merit

As mentioned before, recalling all the *buddhas, bodhisattvas,* and teachers of the past and present, perform the seven-limb preliminary practices.

iii. Purifying the mind:

Visualise the objects and the aspects of loving-kindness and compassion.

B. The actual ritual:

In front of your teacher, put the cap of one's right knee on the ground or in an upright posture, and generate the mind of enlightenment—this is done not just by thinking that we will attain enlightenment for the sake of sentient beings, but in order to generate that mind, we should steadfastly hold onto the correct commitment that we will not part with that mind until enlightenment. This thought is cultivated through the performance of the ritual. Those who do not engage in generosity and such positive deeds can still cultivate the mind of enlightenment, but they are not suitable vessels to receive the *bodhisattva* vow.

The ritual for mind cultivation is to recite three times: "*buddhas* and *bodhisattvas* of the ten directions, please heed me! Oh master, please heed me! By the merit of whatever virtuous deeds that are by nature generous, ethical, or meditative that I (one's name) have done, have encouraged others to do, or have rejoiced in doing in the past, just as the former victorious tathagatas[42] who were completely enlightened and the heroic *bodhisattva*s of the great ground have cultivated the unsurpassable mind of enlightenment, may I (one's name), from now until I obtain the perfect essence, be able to cultivate the unsurpassable mind of enlightenment, may I be able to liberate beings that are not liberated, free beings that are not free yet, relieve those who need relieving, and cause those who have not yet passed into nirvana to obtain nirvana"

Both this ritual and that of taking refuge should be repeated after the master. Even without a master, we should perform the rituals and say the vows by visualising the *buddha* and the

42 Tathagata (Skt.): 'Thus-gone' Same as a fully enlightened Buddha.

tathagathas of all the ten directions. Leave out the word 'master' and follow the rest of the vow to take refuge step by step.

C. Conclusion

At the conclusion, the master will enumerate the precepts of the aspirational mind of enlightenment.

H.2: Sustaining what has been attained

This requires knowledge of the precepts which I explain here in two sections:

I. Adopting the cause of keeping the mind of enlightenment from degenerating in this life
II. Adopting the cause of not being separated from the mind of enlightenment in future lives

I. Adopting the cause of keeping the mind of enlightenment from degenerating in this life

This has four parts:

A. Learning the benefits of the mind of enlightenment that generate joy in cultivation
B. Practising the cultivation of the mind six times to generate the actual mind of enlightenment
C. Learning not to give up on the sentient beings for whom one is cultivating the mind of enlightenment
D. Practising the accumulation of merit and wisdom

A. Learning the benefits of the mind of enlightenment that generate joy in cultivation

This is done by listening to the teachers or reading *sutra* texts about the benefits of cultivating the mind of enlightenment and contemplating it.

B. Practising the cultivation of the mind six times to generate the actual mind of enlightenment

This has two parts:

i. Not losing the aspirational mind of enlightenment that has already been cultivated
ii. Increasing the aspirational mind of enlightenment

i. Not losing the aspirational mind of enlightenment that has already been cultivated:

We should hold onto this mind by thinking about how wonderful it is that we have been able to cultivate it. By focusing on this thought, you contentiously commit to it.

ii. Increasing the aspirational mind of enlightenment:

It is not enough just to not let go of this mind; it has to be increased by being strenuously cultivated three times each day and three times each night. This is preceded by performing the aforementioned detailed ritual. If this ritual is not performed, then we must visualise the field of merit, make offerings, and practise positive thoughts such as compassion and loving-kindness six times. The ritual for this is reciting the refuge prayer three times: "I go for refuge until I attain enlightenment, to the *buddha*, *dharma*, and *sangha*..." and so forth.

C. Learning not to give up on the sentient beings for whom one is cultivating the mind of enlightenment

By caring about sentient beings and not giving up on them, we retain the object of cultivating the mind of enlightenment and its benefits, and similarly, we adopt its rituals without negligence. The measure of giving up is arising thoughts such as "now I will never again help this being" based on conditions like the other's unacceptable actions.

D. Practising the accumulation of merit and wisdom

From the moment we adopt the ritual of generating the aspiring mind of enlightenment, we should strenuously engage in virtuous deeds, such as making offerings to the Three Jewels and so forth.

II. Adopting the cause of not being separated from the mind of enlightenment in the future lives

This has two parts:

A. Abandoning the four negative activities that degenerate the mind
B. Adopting the four positive activities that cultivate the mind

A. Abandoning the four negative activities that degenerate the mind:

i. We must abandon attempts to deceive the abbot, master, or object of our offering with lies.
ii. Making other people who have no regret over positive work feel regret about things they should not feel regret about

iii. Saying unscrupulous things to *bodhisattva*s.
iv. Deceiving others with inappropriate intent

B. Adopting the four positive activities that cultivate the mind

i. Not lying to other sentient beings, even in jest or at the cost of one's own life
ii. Being wholeheartedly honest with other sentient beings and abandoning deceptive motives
iii. Cultivating faith in other sentient beings by seeing them as teachers
iv. Ushering those beings who are the recipients of one's teaching towards complete enlightenment rather than mere liberation

It is said that by practising these four positive activities, we will not be separated from the mind of enlightenment even in sleep. Moreover, deeds such as reducing pride, clearing away jealousy and stinginess, and finding the four kinds of joy in seeing others' enjoyments will help maintain the mind of enlightenment. We should always act with the mind of enlightenment, and every positive action should be imbued with that mind so that we will never part with this precious attitude, even in our future lives.

H.3: Repairing violations

Apart from maintaining the aspiring mind of enlightenment and not forsaking sentient beings, if we violate the remaining precepts before we take the *bodhisattva* vow, we may not commit the downfalls of a true *bodhisattva*. However, we will have violated the intermediate precepts, which require repair, and

this is done through the four opponent powers. After receiving the *bodhisattva* vow, violating any of the precepts will spoil the vow and will have to be repaired only as per the instructions of the engaging mind of enlightenment. However, the practice of generating the mind of enlightenment six times a day is the exclusive precept of the aspirational mind of enlightenment.

F.3: How to engage in the practice after cultivating the mind of enlightenment

This has three parts:

G.1: The reasons for engaging in the practice after cultivating the mind of enlightenment
G.2: The impossibility of obtaining *buddha*hood by relying on only one of either the method or the wisdom
G.3: The actual stages of engaging in the practice

G.1: The reasons for engaging in the practice after cultivating the mind of enlightenment

Without taking the training as the core practice, we will not be able to achieve enlightenment. Therefore, to obtain enlightenment, we must practise the methods that lead to enlightenment.

G.2: The impossibility of obtaining buddhahood by relying on only one of either the method or the wisdom

The exalted wisdom of the all-knowing *buddha* has come from the root of compassion, the cause of the mind of enlightenment, and is completed by the method. Compassion has already been explained. The mind of enlightenment has two types: The conventional and ultimate minds of enlightenment. The method

is perfecting the way with generosity and so forth. Therefore, if we wish to obtain enlightenment, we have to rely on both wisdom and method. One without the other will not accomplish anything.

G.3: The actual stages of engaging in the practice

This has two parts:

H.1: How to train in the general path of the Great-vehicle
H.2: How to train specifically in the Diamond Vehicle

H.1: How to train in the general path of the Great Vehicle

This has three parts:

I.1: Generating the desire to engage in the stages of the path of the Great Vehicle
I.2: Taking the Bodhisattva Vow
I.3: How to practise after taking the vow

I.1: Generating the desire to engage in the stages of the path of the Great Vehicle:

In the practice of Vinaya[43] and the Vajrayana, we cannot listen to the instructions until we have taken the vows. In this case, it is different. We must first understand the precepts fully, and then, focusing the mind on the object, cultivate a genuine desire to train in the precepts. This way, the vow we take becomes unwaveringly firm. This is a good method.

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43 Pali and (Skt.) literally meaning 'leading out', 'education', 'discipline' is the regulatory framework for the monastic community of Buddhism based on the canonical texts called the Vinaya Pitaka /basket of discipline.

I.2: Taking the Bodhisattva Vow:

As explained in the section on ethical discipline, as a prerequisite, we must first be informed about how to receive the vow, followed immediately by how to restrain from committing root downfalls and offences, and how to repair the vows if violated.

I.3: How to practise after taking the vow

This has three parts:

J.1: The basis of the practices
J.2: How the practices are encompassed in the six perfections
J.3: The stages of practising the six perfections

J.1: The basis of the practices

There are numerous categories of subjects for the practices. However, all of them fall within the categories of the six perfections, or the precepts of the mind of enlightenment. The four great methods of attracting disciples, stated in the essential points of the path of cultivating the mind of enlightenment, can be said to be contained within the six perfections: *generosity* is easy to understand; *speaking pleasantly* is teaching the six perfections to disciples; *helping sentient beings* is leading others to practise what we teach; and *consistency* is practising what one preaches to the disciples. Although the two types of accumulations and the three tranings also comprise the entire paths of the *bodhisattva*, no other classification can give a better understanding than the six perfections, for this is the best way of condensing the subjects.

J.2: How the practices are encompassed in the six perfections

This has two parts:

I. Actual topic, ascertaining the number of perfections
II. Secondarily, ascertaining the order of the perfections

I. Actual topic, ascertaining the number of perfections

This has six sections:

A. Ascertained number based on obtaining higher status
B. Ascertained number based on accomplishing the two types of welfare
C. Ascertained number based on perfect fulfilment of others welfare
D. Ascertained number based on how they cover the entire Great Vehicle
E. Ascertained number based on the completeness of the necessary paths or methods
F. Ascertained number based on the three trainings

A. Ascertained number based on obtaining higher status

We want a life with resources and company to enjoy. Our entire endeavour should be accomplished. Furthermore, we should not be overpowered by affliction and have a clear understanding of the object of abandonment and adoption. Obtaining these six attributes in the future life is not possible without causes, and discordant causes. Since the only coherent causes are the six perfections, we should always act in accordance with the six perfections in the present life and become constantly familiar with them. The more familiar we are with the causes, the more

powerful the effect will be. These are temporary higher status. The ultimate high status, such as an excellent body, is obtained only in the realm of *buddha*s.

B. Ascertained number based on accomplishing the two types of welfare

To achieve others welfare, we must first show material generosity. Generosity motivated by harmful intent will be of no benefit and will cause harm to the object of the benefit. That needs ethical discipline, abiding by the object of harm, etc. To be able to accomplish that, we should have the patience to treat the harm inflicted upon us indifferently. To achieve our own welfare, we need to have the power of wisdom, which brings ultimate liberation and happiness. To gain that wisdom, we must have the meditative equipoise that can focus the mind on any object with ease. This requires persistent effort, day and night. Therefore, the six perfections are necessary to accomplish the two types of welfare.

C. Ascertained number based on perfect fulfilment of others welfare

Using material generosity, we first help others to be free from poverty. Then we should practise not harming beings of any type. Moreover, we should be patient with those who do us harm. By helping them, we engage in effort. Then we should make them suitable vessels for the *dharma* through the miraculous power of meditative concentration. With wisdom, we should skillfully teach them, and by eliminating the confusion, we should free them. This is all accomplished with the six perfections.

D. Ascertained number based on how they cover the entire Great Vehicle

This refers to not getting attached to wealth that we do not have and not being tempted to find ways to obtain it. If we adopt such behaviour, then we can preserve the training, and with our respect for ethical discipline, which can stop us from being disheartened with living beings and non-living things by being patient, we can engage in every kind of virtuous deed enthusiastically without becoming discouraged. Followed by the practice of meditation on non-conceptual calm-abiding and special-insight, these six include the entire Mahayana teachings. And they are accomplished in accordance with the stages of the practice of the six perfections.

E. Ascertained number based on the completeness of the necessary paths or methods

To avoid attachment to the wealth we may have already acquired, we should engage in generosity. As it becomes a habit, we become detached from our wealth. To avert the desire to obtain things that we do not have, we should abide by the ethical discipline of the fully ordained. This will block all sorts of limiting distractions. To behold sentient beings without being discouraged, the best method is to have patience—the mind that bears all sorts of harm without letting it disturb our mental state. The best way to increase virtue is with diligent effort; enthusiasm increases virtue. The way to completely eliminate obstructions is through the practice of the last two perfections: meditative concentration, which eliminates affliction; and wisdom, which clears away the obstruction to omniscience. For this, the six perfections are necessary.

F. Ascertained number based on the three trainings:

The nature of the training of ethical discipline is observing discipline. Giving resources generously without expectation makes the practice excellent, as this is the basis of ethical discipline. Sustaining such an excellent practice with patience against abuses by not reiterating and so forth are the parts of this practice. Meditative concentration is mental training, and wisdom is training in wisdom. Effort is included in all three trainings, and in this way, the perfections are six in number.

II. Secondarily, ascertaining the order of the perfections

This has three parts:

A. The order of arising
B. The order of superiority
C. The order of subtlety

A. The order of arising:

Having generosity without expectation and attachment engages in ethical discipline, and the ethical discipline that restrains perfectly from negative action gives rise to the patience that can bear any harm. Such patience that does not fear any difficulties leaves little cause for degeneration; therefore, it gives rise to diligence, and if we diligently focus our minds on virtuous deeds day and night, this will generate useful meditative concentration that can direct the mind to virtuous objects. When the mind is in equanimity, realisation of the ultimate reality occurs as it is.

B. The order of superiority:

Each practice is superior to the one preceding it.

C. The order of subtlety:

The former practices are easier to engage in and perform than the later ones; therefore, since the latter are more difficult to engage in and perform, each is more subtle than the preceding one.

J.3: The stages of practising the six perfections

This has two parts:

K.1: Training in the general practice (of a *bodhisattva*)
K.2: Especially training in the last two perfections

K.1 Training in the general practice

This has two parts:

L.1: Training in the perfections to ripen one's own qualities of enlightenment
L.2: Training in the four means of gathering disciples to ripen others continuum

L.1: Training in the perfections to ripen one's own qualities of enlightenment

This has six parts:

M.1: The training of perfection of generosity
M.2: The training of perfection of discipline
M.3: The training of perfection of patience
M.4: The training of perfection of effort
M.5: The training of perfection of meditative concentration
M.6: The training of perfection of wisdom

M.1: The Training in perfection of generosity

This has four parts:

I. The nature of generosity
II. The method of cultivating generosity
III. The types of generosity
IV. Summary of the points

I. The nature of generosity

It is the virtuous mind of giving and all acts of body and speech that are motivated by it.

II. The method of cultivating generosity

We need to generate a thorough wish to give away all that we possess and contemplate the benefits of giving as well as the faults of holding onto possessions.

III. There are three types of generosity

A. Types of generosity based on how everyone should practise
B. Types of generosity based on the individual practitioner
C. Types of generosity based on actual giving

A. Types of Generosity based on how everyone should practise

This has two divisions:

i. The practitioners must engage in generosity with the six excellences

ii. The practitioners must engage in generosity with the six perfections

i. The practitioners must engage in generosity with the six excellences

a. The excellent basis is the mind of enlightenment; one needs to be fully motivated by it.
b. Excellent object: Generally, this includes all objects of generosity. Even where special objects are concerned, we must not abandon the generous mind.
c. Excellent objective: When giving, we must give with the wish to bring sentient beings immediate happiness and lasting benefit.
d. Excellent method: This refers to having non-conceptual exalted wisdom; for beginners, this should be the wisdom of realising the lack of inherent nature of phenomena.
e. Excellent dedication: The merit gained by practising generosity should be dedicated to perfect enlightenment.
f. Excellent purity: The cessation of afflictions and defilements that obstruct wisdom.

ii. The practitioners must engage in generosity with the six perfections

In performing generosity such as that of giving teaching, we should have disciplines that restrain one from the concerns of the hearers and solitary-realizers. We need patience to develop conviction in the teachings of omniscience and bear the abuses of others. We must practise diligence for the higher and higher development of this very generous mind, and we need meditative stabilisation that dedicates the virtues of the single-pointed

mind unassociated with views of the lower vehicle for complete enlightenment. And finally, we need to have the wisdom to realise that the object and subject of generosity both are like illusions. Applying the six perfections will generate immense power.

B. Types of generosity based on the individual practitioner

These are primarily the acts of giving teaching by ordained *bodhisattva*s and material generosity performed by lay *bodhisattva*s.

C. Types of generosity based on actual giving:

The generosity of the *dharma* is correctly teaching the excellent doctrine.

i. The generosity of fearlessness is to protect sentient beings from human-and non-human-induced harm, such as kings and robbers.
ii. The generosity of material goods

This has two parts:

a. Generosity of the actual giving of material goods
b. Merely mental generosity

a. Generosity in actual giving of material goods

This has three parts:

1. How to give material goods
2. What to do if one is unable to give material goods
3. Relying on the remedies that clear the obstructions to engage in generosity

1. How to give material good

This has four parts:

1.a: To whom to give
1.b: The intention with which we give
1.c: How to practise giving
1.d: What material to give

1.a To whom to give

There are ten recipients for material goods: our enemies, friends, and neutral people; those with qualities and those with faults; those who are inferior, superior, or equal to us; the fortunate and the unfortunate.

1.b The attitudes with which we should give

There are two aspects to the attitudes with which we should engage in generosity:

1.b.i. The kind of intentions should one have
1.b.ii. The kind of motivation to abandon

1.b.i. The intention with which we give

There are two types of intentions we need to have: three general motivations and four particular intentions. The three general intentions are: an intention of focusing on the objective, which is to engage in the perfection of generosity; the merit to obtain unsurpassable enlightenment; an intention of focusing on the object, which is to see our own wealth as other; and an intention of focusing on the recipient of our generosity, which is to see them as our teacher in showing us the way towards the complete

perfection of generosity. Regarding the particular intentions, we should engage in generosity with an intention of kindness toward those causing harm; compassion for those who are suffering; joy toward those who have positive qualities; and equanimity towards benefactors.

1.b.ii. The kind of intentions to abandon

There are seven intentions that we should abandon when engaging in generosity:

1.b.ii.1) We should be free from the intention that holds wrong views as superior, such as thinking that there is no use in engaging in generosity or engaging in harmful generosity, thinking it will bring merit.

1.b.ii.2) We should abandon the attitude of arrogance, such as insulting beggars or giving only for competition.

1.b.ii.3) We should be free from the wish for support, which is giving without ulterior motives of obtaining fame.

1.b.ii.4) We should not give reluctantly—before we engage in generosity we should feel joy, and at the time of giving and after parting with the gift, we give without regret or such.

1.b.ii.5) We should abandon bias and give impartially to friends, enemies, and people in general.

1.b.ii.6) We should not give with the hope of receiving, expecting others to give us something in return.

1.b.ii.7) We should abandon giving with the hope of good results and rather engage in generosity without the intention of obtaining prosperity and bodily perfection in the next life.

1.c: How to practise giving

There are two aspects to how we should practise giving

1.c.i. How not to give
1.c.ii. How to give

1.c.i. How not to give

We should abandon these ways of giving, such as procrastinating the time to give without being prompt, giving only after stressing out the recipient, giving to make others engage in worldly or spiritually unethical actions, etc.

1.c.ii. How to give

We should practise generosity with a radiant face, smiling and speaking sincerely. Regardless of who the recipient is, with respect, we should give with our own hands, in a timely way, without causing harm to others, and by bearing all hardship.

1.d: What materials to give

There are two parts to this:

1.d.i. A brief overview of what to give and what not to give
1.d.ii. A detailed explanation

1.d.i A brief overview of what to give and what not to give

We should give what will be beneficial at the time of giving and in the future, or what will benefit the recipient in times to come. If what we can give is not beneficial for both the present and the future, or just the future, then we should not give it.

1.d.ii. A detailed explanation

There are two things to consider;

1.d.ii.1). Which of the internal materials are to be given and which are not
1.d.ii.2). Which of the external materials are and which are not to be given

1.d.ii.1). Which of the internal materials are to be given and which are not?

There are three particulars concerning which of the internal materials are to be given and which are not.

In terms of time, for example, we cannot give things like our own flesh, even when asked, if we have not yet cultivated the mind of enlightenment.

In terms of necessity, we should not give our bodies for minor purposes.

In terms of recipients, we should not give our body parts and the like to evil gods and the souls possessed by them, as they have harmful intent. Apart from these occasions, we can

give our body or its parts at any time and commit ourselves to servitude for the fulfilment of the spiritual objectives of others.

1.d.ii.2) Which of the external materials are and which are not to be given

Concerning which of the external materials are and which are not to be given,
There are two parts:

1.d.ii.2.a): How not to give external materials
1.d.ii.2.b): How to give external materials

1.d.ii.1.a): How not to give external materials

There are five ways in which we should not engage in giving external materials:

1.d.ii.1.a.i): *Not giving in terms of time* means, for example, not giving evening meals to the ordained or to those who have taken one-day vows.

1.d.ii.1.a.ii): *Not giving in terms of the recipient* means not giving scraps or food contaminated with defecation, saliva, mucus, vomit, pus, or blood, or garlic, onion, and beer, to vow holders; not giving our children or servants to vicious evil gods; and not giving *dharma* texts to non-Buddhists who are looking to find fault in the doctrine or to those who have the intention of using them not for learning but to make money.

1.d.ii.1.a.iii): *Not giving in terms of the base* means, for instance, not giving away *dharma* texts without the taint of miserliness to others who are asking for them out of a desire for knowledge at a time when we have not yet grasped the purpose of it.

1.d.ii.1.a.iv): *Not giving in terms of the object* means not giving away our parents, food and drinks containing bugs, or the three robes of the ordained ones, and so forth.

1.d.ii.1.a.v): *Not giving in terms of necessity* refers to not giving poison, weapons, fire, and alcohol to those who are asking for them for the sake of harming themselves or others.

1.d.ii.2.b): How to give external materials

When it comes to giving external materials, other than the times and bases that the Buddha has advised us to avoid and the persons for whom the gift is not suitable, we should engage in generosity whenever we can.

2. What to do if one is unable to give away material goods:

When someone asks us for something that we do not feel we can part with, we should think that we are going to have to part with it at some stage anyway, so instead of waiting for that eventuality, we should part with it right now in a meaningful way and happily prepare for death. This way, when death comes, we will not be attached to wealth and will not feel regret but rather delight and satisfaction.

3. Relying on the remedies that clear the obstructions to engage in generosity

There are four obstructions in the way of engaging in generosity, as shown in Asanga's *Compendium of Ascertainments*:

3.a *Non-habituation*, which is due to a lack of familiarity with generosity in previous lives.

3.b *Disadvantage*—due to a lack of possessions, we cannot afford to give.

3.c *Attachment*—due to our attachment to its beauty and excellence, we are unable to part with an object.

3.d *Not seeing the result*, which is not engaging in generosity because we cannot see the benefit of obtaining the state of perfection.

b. Merely mental generosity

We find a quiet place where, collecting our minds inwardly with a genuine desire and devotion from the depths of the heart, we visualise all sorts of material goods in great quantities and imagine giving them to sentient beings.

V. Summary of the points

We should take the Bodhisattva Vows with the aspiration to train in the practice of high-level generosity and start practising the

types of generosity explained above immediately by knowing what is permitted and what is prohibited. In particular, by relying on the antidote to miserliness of body, wealth, and virtue, we should put effort into increasing the desire to give and generating joy for these practices.

M.2: The training of perfection of ethical discipline

There are five aspects of the ethical discipline:

I. The nature of ethical discipline
II. The method of cultivation
III. The types of ethical discipline
IV. How to practice when accomplishing them
V. Summary of the points

I. Nature of ethical discipline:

Perfect ethical discipline is the mind that wishes not to harm others and abandons the basis of harming others. This way, we become familiar with that mind and can obtain higher and higher levels of practice.

II. The method of cultivating ethical discipline:

Having generated the mind of enlightenment and vowed to engage in the practices, we have promised to establish all sentient beings in the complete ethical discipline of the Buddha, and we must work for that.

III. The types of ethical discipline:

There are three types of ethical discipline:

A. Ethical discipline of restraint
B. Ethical discipline of accumulating virtue
C. Ethical discipline of working for the welfare of sentient beings

A. Ethical discipline of restraint:

Ethical discipline of restraint entails preserving the actual vows of the individual liberation and those to abandon and adopt that are common with these vows.

B. Ethical discipline of accumulating virtue

By focusing on the virtues of the six perfections and so forth, we generate the virtues that are yet to be cultivated, sustain those we have, and increase them.

C. Ethical discipline of working for the welfare of sentient beings

By aiming for the welfare of the eleven types of beings[5], we work unmistakenly for their present and future lives in the way best suitable for them.

IV. How to practice when accomplishing them

Ethical discipline should be practised through the six excellences and the six perfections. The generosity of ethical discipline is establishing others in ethical discipline after we have stabilised ourselves in it. The rest are as explained previously.

V. Summary of the points

The essence of practice like ethical discipline is to cultivate the mind of enlightenment, which is the basis of conduct, and prevent it from degenerating. This is also the best way to abstain from harming sentient beings. While practising, we should aim for ethical disciplines of the higher levels. The beginner practitioners should sincerely strive to train in the precepts of ethical discipline about what to adopt and what to abandon right away, especially those that we know are wrong by nature, such as the ten virtuous deeds, making progress each day in increasing the attitude of restraint repeatedly and particularly against the root downfalls of the vows.

M.3: Training for the perfection of patience

There are five aspects to the perfection of patience:

I. The nature of patience
II. The method of cultivating patience
III. The types of patience
IV. How to practice when accomplishing them
V. Summary of the points

I. Nature of patience:

The nature of patience is disregarding those who inflict harm on us, accepting suffering, and being tolerant in our search for the truth—in which we must remain deeply faithful. To attain perfection of patience, we must become completely familiar with the practice of patience regarding emotions such as anger.

II. Methods to cultivate patience:

We must contemplate the benefits of patience and the defects of not having patience.

III. The types of patience:

There are three types of patience:

A. The patience to disregard those who harm us
B. The patience to accept suffering
C. Patience to practice the teaching with conviction

A. The patience to disregard those who harm us

This has two aspects:

i. Resisting impatience towards those who harm us
ii. Resisting impatience towards the prosperity of the agent of harm or rejoicing in their downfall.

i. Resisting impatience towards those who harm us

This also has two sub-categories:

a. Resisting impatience towards those who cause impediments in the path to happiness or towards the creation of unhappiness
b. Resisting impatience towards those who are impediments in the way of one's praise, fame, or honour and towards those who insult, offend, or despise us

a. Resisting impatience towards those who cause impediments in the path to happiness or towards the creation of unhappiness

This also has two sub-categories:

1. Showing why it is wrong to get angry based on analysis
2. Showing why it is right to be compassionate

1. Why it is wrong to get angry based on analysis

There are three aspects to avoiding anger:

1.a It is wrong to get angry based on an analysis of the object
1.b It is wrong to get angry based on an analysis of the subject
1.c It is wrong to get angry based on an analysis of the basis

1.a. It is wrong to get angry based on an analysis of the object

There are four reasons why it is wrong to get angry at the object of anger

1.a.i It is wrong based on the analysis of whether the object has self-control or not

The agent of harm does not have control over his own actions, for mental afflictions have caused them to take such actions, which have led to the harm they have done. The agent does not have any control, much like one who is possessed by an evil spirit and attacks their benefactors.

1.a.ii It is wrong based on analysis of whether the harm done is the natural behaviour of the agent or if it is circumstantial.

We cannot get angry about something that is natural and unintentional—it would be foolish to get angry at the heat of a fire. Even if it is circumstantial, we cannot get angry either. For example, smoke rising in the sky cannot be blamed on the sky.

1.a.iii It is wrong based on analysis of the direct or indirect nature of the harm done

If we were to get angry at the direct cause of the harm done, that would be like beating the stick with which we were beaten. If we contemplate the indirect cause, then we should also be angry at the hatred.

1.a.iv It is wrong to get angry based on analysis of the causes that led to the harm done

The suffering that we face due to causes and conditions is all dependent on our previously accumulated *karma*. There is no one to blame but ourselves, so getting angry with others is wrong.

1.b It is wrong to get angry based on an analysis of the subject

It is contradictory for the subject to get angry at the one who inflicted harm because we are unable to bear pain. By not being able to take just a little suffering now, we are consciously accumulating causes that will lead to endless suffering of the lower realms.

1.c It is wrong to get angry based on an analysis of the basis

1.c.i Analysing the cause of the harm done and whether or not the perpetrator is at fault.

When we are wounded by weapons, we should realize that if both the weapon and we are the cause of our suffering, then what need is there to get angry at others? It is wrong to get angry and right to not be angry.

1.c.ii Analysing the vows one has taken

We should think that if it is wrong for even the hearers to get angry, then how can it be proper for one who is cultivating the mind of enlightenment, one who has vowed to work for the welfare of all sentient beings, to get angry?

2. Why it is right to be compassionate:

All the sentient beings have been cycling in *samsara* since beginningless time. Therefore, there is no one who has not been a close relative or parent. Yet, being tormented by the three kinds of suffering and afflicted by the evil of ignorance, they are destroying even the smallest potential they have for happiness in their current and future lives. I should therefore definitely be compassionate towards them.

b. Resisting impatience towards those who are impediments in the way of one's praise, fame, or honour and towards those who insult, offend, or despise us

This has two sub-categories:

b.1. Resisting impatience towards those who are impediments in the way of one's praise, fame, or honour
b.2. Resisting impatience towards those who insult, offend, or despise us

b.1. Resisting impatience towards those who are impediments in the way of one's praise, fame, or honour

This has three sub-sections:

b.1.i Contemplating that things like praises have no merit
b.1.ii. Contemplating how such things are defective

b.1.iii The need to feel delighted in those who are impediments in the way of one's praise, fame, or honour

b.1.i Contemplating that things like praises have no merit

In contemplating that things like praise have no merit, we should understand that by receiving praise and gaining popularity, we will not stop sickness or expand life. Unlike the generation of merit, praise will not benefit us either in this or future lives.

b.1.ii Contemplating how such things are defective

We should contemplate that things such as flattery are defective in that they only help to degenerate virtuous deeds.

b.1.iii The need to feel delighted in those who are impediments in the way of one's praise, fame, or honour

Causing the decline of our praises, fame, and honour is like a blessing from the Buddha to protect us from the gateway of falling into the lower realms, bondage to attachment, and entry to suffering. We should feel this from the depths of our hearts. Then cease the anger and generate joy.

b.2. Resisting impatience towards those who insult, offend, or despise us

Consciousness is formless, and therefore cannot be directly harmed by external forces. If directly harming the body indirectly harms the consciousness, then slander and the like should harm the body. However, both the body and mind cannot be harmed. Rejoicing in this, we should cease mental unrest. Cessation of which will stop the arising of hatred

ii. Resisting impatience towards the prosperity of the enemy or rejoicing in their downfall

It would be a contradiction if we were to practise the cultivation of the mind of enlightenment to help sentient beings and then become impatient when we see them happy. It is also completely contradictory to claim that all sentient beings must become completely enlightened and then become intolerant when we see them receiving a little reverence. Thinking this way, we should not get jealous of others acquisitions but rather rejoice for them.

B. The patience to accept suffering

This has three aspects:

i. The reason why we need to have the patience to accept suffering
ii. The method of cultivating patience to accept suffering
iii. A detailed explanation in terms of the basis

i. The reason why we need to have the patience to accept suffering

As all of us have to experience mundane suffering daily, we must make good use of these experiences. If not, our suffering will become an obstruction to engaging in virtuous deeds as it acts as the cause of hatred, discouraging us from cultivating the path.

ii. The methods of cultivating patience to accept suffering

This has two aspects:

a. Resisting complete aversion to suffering
b. Showing that it is appropriate to accept suffering

a. Resisting complete aversion to suffering

We should resist complete aversion to suffering because if we can do something about the suffering that we experience, then there is no need to feel dejected. And if it cannot be fixed, then there is no use in feeling disconsolate.

b. Showing that it is appropriate to accept suffering

There are three parts to accepting suffering:

b.1 Contemplating the positive aspects of suffering
b.2 Reflecting on the merits of being patient with suffering
b.3 How it is not difficult to accept suffering if we familiarise ourselves incrementally.

b.1 Contemplating the positive aspects of suffering

There are five positive aspects of suffering:

b.1.i It has the positive aspect of motivating the wish for liberation because, without suffering, we would never strive to renounce worldly existence.
b.1.ii It has the positive aspect of dispelling arrogance, as when one suffers, haughtiness born from pride subdues
b.1.iii It has the positive aspect of preventing us from committing further wrong actions, as experiencing extreme suffering leads us to realise that suffering is the result of negative deeds.
b.1.iv It has the positive aspect of instilling joy in engaging in positive deeds, as when immense suffering depresses us, we wish for happiness and see that to obtain happiness, one must perform virtuous deeds.
b.1.v When we experience suffering, we experience empathy

and generate compassion for other beings wandering in cyclic existence who are also suffering.

b.2. Reflecting on the merits of being patient with suffering

This has two parts:

b.2.i Reflecting on the great benefits, such as obtaining liberation

b.2.ii Reflecting on the benefit of dispelling immeasurable suffering

b.2.i Reflecting on the great benefits, such as obtaining liberation

When reflecting on the benefit of obtaining liberation, we should constantly reaffirm within our minds that, as we have earlier submitted to endless suffering for trivial gratification, now that we know we are engaged in virtue that will accomplish immeasurable benefits and happiness for ourselves and others, it is appropriate that we accept a trillion times more suffering than before—and definitely the smaller sufferings, undoubtedly.

b.2.ii Reflecting on the benefit of dispelling immeasurable suffering

We should reflect on the benefit of dispelling immeasurable suffering by thinking about how the mere effort of bearing little human hardship can reverse the suffering of cyclic existence in general and particularly that of lower realms, such as the hells.

b.3 How it is not difficult to accept suffering if we familiarise ourselves incrementally

With armour-like motivation, if we assimilate the courage to accept suffering with incremental advancement, our ability to accept suffering will increase.

iii. A detailed explanation in terms of the basis

To accept suffering, if one wonders which type of suffering to accept and where do those come from? There are eight of them:

a. *With regard to the object*, we need to accept the suffering of having a less or lower quality of robs, alms, mattresses, blankets, and medicines.
b. *With regard to worldly concerns*, we need to individually discriminate and accept all the suffering caused by the nine worldly concerns; insignificance, unpleasantness, insults, misery, degeneration, loss, ageing, sickness, and death.
c. *With regard to the four activities*—walking, standing, sitting, and sleeping—if we purify the mind day and night with the first and third, we are accepting the suffering caused by them.
d. *With regard to holding steadfastly to the dharma*, we need to worship and serve the three jewels and the spiritual teacher; understand the teachings; expound the teachings to others; recite the treatises; correctly contemplate; and practise calm-abiding and special-insight. By making efforts in these areas, we are accepting the suffering that arises.
e. *With regards to living on alms*, we should accept the suffering that comes with living a life of begging, which is: experiencing ugliness of appearance; wearing tattered clothes of an ugly colour; resisting engagement in

worldly concerns and acting in other ways; living a life of dependence on alms; we must beg for our necessities like robes from others; being detached from human desire for intercourse; and not enjoying human merriment.

f. *With regards to exhaustion through great effort*, while striving to engage in virtue, we should accept the sufferings that arise from mental and physical exhaustion, disturbances, and causes of fatigue.
g. *With regards to working for the welfare of sentient beings,* we should accept all the difficulties that arise while performing the eleven acts of helping others.
h. *With regards to temporary activities*, we should accept the suffering that arises while engaging in activities such as acquiring alms, bowls, and robes, conducting business, or farming without committing transgressions.

C. Patience to practice the teaching with conviction

To generate patience to practice the teachings with conviction,there are eight objects of conviction:

i. *The objects of faith*, which are the qualities of the three jewels
ii. *The objects of actualisation*, which is the reality of the two types of selflessness
iii. *The objects of aspiration*, which are the powers of the *buddha*s and *bodhisattva*s
iv. *The objects of adoption*, which are the causes of virtue and desiring their results
v. *The objects of abandonment,* which are the causes of non-virtue, and not desiring their results

vi. *The objects of meditation,* which is the state of enlightenment that one should achieve.
vii. *The object of meditation,* which are the methods of obtaining enlightenment.
viii. *The objects of practice* after listening and contemplating the teachings are impermanence and so forth. And in the Power-lineage chapter of the *Bodhisattva levels*, it is the three teachings of the Buddha.

The method of generating conviction is to find certainty in the reality of those objects of faith. Then apprehend them without contradiction and constantly engage in contemplation.

IV. How to practice when accomplishing them

The practice of any of the patience needs to be performed in conjunction with the six excellences and the six perfections. Except for the generosity of patience in establishing others patience, the rest is the same as earlier.

V. Summary of the points

In maintaining the mind of enlightenment, the basis of virtuous conduct is the foundation to uplift all sentient beings towards the cultivation of uncontaminated patience. We should, therefore, advance in this practice while maintaining the higher perfection of patience as the objective.

M.4: Perfection of effort

Training in the perfection of effort has five parts:

I. The nature of the effort
II. The method of cultivating effort

III. The types of effort
IV. How to practice when accomplishing them
V. Summary of the points

I. Nature of effort

The nature of effort is to be explicitly joyful when we engage in virtuous deeds.

II. Method of cultivating effort

The effort is cultivated by frequently reminding ourselves of the benefits of striving for virtue and the defects of not doing so.

III. Types of effort

There are two sub-sections to this:

A. The actual types of effort
B. The methods of generating them

A. Actual types of effort

There are three actual types of effort:

i. Armour-like effort
ii. The effort to accumulate virtue
iii. The effort to work for the welfare of sentient beings

i. Armour-like effort

When the *bodhisattva*s engage in the effort, it is like they don such armour, saying: "I would rejoice even if I were to take rebirth in the hell realm for a trillion sets of three immeasurably

great aeons, each composing days as long as a thousand great aeons, to obtain enlightenment for the sake of a single living being."

ii. The effort to accumulate virtue

This is excellently engaging in the practice of the six perfections in order to achieve them.

iii. The effort to work for the welfare of sentient beings

This is putting effort into practising the eleven ways of helping others.

IV. Method of cultivating effort

As explained before, the generation, maintenance, and advancement of the virtues of the two accumulations depend on this. Therefore, practices for cultivating effort are essential.

There are four ways to achieve this:

A. Abandoning the obstructions to effort
B. Amassing supporting conditions for accumulations
C. Engaging in the effort with the support of abandoning obstructions and accumulating merits
D. How to make body and mind serviceable with effort

A. Abandoning the obstructions to the effort

This has two aspects:

i. Identifying the obstructions[44]
ii. The methods of abandoning the obstructions

44 Identifying the obstructions part is missed in this book. Referring the GTSPE Vol.2 p 186, I have filled in here the gist of it as needed.

i. Identifying the obstructions

There are two types of obstructions:

a. Not putting effort in even though we can
b. Not putting effort in because we think we cannot

a. Not putting effort in even though we can

This has two categories:

1. We have laziness of procrastination
2. We have laziness of engagement in inferior activities

1. We have laziness of procrastination

We procrastinate the practice because we think that there is still more time.

2. We have laziness of engagement in inferior activities

We are not procrastinating but engaging in other inferior activities.

b. Not putting effort in because we think we cannot

We are not practising because we become discouraged, thinking, "How can I engage in such a practice?"

ii. The methods of abandoning the obstructive factors

There are three ways to this:

a. Abandoning the laziness of procrastination
b. Abandoning attachment to negative activities
c. Abandoning self-depreciation or loss of will

a. Abandoning the laziness of procrastination

We need to engender the thought that there is no time by abandoning the misconception that we have ample time to waste. We should do this by contemplating three things: how fast the body is degenerating, the likelihood that we will fall into a lower realm after we die, and the difficulty of obtaining a good rebirth.

b. Abandoning attachment to negative activities

The excellent *dharma* is the cause of endless delight in our current and future lives. We must abandon useless gossip and excitement, which are distractions from engaging in meaningful practice.

c. Abandoning self-depreciation or loss of will

If we feel discouraged from training in the Great Vehicle, this feeling must be abandoned.

There are three things we need to do to achieve this:

1. We need to counter discouragement regarding the objective
2. We must counter discouragement regarding the means to reach the objective,
3. We must counter discouragement regarding the place in which to practise.

1. Countering discouragement regarding the objective

It is said that even flies can obtain enlightenment, so why should we, born as human beings with the wonderful foundation that possesses discriminative awareness, not be able to obtain it? We should feel invigorated by this fact.

2. Countering discouragement regarding the means to reach the objective

To obtain enlightenment, one needs to render one's body parts. If we feel that we are incapable of such deeds, we must know that performing such acts of generosity is accomplished when it is easiest, when we are not frightened, and when we will be able to make it feel as simple as cutting vegetables to give away.

3. Countering discouragement regarding the place in which to practise

If we are discouraged about the countless number of rebirths we have to take in cyclic existence—where we have to bear tremendous suffering—to obtain *buddha*hood, we should think that *bodhisattva*s commit no transgressions, so there will be no suffering, and, with a clear mind and a fit body, they do not have any reason to feel sad even if they were in cyclic existence.

B. Amassing supporting conditions for accumulations

This has four aspects:

i. Generating the power belief
ii. Generating the power of steadfastness
iii. Generating the power of joy
iv. Generating the power of abandonment

i. Generating the power of belief

Since willpower is said to be the basis of effort, here, belief is willpower. It is said that because faith acts as the basis of willpower, the two types of faiths[45] of conviction generate the

45 Faith of conviction in the two types of karma and their effects will generate two kinds of desire: to eliminate Non-virtuous karma and to adopt virtuous karma. (GTSPE Vol. II p 195)

desire for abandonment and the adoption of non-virtuous and virtuous actions respectively.

ii. Generating the power of steadfastness

Wherever we apply effort, we never deviate from it until the task has been brought to completion.

iii. Generating the power of joy

Joy helps us to develop effort through the support of the immense willpower engendered by belief, while sustaining and preventing the degeneration of what has been developed. With the power of steadfastness or confidence as the cause for that, we begin any practice with joy and continue it without the slightest desire to stop. Such unquenchable delight in engaging in positive deeds is the power of joy. We must, therefore, cultivate it.

vi. Generating the power of abandonment

If we get physically and mentally tired while applying effort, then we should take a break. If we do not do this, continuous effort without respite might lead to frustration and sadness, which may become obstacles to effort. Once rested, seeing that we have done great but without feeling content, we should continue pursuing a higher level of practice with effort.

C. Engaging in the effort with the support of abandoning obstructions and accumulating merits

When engaging in the effort of abandoning what needs to be abandoned, afflictions may wound our minds. We have to be skilled and diligent in being patient with such wounds, avoiding them, and remedying them with antidotes.

D. How to make body and mind serviceable with effort

To generate delight in applying effort, our body and mind should be overpowered by enthusiasm to engage in virtue. In this way, we can effortlessly accumulate all sorts of merit.

IV. How to practice when accomplishing them

When we apply effort to any practice, it should be accompanied by the six excellences and the six perfections. As the generosity of effort is to establish others in this practice after we have stabilised ourselves in it. The remaining perfections are as explained earlier.

V. Summary of the points

We should progress the cultivation of the mind of enlightenment, as it is the essence of all good conduct and the foundation for leading all sentient beings to the perfection of practising effort. Then continue one's practice by aspiring for a higher level of effort. At the same time, we should train in the practice of effort in the beginner's stage in accordance with our capacity.

M.5: Training in the perfection of meditative concentration

This has five parts:

I. The nature of meditative concentration
II. The method of cultivating meditative concentration
III. The types of meditative concentration
IV. How to practice when you are accomplishing them
V. Summary of the points

I. The nature of meditative concentration

The nature of meditative concentration is the virtue of a single-pointed mind that is not distracted from the object of focus.

II. The method of cultivating meditative concentration

This is done by contemplating the benefits of practising meditative concentration and the defects of not doing so.

III. The types of meditative concentration

A. In terms of nature, there are two types: Worldly meditative concentration; and beyond worldly meditative concentration.

B. In terms of function, there are three types: The meditative concentration that helps us gain mental and physical wellness in the present life, the meditative concentration that leads to higher realisations and the meditative concentration that benefits other sentient beings

i. The meditative concentration that helps us gain mental and physical wellness in the present life: This is the kind of meditative concentration that achieves mental and physical pliancy.

ii. The meditative concentration that leads to higher realisations: This is the meditative concentration that gives us mastery over qualities such as clairvoyance, liberations, totalities, masteries, etc.

iii. The meditative concentration that benefits other sentient beings is the meditative concentration of helping sentient beings through the eleven activities.

IV. How to practise when accomplishing them

Any virtuous application of meditative concentration should be accompanied by the six excellences and the six perfections. We should abide in meditative concentration while leading others to it. This is the generosity of meditative concentration, and the rest are similar to the previous.

V. Summary of the points

Meditating and recollecting the mind of enlightenment, which is the basis of conduct, is the motivation behind uplifting all sentient beings towards the cultivation of uncontaminated meditative concentration. We should, therefore, stabilise this spirit and advance our practice while aspiring for the higher perfection of meditative concentration and practice.

M.6: Training in the perfection of wisdom

Training in the perfection of wisdom has five parts:

I. The nature of wisdom
II. The method of cultivating wisdom
III. The types of wisdom
IV. How to practice when accomplishing them
V. Summary of the points

I. The nature of wisdom

The nature of wisdom is the analysis of all the objects of knowledge. Thorough discrimination of all phenomena—categorised into the five disciplines of study that are sacred literature, reasoning, medicine, language, and craft—knowledge of which should be understood as the nature of the wisdom of the *bodhisattva*s.

II. The method of cultivating wisdom

Wisdom is generated by contemplating the benefits of cultivating it and the defects of not cultivating it. If we have wisdom, we have a clear understanding of right and wrong that leads to mastery over the clearing of ignorance and the increasing of virtue. Wisdom endows us with the ability to be moved to *great kindness* and to see beings affectionately without the slightest stain of attachment. Though moved by *great compassion* for the immense suffering of sentient beings for great lengths of time, wisdom keeps great beings from falling into depression and becoming lazy from the joy of virtuous deeds. Even though they experience *immeasurable joy*, they do not get distracted from their objective, and though they have *great equanimity*, they never cease to work for the welfare of sentient beings. Wisdom drives away the equally opposing forces.

III. The types of wisdom

There are three types of wisdom:

A. The wisdom that understands the ultimate
B. The wisdom that understands conventional
C. The wisdom that understands how to work for the welfare of sentient beings

A. The wisdom that understands the ultimate

This is the wisdom realising the reality of selflessness conceptually or directly.

B. The wisdom that understands conventional

This is the wisdom of knowing the five fields of study

C. The wisdom that understands how to work for the welfare of sentient beings

This is to know the way to work for the benefit of sentient beings in this and future lives without any negativity.

IV. How to practice when accomplishing them

To cultivate the three kinds of wisdom, we need to apply the six excellences and the six perfections. The generosity of wisdom is practising wisdom ourselves and leading others to do so. The remainders are the same as earlier.

V. Summary of the points

Even if we have the wisdom to understand emptiness, without the mind of enlightenment, we are not really practising the conduct of a *bodhisattva*. Therefore, we should develop the mind of enlightenment, the core of the *bodhisattva*'s conduct. Then continue to aspire for the wisdom of higher grounds and practice.

L.2 Training in the four means of gathering disciples to ripen others continuum

This has five parts:

I. The nature of the four means of gathering disciples
II. The reason why there are four means
III. The function of the four means
IV. The need to rely on the disciples they gather
V. Further explanation

I. The nature of four means of gathering disciples

Generosity in this context is similar to what was explained in the six perfections: *pleasant speech* is showing the six perfections to the disciples; *applying the practice* is letting the disciples enter the teaching that one has shown or making them practice the teaching with excellence; *being in harmony with the practice* is abiding in what one has taught others and practicing them accordingly.

II. The reason why there are four of them

There are four means of gathering disciples because, to encourage them to engage in virtuous deeds, one must first please them. To please them, we have to depend on the generosity of material things for physical benefit. Once we have their attention, to introduce them to the path, we must give pleasant speech on the teachings so that they will know how to engage. Having accomplished that, we must encourage them to engage in virtuous deeds, and if it is something the teacher should practise, he should abide by the virtuous action that he encourages his disciples to engage in. Seeing this, the disciples will follow, thinking the actions will certainly bring happiness.

III. The function of the four means

Generosity makes the disciples suitable vessels to listen to the teachings; pleasant speech generates faith in the teachings given; applying the practice engenders the application of the teachings; and being in harmony with the practice ensures the continuation of the practice without reversing it.

IV. The need to rely on the disciples they gather

As these are shown as an excellent method by the enlightened ones to help achieve welfare of all sentient beings and a great method, those gathering disciples must rely on them.

V. Further explanation

There are two kinds of pleasant speech. Pleasant speech in terms of worldliness is making others happy through pleasant speech such as greetings, and pleasant discourse in terms of showing excellent discourse is teaching sentient beings through faith, discipline, knowledge, generosity, and wisdom with the aim of their benefit and happiness.

Applying the practice also has two types: maturing the immature and liberating the mature.

Then there is abiding ourselves in what we are teaching others or being better at them.

The four means of gathering disciples can, in short, be categorised thus: The first is attracting with material goods; the latter three are attracting with teachings.

Here concludes the training in the cultivation of the aspirational mind of enlightenment and the stages of general conduct of the path as shown in *The Essence of the Stages of the Path*: Lamp Illuminating the Essential Instructions of the

Stages of the Path of the Persons of the Great Scope Based on the Outlines of the Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment.

K.2 Especially training in the last two perfections

This is the training in calm-abiding and special-insight. These two, respectively are encompassed within the perfection of meditative concentration and wisdom.

There are six sections to this:

L.1 The benefit of cultivating calm-abiding and special-insight
L.2 Showing how the two include all states of meditation
L.3 The characteristic of calm-abiding and special-insight
L.4 The reason for cultivating calm-abiding and special-insight
L.5: How the order is definite
L.6: Process of their individual practice

L.1 The benefits of cultivating calm-abiding and special-insight

Although calm-abiding and special-insight are qualities acquired by those with meditative experiences, all mental concentrations aimed at virtuous objectives are classified as calm-abiding, while all virtuous discriminative awareness that distinguishes ultimate or conventional phenomena is included in special-insight. This is what was intended when texts such as *The Sutra Unravelling the Thought*[46] stated that all the good qualities of the three vehicles are the result of calm-abiding and special-insight.

46 mdo sde dgongs 'grel (Tib.) Samdhi-nirmocana-sutra (skt.)

L.2 Showing how the two include all states of meditation

Calm-abiding and special-insight are the essences of all the numerous meditative concentration that we have been taught in the great and lesser vehicles.

L.3 The characteristics of calm-abiding and special-insight

Characteristic of calm-abiding: it is the mental engagement that continuously engages the mind inwardly upon the object on which the mind is set properly within. The *sutra* says; "When one abides in this state and practises it many times, the physical and mental pliancy that one gain is called 'calm-abiding'" This means calm-abiding is the single-pointed meditative concentration imbued with mental pliancy while observing virtuous objects.

Characteristic of special-insight: the same *sutra* says; "After obtaining pliancy of body and mind, one eliminates other mental aspects while remaining in that state of pliancy. Then, inwardly discern individually the very object that our mind had focused on with meditative concentration as mental images if possible. In relation to those images, any differentiation of the meaning of the objects, or full differentiation, complete examination, through analysis, patience, wish, differentiation of particulars, view, or thoughts is called 'special-insight'." This is discriminating wisdom, possessing the pliancy induced by the power of investigating an object with calm-abiding mind. Therefore, calm-abiding and special-insight are not differentiated by their object of focus.[47] And it would also be completely wrong to differentiate them through the intensity of the clarity of the mind

47 For there is meditative serenity that knows emptiness and there is insight which does not know emptiness. GTSPE Vol.3 p19

in its non-discursiveness.[48]

L.4 The reason for cultivating both calm-abiding and special-insight

Without the wisdom that realises ultimate reality, however highly familarised we are with a concentration that lacks the eye that sees suchness—even with the non-conceptual meditative concentration that stops mental discursiveness—we will never understand reality. At the same time, even if we have a profound understanding of selflessness, without the meditative concentration that keeps the mind focused, we will be easily disrupted by the uncontrollably fluctuating wind of conceptual thoughts, making a clear realisation of suchness impossible. Therefore, we need both calm-abiding and special-insight.

L.5: How the order is definite

In the beginning, we must first cultivate calm-abiding and then, relying on that, we should cultivate special-insight. Later, it is said that calm-abiding is also cultivated by relying on special-insight.

L.6 Process of their individual practice

This has three sections:

M.1 Cultivating calm-abiding
M.2 Cultivating special-insight
M.3 How the two are brought into union

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48 Bliss, clarity, and non-discursiveness are present in concentrations that know emptiness, yet very often occur in concentrations that are not directed toward emptiness, you have to differentiate these two. GTSPE Vol.3 pa19

M.1 Cultivating calm-abiding

This has three sections:

N.1: Acquiring the causal conditions to cultivate calm-abiding
N.2: Way of Meditating on calm-abiding by relying on that
N.3: The measure of achieving the cultivation of calm-abiding

N.1: Acquiring the causal conditions to cultivate calm-abiding

There are six conditions to cultivate calm-abiding:

I. *In terms of a conducive milieu*, it is said that our environment should have five qualities: proper access, a secure place, good ground, ethical companions, and quietude for spiritual practice.
II. *Having less attachment* means not getting overly attached to the quantity or quality of robes, etc.
III. *Being content*: Always being content with whatever ragged robes one finds.
IV. *Completely abandoning various activities*: Unethical activities such as buying and selling, excessive correspondence with lay or ordained persons, and engaging in medicine and astrology should be completely abandoned.
V. *Excellent discipline*: not violating the precepts, not doing deeds that are wrong by nature or wrong by prohibition, either in the case of vows of individual liberation or in the case of a *bodhisattva* vow. If a violation occurs out of carelessness, immediately correcting it with remorse in accordance with the teachings.

VI. *Eliminating discursive thoughts such as desire*: we need to eliminate discursive thoughts of desire by contemplating that things such as killing and getting attached to the desired object are faults for the present life and cause of faults for future lives, such as taking lower rebirth, and also that all cyclic phenomena are subject to disintegration.

N.2: Way of Meditating on calm-abiding by relying on that

This has two sections:

O.1 Preparation
O.2 The actual practice

O.1 Preparation

Apart from the six-fold preliminary practices, we should particularly engage in prolonged contemplation of the mind of enlightenment, and as supports, we should practise the procedures that are shared with persons of small and medium scopes.

O.2 The actual practice

This has two parts:

P.1 Physical posture with which to meditate
P.2 Stages of practice itself

P.1 Physical posture with which to meditate

Be seated on a comfortable mattress in the eight-fold posture[6].

P.2 Stages of practice itself

This has two sections:

Q.1 Cultivating perfect meditative stabilisation
Q.2 The stages of developing the mental states on that basis

Q.1 Cultivating perfect meditative stabilisation

This has three parts:

I. What to do before focusing the mind on the object
II. What to do while focusing the mind on the object
III. What to do after focusing the mind on the object

I. What to do before focusing the mind on the object

If we do not have an interest in meditative concentration and cannot resist laziness that diverts our interest towards the opposing factors, we cannot cultivate concentration. And even if we are successful once, it will decline rapidly. Therefore, first of all, it is crucial to stop laziness. For that, we need to cultivate bliss of physical and mental pliancy, obtaining which will eliminate laziness by allowing us to engage in virtuous deeds for days and nights without tiredness. To develop this, we have to make a continuous effort to cultivate meditative concentration, as it causes pliancy. For that, we need to have intense motivation to achieve meditative concentration, which comes from a firm faith of admiration in the qualities of meditative concentration. Therefore, in the beginning, we have to persistently contemplate the positive qualities of meditative concentration.

II. What to do while focusing the mind on the object

This has two sections:

A. Ascertaining the object of meditation
B. How to focus the mind on the object

A. Ascertaining the object of meditation

This has two parts:

i. General objects of meditation
ii. Objects of meditation in the present context

i. General objects of meditation

This has three sections:

a. Actual objects of meditation
b. Who should meditate on which object
c. Various terms for objects of meditation

a. Actual objects of meditation

There are four kinds of objects for meditation:

1. Pervasive objects of meditation
2. Objects of meditation for correcting behaviour
3. Objects of meditation for becoming skillful
4. Objects of meditation for purifying afflictions

1. Pervasive objects of meditation are of four types:

The four are: discursive images, non-discursive images, limits of phenomena, and complete achievement of the purpose[7]. The first two are based on the observer; the second is based on the

observed object; and the complete achievement of the purpose is based on the result[8].

2. Objects of meditation for correcting behaviour

The objects of meditation for correcting behaviour are: ugliness, kindness, dependent-arising, diverseness of realms, and inhaling and exhaling.

3. Objects of meditation for becoming skillful

There are five objects of meditation to be skillful: the aggregates, the elements, the sense-spheres, interdependence, and what is and is not possible.

4. Objects of meditation for purifying afflictions

This has two parts:

4.a Objects of meditation that subdue affliction
4.b Objects of meditation that eliminate affliction

4.a Objects of meditation that subdue afflictions

Objects of meditation that subdue affliction are aspects of the coarseness of the lower realm in comparison to the peacefulness of the higher realm between the desire realm and the sphere of nothingness.

4.b Objects of meditation that eliminate affliction

The objects of meditation that eliminate affliction are the sixteen aspects of the four noble truths.

b. Who should meditate on which object

The respective types of objects of meditation taken by a particular person are ugliness for those with greater attachment, compassion for those with hatred, interdependency for those with greater ignorance, diverseness of realms for those with greater haughtiness, and inhaling and exhaling for those with greater misconceptions. For those with less ignorance, any of these objects of meditation are appropriate.

c. Various terms for objects of meditation

The synonyms for the images or aspects of the objects mentioned above, which are the basis of the meditative concentration or the basis of attention, that appear to the mind are eight, such as images, signs of concentration, etc., as stated in Asanga's *Hearer's Level*.

ii. Objects of meditation in the present context

The objects of meditation should be as shown above in terms of who should meditate on which object. Apart from that, one can also achieve meditative concentration by focusing on the image of Buddha.

B. How to focus the mind on the object

This has three parts:

i. Establishing faultless practice
ii. Eliminating defective practice
iii. Duration of the practice

i. Establishing faultless practice

The meditative concentration cultivated here has two special qualities: *extreme clarity of the lucid mind* and a *state of non-conceptual steadiness* on the object. Because of the need for constant focus on the object, there is a means of preventing distraction from the object and a mind that knows if we are distracted or not. The first is *mindfulness*, and the latter is *vigilance*.

ii. Eliminating defective practice

When the mind is set at a high level and stabilised tightly without non-conceptual thoughts, there will not be even the slightest fault of laxity. However, seeing that with overexcitement we are losing continuity of mental steadiness, one lowers the mental elevation. Seeing that by reducing the tightness of our mind, we find stability quickly, we would seem to think that the method is a significant formula and proclaim "good relaxation is good meditation!" This is a babble of not being able to differentiate between the development of laxity and the cultivation of meditative concentration. Therefore, perfect meditative concentration should have the two qualities stated above.

iii. Duration of the practice

Regarding whether there should be a certain duration for each session, Tibetan teachers of various lineages are unanimous in saying that we should begin with a greater number of shorter sessions in the early period when we are still unfamiliar with the practice.

III. What to do after focusing the mind on the object

This has two sections:

A. What to do when laxity and excitement arise
B. What to do after eliminating laxity and excitement

A. What to do when laxity and excitement arise

This has two parts:

i. Applying antidotes when unable to recognise laxity and excitement
ii. Applying antidotes to laxity and excitement when recognised but not able to abandon

i. Applying antidotes when unable to recognise laxity and excitement

This has two parts:

a. Defining laxity and excitement
b. How to cultivate vigilance to clear away laxity and excitement

a. Defining laxity and excitement

Excitement is a restless, craved type of mind that is attracted to signs of beauty and functions as an obstruction to calm-abiding. Laxity is the loss of the mode of apprehension, leading to a decline in the tightness or clarity of the focus on the object, resulting in clarity without an intensely lucid mode of apprehension.

b. How to cultivate vigilance to clear away laxity and excitement

It is not enough to have an understanding of laxity and excitement. During the practice, we should have the vigilance to properly identify whether there is any development of laxity or excitement. To cultivate this, we have to do two things; realise how to maintain mindfulness that does not lose the object and with that mindfulness, holding the focus by watching if the mind is distracted somewhere other than the object or not.

ii. Applying antidotes to laxity and excitement when recognised but not able to abandon

When we are unable to abandon laxity and excitement, we have to cultivate the intention called 'effort of application' as an antidote to non-application.

There are two parts to this:

a. Recognising intention and how it stops excitement and laxity
b. Recognising the cause of laxity and excitement

a. Recognising intention and how it stops excitement and laxity

Intention is the mental factor that moves the primary mind towards any of the virtuous, non-virtuous, or neutral actions. Here, when excitement and laxity arise, we should maintain the intention that directly applies the mind to eliminate them.

Laxity results from losing the mode of apprehension due to over-internalisation. For that, we need to focus the mind on something delightful that will direct the mind outward, like an

exquisite image of the Buddha or sunlight—something luminous in the mind. And after dispelling laxity, we should immediately tighten the mode of apprehension of the object of contemplation and continue the meditation.

Excitement occurs when out of attachment, the mind pursues objects, such as sound or form. Therefore, we should engage the mind in a cause that disenchants the mind and retracts it. Having eliminated the excitement, we should return our focus to the object of meditation.

b. Recognising the cause of laxity and excitement

As stated in the *Actuality of the Levels*, the signs of laxity are: Not having control over the senses; not having control over eating; not making effort to practise in the early and later part of the night rather than sleeping; being non-vigilant; defiled behaviour; over-sleeping; being unskillful; being lazy in aspiration, effort, reflection, and analysis; not accustoming and fully training in the calm-abiding; paying attention to only a fragment of the practice; and having a dull mind that detests focusing on the object.

The signs of excitement are: the four mentioned above, such as having no control over the senses; indulging in sensual pleasure; behaving restlessly; lacking a mind of disenchantment; being unskillful; great sense of grasping in one's aspiration, etc.; not accustoming to effort; meditating on an aspect of the object without proper clarity; and being distracted by anything related to excitement, such as loved ones. These signs of excitement and laxity are their causes.

B. What to do after eliminating laxity and excitement

As we meditate, after eliminating the subtlest forms of laxity and excitement, a level of a balanced mind free from laxity or excitement is achieved. The application of effort at that time would be the fault of meditative concentration. For that, one must cultivate equanimity as an antidote. How then do we achieve the meditative concentration that generates clairvoyance and such? The answer is by relying on the eight applications that eradicate the five faults.

The five faults are: *Laziness* at the time of preparation, which hinders the application of meditative concentration; *forgetting instructions* at the time of applying meditative concentration, as forgetting the object makes concentration on the object impossible; *laxity and excitement* when in meditative equipoise, for both will distract the mind; *non-application* of effort when laxity and excitement arise, for they will not be pacified; and finally, *intention of application* after elimination of excitement and laxity. The texts on *The Stages of Meditation* state that laxity and excitement, when considered as one, make five faults, and six if they are separated.

Of the eight applications that are the remedies to these faults to eliminate laziness, there are four antidotes: Faith, aspiration, effort, and pliancy. The antidotes to forgetfulness, laxity and excitement, non-applicability and applicability are, respectively: mindfulness, introspection, intention of application, and calmly stabilised equanimity.

Q.2 The stages of developing mental states on that basis

This has three sections:

I. The Actual stages of developing mental states

II. Accomplishing mental states with the six powers
III. These consisted of four mental engagements

I. The Actual stages of developing mental states

There are nine stages of mental state:

A. *Focusing mind*: This is properly collecting the mind away from all external objects and internally directing it on the object of meditation.
B. *Continuous focusing*: This is maintaining of the continuation of the focusing mind on the object of concentration by not being diverted from it.
C. *Repeated focusing*: This is being aware if the mind gets distracted due to forgetfulness, and refocusing it on the object.
D. *Closely focusing*: In the previous stage, you became aware of the distraction and eliminated it. Here, you eliminate distraction and make an effort to focus on the object.
E. *Taming*: Finding delight in meditative concentration by seeing its positive qualities.
F. *Pacification*: Eliminating dislike for meditative concentration by contemplating the defects of distraction.
G. *Full pacification*: Pacifying attachment, discomfort, dullness, and sleepiness.
H. *Single-pointed mind*: Applying effort to gain effortless meditative concentration.
I. *Balanced mind*: cultivating equanimity once the mind obtains balance.

The terms used for these nine mental states are based on Kamalasila's *First Stages of Meditation*. The definitions of the

fourth and ninth mental states are from the same text, and the rest are as explained in the *Ornament for the Mahayana Sutra*.

II. Accomplishing mental states with the six powers

The six powers are:

A. The power of listening
B. The power of contemplation
C. The power of mindfulness
D. The power of vigilance
E. The power of effort
F. The power of complete familiarisation

How each of these obtains the mental states:

A. The power of listening obtains the focusing mind. We learn to focus the mind on an object just by listening to instructions. Other than merely focusing the mind on the object, there is not much contemplation done in this state.
B. The power of contemplation obtains the continuous focusing mind. By repeatedly contemplating the initial focusing mind on the object, we can get some level of continuation for the first time.
C. The power of mindfulness obtains the repeated focusing mind and the closely-focusing mind. When we are distracted from the object and remain distracted, we can regain our focus by remembering the object. The generation of mindfulness from the beginning stops distraction from the object of meditation.
D. The power of vigilance obtains the mental state of taming and pacification. Through vigilance, we realize

the defect of being distracted by discursive thoughts and signs of secondary mental afflictions. Knowing that we will not give in to them.

E. The power of effort obtains the fully pacified and single-pointed mind. By making a concentrated effort to eliminate the subtlest discursive thoughts and secondary mental afflictions and by not letting laxity and excitement obstruct the progress of meditative concentration, we will reach a state of continuous meditative concentration.

F. The power of familiarisation achieves a balanced mind. With great familiarity with the previous mental states, effortless meditative concentration is generated.

In short, we first proceed by listening to the instructions and learning to focus the mind on the object. Then contemplate the focus repeatedly, and while gaining a level of continuity, move forward with it. Then quickly recall the object if the mind loses it and gets distracted. After that, we cultivate greater mindfulness and the power of remembrance, which will prevent us from getting distracted in the first place. With that, we generate a strong, vigilant mind that will guard against laxity and excitement that distract the mind. Even for momentary distractions, the power of effort should be cultivated to stop them immediately and lengthen the duration of the session. After that, we continue the progress, and when it becomes familiar, we achieve the ninth mental state of meditative concentration, which requires no further effort.

III. These consisted of four mental engagements

The four mental engagements are *intense engagement*, *engagement with breaks*, *uninterrupted engagement*, and

spontaneous engagement. The first two mental states need intense engagement. In the next five mental states, due to laxity and excitement, we are unable to sustain the session for long and need breaks. Therefore, there is engagement with interruption. In the eighth state, laxity and excitement will no longer be obstructions, the meditation session will be long, and the mind will engage without breaks. Finally, in the ninth state, there is no obstruction and no need for constant effort, so the mind engages spontaneously without effort.

N.3 The measure of achieving the cultivation of calm-abiding

There are three parts to this:

O.1 The distinction between cultivation and non-cultivation of calm-abiding
O.2 The general method of progressing through the path with calm-abiding
O.3 The specific method of progressing through the path of ordinary beings

O.1 The distinction between cultivation and non-cultivation of calm-abiding

This has two parts:

I. The actual meaning of achieving the cultivation of calm-abiding
II. The signs of achieving cultivation of attention and eliminating doubts

I. The Actual meaning of achieving the cultivation of calm-abiding

As shown in the *Middling Stages of Meditation*, when the one who has familiarised himself with calm-abiding can obtain physical and mental pliancy and has gained control over his mind towards any object as he wishes, that should be understood as the time one has achieved cultivation of calm-abiding.

II. The signs of achieving cultivation of attention and eliminating doubts

A. We will achieve these four in a small measure: mental state of the form realm, physical pliancy, mental pliancy, and single-pointed concentration.
B. We will become efficient in purifying afflictions by following the path attributed to aspects of calmness and coarseness[49], or the path with aspects of truth[50].
C. When practising meditative equipoise, we will easily gain pliancy of body and mind.
D. The five obstructions—such as desiring pleasurable things—will not mostly arise.
E. Even after the session of meditative equipoise, we will experience pliancy from time to time.

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49 Ordinary path through which practitioners in seeing the shortcomings in the result/realm of the preceding path, aspires to take higher rebirth and thus strives for the next path. This means is limited to acquiring higher rebirth within the cyclic existence. Also refer to p 38,42,85 or 96 GTSPE Eng Vol.3

50 This is the path where in an individual seeks the ultimate truth/the view of emptiness to be liberated from the cyclic existence.

Eliminating doubt:

At which of the five stages of the path do we acquire the non-discursive mind that is intensely clear, without the subtlest laxity, almost without afflictions—such as desiring pleasurable things—and possessed of the quality of having consistent pliancy even without effort in mindfulness and vigilance?

There have been many in the past as well as in recent times who say that this should belong to the Mahayana path or the fully qualified practice of the completion stage of the highest *yoga*. However, if we analyse it by relying on the standard treatises, this kind of meditative concentration does not qualify even for the paths of the lower vehicles, let alone the Mahayana path.

O.2 The general method of progressing through the path with calm-abiding

Even with great meditative concentration, if the calm-abiding or attention we have achieved cannot generate special-insight, let alone get rid of all the afflictive emotions, we will not even be able to abandon the afflictions of the desire realm. Therefore, cultivating special-insight is essential. There is the special-insight that will eliminate the gross level of affliction for those cultivating the ordinary path, and the special-insight that eliminates afflictions from their root for those cultivating the beyond-ordinary path. There are no special-insights other than these two. We should, therefore, excel in the signs of special-insight and calm-abiding, and then, according to the kind of path we choose, start applying the effort required to follow it.

O.3 The specific method of progressing through the path of ordinary beings

This has two sections:

I. The need to obtain calm-abiding before training in the path that is attributed to calmness and coarseness
II. How to eliminate attachment to pleasure by relying on calm-abiding

I. The need to obtain calm-abiding before training in the path that is attributed to calmness and coarseness

To cultivate the path contemplating calmness and coarseness through discerning knowledge of individual characteristics, we must first have achieved calm-abiding, as it is mentioned in texts such as the *Ornament of the Mahayana Sutra* that we must rely on the cultivation of meditative concentration to engage in the actual practice.

II. How to eliminate attachment to pleasure by relying on calm-abiding

In the *Hearer's Level,* it is said that to abandon attachment to pleasure, the great practitioners would use seven types of mental engagements.

These seven types of mental engagements are:

A. Individual knowledge of the character
B. Arising from belief
C. Complete isolation
D. Joy-withdrawal
E. Analysis
F. The Final application

G. Fruit of the final application

The last is mental engagement at the time when one is entering the actual state of meditative stabilisation after the abandonment of the attachment to pleasure. Therefore, this is to be established while the first six are establishers.

M.2 Cultivating special-insight

This has four sections:

N.1 Adhering to the conditions to cultivate special-insight
N.2 The types of special-insight
N.3 How to cultivate special-insight
N.4 The measure of achieving special-insight cultivated through meditation

N.1 Adhering to the conditions to cultivate special-insight

This has three parts:

O.1 Recognising the interpretable and definitive teachings
O.2 How the commentaries on Nagarjuna's[51] views developed
O.3 Establishing the view of emptiness

O.1 Recognising the interpretable and definitive teachings

Based on the subject they teach, the definitive teachings are those that explain ultimate truth and the interpretable teachings are those that teach conventional truth.

51 Nagarjuna (c. 150–250) one of the most important Buddhist philosophers. Along with his disciple Aryadeva, he is considered the founder of the Middle Way /Madhyamika School of the Great Vehicle /Mahayana Buddhism.

O.2 How the commentaries on Nagarjuna's views developed

Nagarjuna has non-mistakenly explained that all phenomena have no arising and cessation from their nature whatsoever as per scriptures such as the *Perfection of Wisdom Sutra.* The great Middle Way[52] masters like Buddhapalita, Bhavavivek, Chandrakirti, and Shantideva look to master Aryadeva as reliable as the master Nagarjuna himself in explaining his views. Therefore, since the duo of father and spiritual son is the source of the Middle Way proponent, the earlier scholars referred to them as the 'Middle Way of the Fundamental Text' and the others as the 'partial-Middle Way proponent.'

O.3 Establishing the view of emptiness

This has two sections:

P.1 The stages of introduction to suchness[53]
P.2 The actual establishment of suchness

P.1 The stages of introduction to suchness

To begin with, we must see the defects of cyclic existence and, saddened by that, develop the mind to leave it. Then we must realise that without getting rid of its root causes, we cannot be free from it. As we look for the causes of cyclic existence, we should find the view of transitory collections, or ignorance, as the root cause, and with a wholeheartedly ascertained acknowledgment of that, we should have a genuine desire to abandon it. With that, we should see that remedying the transitory view depends

52 Madhyamika; the Buddhist schools of philosophy that propound that there are no truly existent phenomena, not even particles.

53 The ultimate reality or emptiness in Buddhism; the state of being just as it is. 'de kho na nyid' (Tib.)

on cultivating the 'wisdom of understanding selflessness'. By wanting to eliminate the view of the self, we become convinced that it is indispensable to pursue the liberation that is obtained through the scriptural and logical teachings that establish the lack of the self and refute its existence.

P.2 The actual establishment of suchness

This has three parts:

Q.1 Identifying the object of negation by reason
Q.2 Whether to refute the object to be negated with the Middle Way Consequentialist System or the Middle Autonomy System
Q.3 How to cultivate the right view based on the system that negates the object

Q.1 Identifying the object negated by reason

This has three sections:

I. Why proper identification of the object of negation is necessary
II. Refuting other systems that refute without identifying the object to be negated
III. Identifying the object of negation as per our system

I. Why proper identification of the object of negation is necessary

To ascertain the meaning of '*selflessness*' and the '*lack of the nature*', we must first identify the '*self*' and the '*nature*'[54] that

54 The kind of 'nature' 'rang bzhin' (Tib.) refuted by the Middle Way Consequentialist school is one that is even conventionally non-existent in a

does not exist. Without having a clear concept of the generality of what is being discerned, the negation itself cannot be expected to be accurate. It is important to properly identify the object of negation. Otherwise, we will undoubtedly fall into either the extremes of externalism or nihilism.

II. Refuting other systems that refute without identifying the object to be negated

This has two sections:

A. Refuting systems with overly broad identification of the object to be negated9
B. Refuting systems with restrictive identification of the object to be negated10

A. Refuting systems with an overly broad identification of the object to be negated

This has two sections:

i. Presenting their view
ii. Refuting their view

i. Presenting their view

These days, most of those who claim to be teaching the meaning of the Middle Way say that the rational analysis examining whether production and such are established in reality or not negates all phenomena, from form to the omniscient mind. For when reason analyses whatever is accepted, there is not even a

way that is truly existent/ ultimately existent/ intrinsically existent/ existing from its own side/ inherently existing/ existing from its own characteristics/ existing from its own entity/ existing independently or existing objectively. ('intrinsic nature'/'intrinsic existence' GTSPE Vol.3 p126)

particle that can withstand analysis. Also, all four possibilities of whether something is existent or not are refuted.

Moreover, when the arya's[55] wisdom-seeing-reality ascertains the nonexistence of production, cessation, and liberation, it must be that way, as they know, and therefore there is no production and such. However, if we assert the existence of production and so forth, then asking whether it can withstand reason analysing suchness or not and whether it is established by valid cognition or not would be unacceptable. Also, refuting the ultimate nonexistence of production through the four possibilities will not negate it either.

ii. Refuting their view

This has two sections:

a. How the proponent refutes the unique standpoint of the Middle Way
b. How the refutations do not eliminate the existence of conventional phenomena

a. How the proponent refutes the unique standpoint of the Middle Way

This has three parts:

1. Identifying the characteristics of the Middle Way
2. How that system refutes this characteristic
3. How the Middle Way responds

55 Someone who has cognized emptiness directly and thus has risen above the state of a common being. They have obtained the Path of Seeing and the First Ground (as per the Great Vehicle).

1. Identifying the Characteristic of the Middle Way

As explained before, for the disciples of the great vehicle to obtain the supreme truth-body and the form-body at the point of the result, it depends on the immeasurable accumulation of merit and exalted wisdom. This they collect while they are on the path, where method and wisdom are inseparable.

This depends on obtaining a definite understanding of the diversity of phenomena, a deep understanding of the relation between conventional cause and effect, where you are aware that such and such a cause leads to this and that benefit and flaw, which are the results. Also, one must rely on the profound certainty that there is not even a particle of existent nature established by its own entity in all phenomena. Without these two, one will never come to wholeheartedly train on a complete path consisting of both method and wisdom. Therefore, while accepting all presentations of cyclic existence and transcendence, including those of the produced and the producer, the unique characteristic of the middle way lies in the assertion that, there is no nature that is established by its own entity.

2. How that system refutes this characteristic

They ask that since the system of Nagarjuna postulates the possibility of bondage, liberation, and so forth, we have to certainly accept the lack of nature. However, what do phenomena have if they lack nature established by their own entity? Therefore, there is no need to add on attributes such as 'ultimate' to refute bondage, liberation, production, and cessation. For the reason that refute 'nature' is said to be doing the refutation.

3. How the Middle Way responds

Asking, "What is there if phenomena are not established by way of their own entity?" undoubtedly shows that one does not differentiate between the nonexistence of the nature of a sprout and the nonexistence of a sprout. Therefore, there is no distinction between the establishment of a sprout and the sprout being established by its own entity. This is no different from the way of understanding of the essentialists, who assert that if something exists, then it is established by its own entity, and if something is not established by its own entity, then it is completely nonexistent.

b. How the refutations do not eliminate (the existence of conventional phenomena)

There are four to this:

1. The inability to eliminate it through refutation by examining whether or not (conventional phenomena) endure rational analysis
2. The inability to eliminate it through refutation by examining whether or not (conventional phenomena) can be established by valid cognition
3. The inability to eliminate through refutation by examining whether the (conventional phenomena) are produced in the way of any of the four possibilities or not
4. Showing that the refutation of all four alternatives, such as whether things exist or not, will not be able to eliminate (the existence of conventional phenomena)

1. The inability to eliminate it through refutation by examining whether or not (conventional phenomena) endure rational analysis

Analysing whether or not phenomena, such as a form, are existent in reality or whether they are produced or not is the reasoning that analyses reality or the reasoning that analyses the ultimate state of being. It is true since we do not accept that the production of form and so on can endure this analysis. The consequence of fallacy (of asserting true existence) will not befall us.

Especially, we must thoroughly differentiate between: not being able to endure analysis by reasoning and being harmed by reasoning; not seeing cessation and production with the exalted wisdom of the meditative equipoise of aryas and seeing cessation and production to be nonexistent by that wisdom; not finding cessation and production with the reasoning consciousness that analyses the existence and nonexistence of nature and finding the cessation and production to be nonexistent.

2. The inability to eliminate it through refutation by examining whether or not (conventional phenomena) can be established by valid cognition

It is not that (the middle way) accepts phenomena like form and so forth because they are not established by a valid cognition, for they are established by valid cognition. Then one may wonder how the statement, "The world is not valid in anyway"[56], can be correct. This is the refutation of worldly consciousness, such as the eye, being valid to apprehend suchness. It does not refute the validity of these consciousnesses to apprehend every

56 In Chandrakirti's *'Entering the Middle Way,'* which is his commentary on Nagarjuna's *'The Fundamental Treatise on the Middle Way.'*

phenomenon. Therefore, only the consciousnesses of superior beings are valid to directly realize suchness.

3. The inability to eliminate through refutation by examining whether the (conventional phenomena) are produced in the way of any of the four possibilities or not

Since acceptance of ultimate production means acceptance of the object withstanding analysis by reasoning that examines suchness, the fallacy of not refuting ultimate production will not befall us when we refute production in any of the four ways. At that point, we should analyse in which of the four ways: self, others, and so forth is it produced. Acceptance of mere production does not mean acceptance of real production (intrinsic production). Therefore, how can we examine production from self, others, and so forth with the reasoning that analyses suchness? For, we do not have to accept that production withstands reasoning.

4. Showing that the refutation of all four alternatives, such as whether things exist or not, will not be able to eliminate (the existence of conventional phenomena)

Since the treatises of the Middle Way refute four alternatives: existence; nonexistence; both existence and nonexistence; as well as neither existence nor nonexistence of 'things' or 'nature'. One might think that since there is no phenomenon that is not included in this, everything is refuted by the reasoning. But as explained before, there are two meanings to ''things''. Of these, things established by way of their own entity are refuted within both of the two truths, while functional things are not refuted conventionally.

B. Refuting systems with restrictive identification of the object to be negated

Some say that the object of negation is nature, which has three characteristics. The three characteristics are; its entity is not produced by cause and condition, it does not change into other states, and it is posited without depending on any other phenomena. Generally, if a proponent asserts the establishment of the nature of internal and external phenomena, such as sprouts, in this way, the Middle Way must definitely refute it. However, here, identification of the object of negation is the 'fundamental object of negation,' refuting which is the arousal of the view of the Middle Way within one's continuum, that is, the 'realisation of the lack of existence of phenomena by their nature'. Since fellow Buddhist schools have already established that compounded phenomena are produced by causes and conditions and that they change their state, in your case there will be faults, such as not needing to establish the nonexistence of phenomena by their own entity.

III. Identifying the object of negation as per our system

This has three sections:

A. The actual Identification of the object to be negated
B. Whether this attribute[57] of the object to be negated should be applied to other objects of negation or not
C. Whether the attribute 'ultimate' has to be added to the object of negation or not

57 'Nature established by the way of its own entity'

A. The actual Identification of the object to be negated

There are two objects to be negated: misconception and the existence of nature that is apprehended by that misconception. However, the principal object of negation is the latter. To eliminate the misconception that is the subject, we must first negate the object it apprehends. Therefore, that which is not posited by way of inner consciousness but established on the object by its own entity is called the self or nature.

B. Whether this attribute of the object to be negated should be added to other objects of negation or not

Even in the cases where the Middle Way has to refute the non-acceptance of phenomena being established nominally by the unique assertion fabricated by the Buddhist and non-Buddhist essentialists, the attribute 'nature established by the way of its own entity' should not be added except at times when we have to take into account their perspective. That is because these tenets already accept the (essential) existence of those objects. Other than these, we should apply this attribute to every other instance of refutation of the phenomena that are presented by the Middle Way as having conventional existence. If we do not, then the reasoning of the one who refutes will also have the same fault, and it will be a pseudo-refutation. Therefore, it must be added.

C. Whether the attribute 'ultimate' has to be added to the object of refutation or not

It is utterly wrong to state that only the system of Middle Way Autonomy distinguishes their object of negation with the attribute 'ultimate'. Because if one vehemently refuses to accept that in this system (Consequentialist) also the attribute 'ultimate'

is added to the object of negation, then the distinction of the two truths with the statement 'ultimately, it is this and this and conventionally, it is this and this.' would not apply. Such Middle Way is never spoken of anywhere. The refutation of the use of 'ultimate' in the *Clear Words* to the object of negation aims to refute 'self-production,' not 'mere production.'

Q.2 Whether to refute the object to be negated with the Middle Way Consequentialist System or the Middle Autonomy System

There are two parts to this:

R.1 Identifying the definition of the Middle Way Consequentialist and Middle Way Autonomy

R.2 Which of the Middle Way systems should one follow to cultivate the view within oneself

R.1 Identifying the definition of the Middle Way Consequentialist and Middle Way Autonomy

This has two parts:

I. Refuting other views
II. Positing our own view

I. Refuting other views

A. Stating what they believe
B. Refuting those beliefs

A. Stating what they believe

There are four views:

i. The view of Jayananda[58]

If an argument is established through the three modes of syllogism by valid cognition, then it accepts the three modes as per Autonomy. And if it is established just with the ultimate assertion, that appears to be the Consequentialist.

ii. Some translator disciples of this pundit (Jayananda)

Though they do not have their own stance, they simply refute the views of others. Also, they have assertions, but they do not have a thesis. Having no stance of their own means not positing a thesis such as 'lack of nature' when analysing ultimate truth and not refuting the nonexistence of all assertions. Therefore, Autonomous are those who, while analysing the ultimate truth, accept the probandum 'lack of nature' and assert that as their own system. Those who do not accept this but rather merely refute other's claims appear to be Consequentialists.

iii. The view of those who consider themselves contemporary Middle Way Consequentialists

They say that there is no assertion of any sort, even conventionally, with regard to ultimate or conventionality in the Consequentialist's own system. If there is such a thesis, then one has to accept the examples and reasons that establish it. In that case, one will become Autonomous.

iv. The view of a group of Tibetan scholars following Master Chandrakirti

They say that, refuting both direct and inferential valid cognition

58 Jayananda was a Kashmir Pundit who wrote the commentarial explanation of the *Entering the Middle Way*/ Madhyamakavatara by Master Chandrakirti.

based on real fact[59] by those who accept the presentation of objects of knowledge and valid cognition in terms of own-characteristics analysed thoroughly by reasoning, they accept the conventionally unanalyzed valid cognition and object of knowledge that is commonly known in the world. Then the Middle Way followers themselves put forward a statement of proof to the opponent with a correct reason to prove lack of true existence. However, that does not make them adherents of the Autonomy school, as they posit arguments based on unanalyzed conventional reasoning that are familiar to the world.

B. Refuting those beliefs:

There are four views to refute:

i. Refuting the first view:

In the system of Consequentialism, if the argument with three modes of reasoning is not established by valid cognition but merely by the acceptance of the argument by the respondent and opponent, it will not refute the opponent as their acceptance means that subject is established. Moreover, both sides do not have valid cognition. However, if you differentiate the types of acceptance and say that such an acceptance will and such an acceptance will not establish it; that too by reason of having accepted the argument, will be similar to the assertion to be established. If one differentiates by whether there is valid cognition or not, then the view of (Consequentialists) having accepted that there is no valid cognition will fail.

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59 *The Collections of Madhyamaka Arguments* is a list of texts, usually by Nagarjuna GTSPE Vol. 3 p

ii. Refuting the second view:

When one analyses suchness, is the non-acceptance of the thesis 'lack of nature' based on the fact that it is not established by reasoning consciousness, or is it because one is analysing suchness? As for the first, if 'lack of nature' could not be established by reasoning consciousness, then acceptance of the existence of nature should not be able to be refuted by reasoning consciousness either. The second would also be incorrect; if one does not accept that there is an occasion for analysis of suchness, there should not be a time for analysis by the reasoning of the Middle Way. But if you do accept, then since one certainly should accept an analyzer and analysing logic and such, it is not necessary that everything established at that point of analysis to be ultimately established.

iii. Refuting the third view:

Saying that the Middle Way does not have a thesis even conventionally is caused by not being able to properly identify the object of negation, as explained before. Therefore, when applying reasons that refute nature to oppose others, one sees that the logic applies similarly to your own stance. Hence, without knowing how to eliminate the errors that strike one's own system, the existence and nonexistence of the entire interdependent phenomena of the cycle of existence and beyond becomes akin to that of Shiva[60].

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60 End up having an ontological status like that of non-Buddhists' fabrications such as a divine creator. (GTSPE Vol.3 p236)

iv. Refuting the fourth view:

This view accepts the conventional existence of 'own-characteristic', but seems to refute it as conventionally able to be analysed by reasoning, which is incorrect. Moreover, when debating with essentialist opponents, it would be wrong for the proponents of the Middle Way to claim that in the system of Chandrakirti, there are three modes of reasoning common to both sides. Such a case is specifically refuted in the *Clear Words*, and if such a position is accepted, then even without the use of the term 'based on the reason of sheer fact', it is indisputably an Autonomous reason.

II. Positing our own view

This has two parts:

A. The actual negation of the Middle Way Autonomy[61] view
B. How is it different in our own system

A. The actual negation of the Middle Way Autonomy view

There are two sections to this:

i. The fault of not establishing the subject basis
ii. Showing that because of that fault, the reason is also not established

i. The fault of not establishing the subject basis

This has two parts:

a. Presenting what they believe
b. Refuting that belief

61 Svatantrika Madhyamika (Skt.)

a. Presenting what they believe[62]

They state that to put the thesis 'sound is impermanent' to the Particularist[63], if the Buddhist posits 'sound arisen from elements' as the subject, it will not be established for the Particularist. And if 'sound of spatial quality' is posited as the subject, it will not be established for us. Therefore, one cannot take one's own unique view as the subject. The subject is the common basis to be analysed by both the proponent and the opponent, and they must establish a commonly appearing subject. Similar to this example, when the Middle Way establishes form-sense sphere as not produced from itself to non-Buddhist, positing 'real form sense sphere' as the subject will be established in our own system, and if the 'the unreal form sense sphere' is posited as the subject, it will not be established for the other. So, by eliminating the attributes, merely 'form sense sphere' should be posited as the subject. Also, the commonly appearing subject posited by the proponent means something that should be established by the similar valid cognition of the opponent.

b. Refuting that belief

There are two parts to this:

1. Incorrectness of the meaning
2. Incoherence of the example

1. Incorrectness of the meaning

If the proponent of the nonexistence of nature posits the syllogism "form sense-sphere is not produced by its nature; for it exists;

62 Bhavavivika (GTSPE Eng Vol.3 p252)

63 Differentialist/Vaisheshika; one of the six fundamental Hindu philosophical schools.

example, reflection," To the opponent who asserts the existence of nature, the way establishment of the subject 'form sense-sphere' in the system of the opponent is that it has to exist for the direct eye perception apprehending it. If they do not establish that without mistake, then it would not be suitable for the direct perception that establishes it. Therefore, it has to be non-mistaken. To be established as not mistaken non-conceptually is to apprehend the inherent establishment of that which is not mistaken and have to certainly rely on its existence in the way it appears. According to this, the kind of valid cognition with which the subject is established for the opponent is not suitable for the proponent. To them, no phenomenon even conventionally has an entity that is established by its inherent nature, and therefore, there is no valid cognition that establishes it.

2. Incoherence of the example

Without specifying either the 'sound produced from the element' or 'the sound of spatial quality', it is admissible for both sides to ascertain the 'existence of sound'. There is no generality of form sense-sphere that is established by a valid cognition that is neither established by non-mistaken nor by mistaken consciousness in the systems of both proponents of lack of nature and non-lack of nature. Establishment with mistaken consciousness is not established for the opponent, while discovering with non-mistaken consciousness is not established by the valid cognition of the proponent. Therefore, there is no coherence with the example.

ii. Showing that because of that fault, the reason is also not established

It is stated[64] that the same procedure of showing the fault of not establishing the basis should be applied to show the defect that the reason.' for it exists,' is also not established.

B. How is it different[65] in our own system

If one wonders whether reckoning the fault of the subject and reason being not established in the argument of other schools will similarly affect one's own argument and that one should not challenge others, we should know that the reason other systems face the contradiction is due to their acceptance of the Autonomous argument. It is stated[66] that our system does not accept the Autonomous argument, and therefore, the fault does not arise. Here, 'argument' refers to the syllogisms.

R.2 Which of the Middle Way systems should one follow to cultivate the view within oneself

The great scholars of Middle Way School who followed the superior father, the great Nagarjuna, and his superior spiritual son Aryadeva separated into two schools of thought: Consequentialist and Autonomous. If we wonder which of these two should one follow? Here we are following the Middle Way Consequentialist. Therefore, we need to be certain of two things: to refute the conventional existence of nature established by its own entity and to be able to refute that, the perfect possibility

64 Chandrakirti's *Clear Words:* Commentary on Nagarjuna's *"Fundamental Treatise on the Middle Way"*/Mulamadhyamakakarikas

65 Why the faults one find in Middle Way Autonomy arguments do not apply to the consequentialist.

66 Chandrakirti's *Clear Words*

of the existence of everything worldly and beyond within that reality.

Q.3 How to cultivate the right view with that system

This has three parts:

R.1 Establishing the selflessness of the person
R.2 Establishing the selflessness of phenomena
R.3 How to eliminate obscurations through familiarisation with these views

R.1 Establishing the selflessness of the person

This has three sections:

I. Actual establishing of the lack of nature of the self
II. Showing how that establishes the lack of nature of what pertains to that self
III. How the same reasoning is applied to other objects

I. Actual establishing of the lack of nature of the self

This has two parts:

A. Presenting the example
B. Relating it to the meaning

A. Presenting the example

This has four sections:

i. Showing that the chariot exists imputedly without nature
ii. Dispelling disagreement
iii. Showing how it is established under various names

iv. The benefit of gaining realisation quickly through that

i. Showing that chariot exists imputedly without nature[67]

Just as a chariot does not exist in any of the seven modes, such as; one with its part, different from its part, etc., but as mere imputation, the self and the aggregates are said[68] to be similar. If a chariot has nature established by the way of its own entity, then it has to be certainly established by the reason analysing the existence of nature in any of the seven modes, such as one with its part, different from its part, etc. Since the analysis does not establish it in any of the seven ways, therefore, there is no nature.

ii. Dispelling disagreement

It does not matter if the essentialist says that– if the reasoning that analyses whether or not natures exist through the seven modes does not find it, the chariot must be nonexistent. In that case, any form of imputation of the term – the convention of - a chariot in the world will not stand,–because not finding of the chariot in any of the seven mode of existence when looked for with the reasoning that searches for whether or not natures exist is the case in both truths. Therefore, how could not finding it in any of the seven ways through that reasoning process possibly refute the existence of the chariot? However, accepting the existence of the chariot is not established by reason analysing whether or not natures exist; instead by abandoning the analysis with the reasoning, it is established by the 'worldly', which is

67 I.e established from its own entity. (GTSPE use the term 'intrinsic existence' to refer to 'rang bzhin' in Tibetan)

68 Chandrakirti's *Commentary on the Middle Way* (GTSPE Eng Vol.3 p278)

an unimpaired mere conventional consciousness. Therefore, the way to posit it (chariot) is that it is established as existing imputedly, designated in dependence upon its parts.

iii. Showing how it is (chariot) established under various names

In our system, it is clearly established that the term 'chariot' is imputed based only on worldly convention. Moreover, whatever various names it is known by should also be accepted based on worldly convention without analysis. That is, chariot is established to refer to terms like 'parts possessor', or 'component possessor,' independence upon its parts and components such as the wheel.

iv. The benefit of gaining realisation quickly through that (example)

The *Commentary on Entering the Middle Way* states: "The worldly conventions will not exist if they are analysed. Since things exist conventionally without analysis, practitioners go through this order of analysis, and only then do they accomplish the quickest realisation of the depth of suchness."

B. Relating it to the meaning

There are two sections to this:

i. Relating the lack of nature to the meaning[69]
ii. Relating establishment under various names to the meaning

69 The example shows how the person lacks nature.

i. Relating the lack of nature to the meaning

This has four parts:

a. Refuting the position of the oneness of self and aggregate
b. Refuting the position of the separateness of self and aggregate
c. How this refutes the remaining positions
d. How the person appears like an illusion based on that refutation

a. Refuting the position of the oneness of self and aggregate

If one wonders what defect there could be if the self and the aggregate are established as one by nature, then three flaws are explained[70]: the meaninglessness of speaking of a 'self,' the existence of multiple selves, and the 'self' becoming an object of production and disintegration [71].

b. Refuting the position of the separateness of self and aggregate

If the self exists separate from aggregates as an entity by its own nature, then it would not have the characteristics of the aggregate as that which is producing, abiding, and disintegrating. Like a horse being established as different from an ox, it would not have the characteristics of an ox[72].

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70 Buddhapalita (GTSPE Eng.Vol.3 p290)

71 Production and disintegration by its own nature or intrinsic production and disintegration.

72 Conventionally though it should have.

c. How this refutes the remaining positions

If self and aggregate are separate by nature, then, like curd in a vessel, self will be dependent on the aggregates and aggregates on the self, and there will be a side of a dependent and dependency. But since they are not different by their nature, they do not exist as dependent and dependency[73], as explained before in the case of the chariot.

d. How the person appears like an illusion based on that

If, for example, our eye consciousness saw an illusory horse and an illusory ox and then saw that they were not there as they appeared to be, we would feel certain that they were false. Similarly, when a person is seen as conventionally real to the conventional consciousness, the reasoning consciousness sees them as empty of a nature established by its own entity. Based on these consciousnesses, we can ascertain that the person is illusion or false appearance.

ii. Relating establishment under various names to the meaning

The term chariot is imputed in dependence upon the parts, such as wheels and so on; the parts are the 'appropriation' or the 'appropriated,' and the chariot is the 'agent' or the 'appropriator'. Similarly, when the self is imputed depending on the five aggregates, the six elements, and the six sense-spheres, it is the ' appropriator'. Likewise, as the self acts as the appropriator of the aggregate, it is the 'agent,' and the aggregate and such are the 'objects' as it appropriates them.

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73 In that mode which will entail an inherent dependency and dependent.

II. Showing how that refutes what the self owns

When we search with the reason that analyses the existence of the nature of the self, finding none in any of the seven modes, the existence of the nature of the self is thus negated. How can reason then find 'the eye that belongs to the self,' etc.? Therefore, what pertains to the self also lacks nature. Practitioners can be liberated from the cycle of existence when they cease to see any nature in the self and what the self owns.

III. How the same reasoning is applied to other objects

Just as the analysis of the self and aggregates is similar to the analysis of a chariot, we should realise that things like pots and cloth are also the same. When we analyse with the reasoning consciousness to find the existence or nonexistence of the nature of an object like a pot, examining whether they are found in any of the seven modes—such as one with their form or different from their form, etc.—nothing will be found that accords with either of the two truths, for they are posited only in the conventional consciousness that does not analyse.

R.2 Establishing the selflessness of phenomena

The five aggregates, the six elements, and the six sense spheres—such as eye consciousness—are the basis upon which the self is imputed. They are phenomena. The selflessness of phenomena is the ascertaining of phenomena lacking nature established by the way of their own entity. There are numerous ways to establish this. However, the establishment of phenomena lacking nature through refutation of the four possible ways of production in the '*Entering the Middle Way*' is said to be the selflessness of phenomena in its *Commentary*.

R.3 How to eliminate obscurations through familiarisation with these views

With the realisation of the lack of even a minute particle of the nature of the self and what pertains to that self, one becomes familiar with that understanding and eliminates the reifying view of the transitory collection of the self and what pertains to that self. When that is eliminated, the four types of grasping explained earlier, such as grasping for what you want, etc., will cease, and without them, there will no longer be existence conditioned by grasping, which then leads to the end of transmigration with the aggregate conditioned by existence. This way, we obtain liberation.

N.2 Types of special-insight

The entire types of special-insights to meditate on the ordinary path are the ones with four aspects, three aspects, and six aspects.

A special-insight with four aspects is the differentiation of all conventional phenomena and the complete differentiation of the ultimate nature of phenomena, each further separated into thorough examination and thorough analysis.

A special-insight with three aspects is that which arises from characteristics; that which arises from thorough searching; and that which arises from individual analysis. The first is focusing on something, such as the meaning of selflessness, and then engaging the mind in its characteristics; the second is establishing what is not certain; and the third is the continued analysis of what has been ascertained.

A special-insight with six aspects is the observation of the six bases. It is a process of analysis based on thorough investigative

insight. The six bases are meaning, things, characteristics, orientation, time, and reason, which are to be individually analysed.

N.3 How to cultivate special-insight

This has two parts:

O.1 Refuting other systems
O.2 Presenting our own system

O.1 Refuting other systems

There are four refutations to make:

I. Refuting the first of the other systems

Some say, "Even without having found any view of understanding selflessness, if the mind is kept clear of any conception, it will gain understanding of the reality; since the reality, emptiness, cannot be identified in terms of what is and what is not,[74] the mind in that position perfectly abides in line with the way reality is." This is not correct. To accept that the person, even without having understood emptiness, keeping his mind in that manner is concord with it as meditation on emptiness is preposterous, for nowhere is it held that any of the sensory consciousnesses think, 'This is this, this is not this.'

74 Setting the mind in that way brings it into accordance with the way that things exist. For, with no object existing at all in the face of emptiness, the mind does not apprehend anything. (GTSPE Eng. Vol.3 p331)

II. Refuting the second of the other systems

Some say, "We too accept that it is wrong to hold that without having any understanding of selflessness, keeping the mind merely clear of conception is meditation on emptiness. However, if the person finds the definitive meaning of the view of selflessness, any subsequent state of mind free of conceptual thought would become the cultivation of emptiness." This, too, is wrong. A person gains a definitive understanding of the view, and if any non-conceptual meditation he engages in becomes a cultivation of meanings established by the definitive meaning, then the meditation on the mind of enlightenment by such a person also has to be a meditation on the view of the definitive meaning.

III. Refuting the third of the other systems

Some say, "We neither accept the first, that is, non-conceptual abiding without finding the view as meditation on emptiness, nor do we accept the subsequent non-conceptual abiding after finding the view as meditation on emptiness. However, alternatively, if we engage our mind without any conceptual thought preceded by analysis with wisdom of individual investigation once, then later, any engagement in non-conceptuality would become meditation on the meaning of emptiness." This is also incorrect, as it implies that if we were to engage in one time analysis of the view right before we fall into a deep sleep, the non-conceptual state following thereafter would be meditation on emptiness, which is extremely absurd.

IV. Refuting the fourth of the other systems

Some say, "While we do not accept the first three systems, the correct way of meditation on emptiness is the one where we have gained certainty of emptiness. Then, without any other analysis, we have to concentrate on the meaning of emptiness. This is the correct way to meditate on emptiness, as there would not be the faults of the first system—where there is a lack of orientation towards emptiness. Also, that of the second system—where one does not think of the view of emptiness when abiding in non-conceptual thought, and similarly of the third system—where even with prior investigation of the view, afterward it remains a conceptual thought that does not concentrate on the view of emptiness." According to this view, 'analysis of the view' refers to simply remembering the view and engaging only in meditative stabilisation on the view, which they posit to be the meditation on emptiness. This is not right; for it will merely obtain the calm-abiding mind that engage in meditative stabilisation on emptiness, lacking the process of special-insight maintaining analytical meditation. Thus, this is a one-sided practice lacking the union of calm-abiding and special-insight.

O.2 Presenting our own system

This has three parts:

I. Why both stabilised and analytical meditations are necessary
II. Eliminating objection
III. A brief explanation of how to sustain the practice

I. Why both stabilised and analytical meditations are necessary

Without absolute certainty of the meaning of the view of selflessness, we will not be able to gain realisation of special-insight. How do we cultivate special-insight with that view? First, to attain certainty about the view, we need to analyse it using various possibilities of logical and scriptural reference, and after getting certainty[75], we need to repeatedly analyse it using the wisdom of individual analysis. Otherwise, only stabilised meditation will not generate insight. After achieving a calm-abiding mind, to meditate, we need to sustain it with analysis. In this way, with the cultivation of pliancy generated by the power of analysis, we have obtained special-insight. Then, we need to sustain the calm-abiding mind that achieved stability as well as engage in analysis. That is why we need both. Here, meditative stabilisation is applied to the final object, upon which thorough analysis is performed using special-insight. Accordingly, the cooperation of special-insight and calm-abiding aimed at selflessness is achieved.

II. Eliminating objection

With regard to the qualm that it is contradictory to have non-conceptual exalted wisdom arising from the individual analysis of selflessness—a conceptual thought—for there should be a concordance between the cause and the effect, the Buddha said, "For example, two trees rubbed against each other will bring a fire that will burn both of them. In the same way, the correct individual analysis will generate the power of the exalted wisdom of noble beings, the generation of which will burn the

75 That there is not even a particle of true existence in anything or non-thing whatsoever. (GTSPE Eng. Vol.3 p344)

correct individual analysis." Thus, he said that from the correct individual analysis arises the supreme wisdom.

III. A summary of how to sustain the practice

As mentioned before, when we find the view of the definitive meaning, we have established that the self or what the self owns—which are the basis of 'I' and 'mine'—lacks nature. We should continue with this analysis for length with the wisdom of individual analysis and finally draw force of certainty in its meaning with meditative stabilisation that retains concentration, alternating with the analysis of the wisdom of individual discrimination. The procedures regarding what to do in the preliminaries, in between, and at the conclusion of the session are similar to those of the practices of the stages of path shared with persons of small scope.

N.4 The measure of achieving special-insight

When one engages in meditation with the wisdom of individual discrimination, until we achieve the pliancy that has been mentioned earlier, we have just cultivated a proximate special-insight. After that, if the power of individual analysis itself engenders 'pliancy', then it transforms into 'special-insight'. This is similar in the case of special-insight aimed at both phenomena in their entirety and their ultimate nature.

M.3 How the two are brought together

Without obtaining calm-abiding and special-insight, there is nothing to unite, so it is necessary to achieve both. The union of the two is achieved when we cultivate special-insight for the first time. Before obtaining special-insight, we must make an effort

to cultivate meditative stabilisation and analytical meditation individually. On obtaining these, we can generate calm-abiding with the analytical meditation of individual discrimination itself. Thus, they are combined.

A general summary of the stages of the path

Since the root of the path is relying on the teacher, take this to heart and then generate a genuine desire to acquire the essence of an opportune rebirth. This will motivate us from within to practise regularly. To acquire this desire, contemplate the leisure and endowments. Without loathing the persuasion of matters of the present life, we will not develop a fierce zest to pursue the happiness of future lives. Therefore, make an effort to contemplate the fact that any rebirth will not last long due to the impermanent nature of life and, after death, how we will wander in lower realms. This will cultivate a genuine fear of such horror.

After this, we should develop pure admiration for the qualities of the three refuges, abide by the common refuge-taking vows, and practise the precepts. Then, by generating faith in the law of causality from every aspect—for it is the great basis of all virtue—and making it firm, we should constantly engage in the adoption of the ten virtues and abandonment of the ten non-virtues and continuously follow the path of the four powers.[76]

Then, contemplate the defects of the general and particular sufferings of cyclic existence and try to be repelled by the general cycle of existence as much as we can. Then, by identifying the nature of the causes of cyclic existence—the actions and afflictions—we should cultivate a genuine desire to eliminate them. We should gain certainty in the three trainings, the path

76 Refer to I.3.II (of E.1):The Four Remedial Powers which are different from the Four Powers as mentioned in G.1.III (of E.3)

that will liberate us from cyclic existence, and, in particular, maintain the individual vows of liberation we have taken.

Then, with the thought that, like us, all mother-sentient-beings have also fallen into the ocean of cyclic existence, we should try our best to generate the mind of enlightenment that is rooted in compassion and kindness. Taking the vows of the *bodhisattva*, we should train in the six perfections to perfect our mental continuum and the four ways of attracting disciples to mature others.

H.2 Training in the diamond vehicle in particular

After training in the common practices for both the *sutra* and *mantra* vehicles, if we are to enter the secret-*mantra* vehicle, first our own mental continuum should be matured by the maturing empowerment received in accordance with the original tantric texts. We should listen to and learn the vows and precepts given at that time and uphold them. As the highest y*oga-tantra* states, "one who does not adhere to the precepts, has received inferior empowerment, or does not know the suchness will never accomplish any cultivation." Thus, with observation of the vows and precepts for the path of *mantrayana*, one should first meditate on the generation stage in its complete wheel of deities as outlined in the original tantric texts. Ordinary conceptions is abandoned in this process. Since the generation stage itself will abandon these, we must make effort in meditating on it, as we visualise special abodes, bodies, possessions, and activities. Then, in the 'completion stage', we need to follow the steps as laid out in the original tantric texts. This way, we must mark the order of two stages of the complete body of the path of the highest *yoga-tantra*.

I have hereby finished explaining how to practise the essence of the last two perfections—calm-abiding and special-insight—and, in particular, briefly about how to practise the diamond vehicle, with this text, *The Essence of the Stages of the Path*: Lamp Illuminating the Essential Instructions of the Stages of the Path of the Persons of the Great Scope Based on the Outlines of The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment.

Supplementary End Notes

i. The twenty-six are enumerated in Guṇaprabha's *Sutra on the Discipline as:* While standing, do not explain the teachings to one who is seated; while seated, do not explain the teachings to one who is lying down; while you are seated on a low seat, do not explain the teachings to someone on a high seat. lt is the same also with regard to bad and good seats. Do not explain them to someone walking in front while you walk behind. Do not explain them to someone walking on the path while you walk on the edge. Do not explain them to someone whose head is covered or whose upper or lower robe is pulled up, whose upper robe is folded and placed on the shoulder, or whose arms are crossed in front with the hands on the shoulders, or whose hands are clasped behind the neck. Do not explain them to someone with a topknot, wearing a hat, wearing a tiara, or whose head is wrapped in cloth. Do not explain the teachings to someone riding an elephant or a horse, to someone sitting in a sedan chair or carriage, or to someone wearing shoes or boots. Do not explain them to someone holding a staff, an umbrella, a spear, a sword, or other arms, or to someone wearing armor.

ii. In Buddhist cosmology there are four large continents, each of which has two smaller continents next to it: In the center, is the monarch of mountains meru. The four continents and eight smaller continents are (1) Purvavideha, the eastern continent "land of [those with] superior/large bodies" (2) Jambudvipa, the southern continent "Jambu-tree land"; (3) Godaniya the western

continent "land of using cattle" (4) Uttarakuru; northern continent "land of unpleasant sound" Surrounding all of these is an outer rim of iron mountains.

iii. Refer above (end note ii)

iv. Four sources of birth According to Buddhism:

In traditional Buddhist thought, there are four forms of birth:

1. Birth from an egg—like a bird, fish, or reptile
2. Birth from a womb—like most mammals and some worldly gods
3. Birth from moisture—probably referring to the appearance of animals whose eggs are microscopic, like maggots appearing in rotting flesh;
4. Birth by transformation—miraculous materialisation, as with most gods

v. The eleven types of living beings are:

(1) those who need help; (2) those who are confused as to the proper method; (3) those who have given help; (4) those afflicted by fear; (5) those afflicted with sorrow; (6) those poor in goods; (7) those who want a dwelling; (8) those who want mental harmony; (9) those who proceed correctly; (10) those who proceed wrongly; and (11) those who need to be disciplined by supernormal powers.

vi. The Eight-fold posture: (1) Cross your legs in the manner of the venerable Vairocana, using either the full-lotus posture or the half-lotus posture as appropriate. (2) Your eyes should be neither wide open nor too far closed,

and they should be fixed on the tip of your nose. (3) Sit with your awareness directed inward, keeping your body straight without leaning too far back or being bent too far forward. (4) Keep your shoulders straight and even. (5) Do not raise or lower your head nor turn it to one side; set it so that your nose and navel are aligned. (6) Set your teeth and lips in their usual, natural positions. (7) Draw your tongue up close to your upper teeth. (8) Your inhalation and exhalation should not be noisy, forced, or uneven; let it flow effortlessly, ever so gently, without any sense that you are moving it here or there.

vii. The two types of images (*discursive* and *non-discursive)* are posited in terms of the observer: the first is the object of insight, and the second is the object of meditative serenity. The image is not the actual specifically characterized object upon which your mind is focused, but rather the appearance of that object's aspect to your mind. When you carry out analysis while observing an object, then the image is discursive since analytical thinking is present. When you stabilize your mind without analysis while observing an object, the image is said to be non-discursive since analytical thinking is absent. As for these images, what objects of meditation are they images of? They are the images, or aspects, of the five objects of meditation for purifying behavior, the five objects of meditation for expertise, and the two objects of meditation for purifying afflictions.(GTSPE Vol.3 p35)

viii. The limits of existence are posited with reference to the observed object. There are two: The limits of existence for the diversity of phenomena, which are expressed in

the statement, "Just this is all there is; there is nothing more"; and the limits of existence for the real nature, expressed in the statement, "This alone is how things exist; they do not exist in any other way." In the case of the diversity of phenomena, this means that the five aggregates include all composite phenomena; the eighteen constituents and twelve sources include all phenomena; and the four truths include everything there is to know; there is nothing else beyond this. In the case of the nature, this means that reason establishes the truth or reality of those objects of meditation. *Achievement of purpose* is posited in terms of the result. With either serenity or insight you direct your attention to the images of those objects of meditation. Then you stabilize on them, become accustomed to them, and, by virtue of repeated practice, you become free from your dysfunctional tendencies, undergoing a fundamental transformation.(GTSPE Vol.3 pa36)

ix. Refuting systems with overly broad identification of the object to be negated

This refers to most of the Tibetan Middle Way view holders of the time of Je Tsongkhapa. They were said to be the followers of the earlier great masters, such as Ngoglo Lodhen Sherab and his spiritual son and, Thangsakpa. Master Ngoglo the Great, Chapachoeseng and Kunkhen Rongton held the Middle Way Autonomous view, while Bodhong Chokley Namgyal held Master Chandrakirti's view.

x. Refuting systems with restrictive identification of the object to be negated: Those were some early Tibetans

who accepted the three natures of emptiness mentioned in the fifteenth chapter of the Fundamental Treatise on the Middle Way as the ultimate object of negation. The three natures are the characteristics of emptiness. Therefore, one has to accept emptiness to be these and thus should not be negated upon emptiness. If the three natures are established upon conventional phenomena, then that would need negation. However, that would not be the ultimate object of negation. Because negation of the three natures upon the conventional phenomena will not generate the view of the lack of nature, as even the Great Expositionist and the Sutra Followers of our Buddhist system have already established the fact that these three natures were not found in the compounded phenomena.